

CORSAIR

A TABLETOP ROLEPLAYING GAME

PREAMBLE: A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Funnily enough, my first tabletop roleplaying game wasn't Dungeons & Dragons. It was some obscure hungarian game called M.A.G.U.S., which if anything, helped me get a feel what I don't want from a roleplaying game. My second, and the first one I learned to run as a GM was Shadowrun. You might be able to spot a few influences here and there. I thoroughly fell in love with the setting but the rules were a bit too crunchy for my taste. That's when I started to experiment with rulesets. I probably tried to hack Shadowrun to be more friendly at least three separate times if not more.

Along the lines I discovered other games, systems, and game designers, each bringing something new to the table, but my other big muse was Blades in the Dark. John Harper's brilliant work was exactly on the opposite end of the spectrum when it came to complexity. You could create a character in less than fifteen minutes if you wanted to, and both you and your group had a clear identity and goal you were working toward. I still hope one day I get to be a player and not a game master in a Forged in the Dark game. That said...

I still found myself tinkering with the rules, trying to make them more complex this time around. I realised what I really wanted was somewhere in the middle. Something that could elegantly handle all the curveballs that players could throw at it with relatively simple mechanics. And somewhere along the line I ended up thinking, "what if I tried my hand at making my own system from scratch?" This is the result of that thought.

But this is the furthest I can go on without admitting how I'm standing on the shoulders of giants. I've already mentioned Shadowrun, and Blades in the Dark, but Dungeons and Dragons, Daggerheart, the Star Wars TTRPGs by Fantasy Flight Games were all crucial inputs to the final mechanics.

As far as the setting goes, where to even begin? I loved Destiny, Horizon Zero Dawn, Mass Effect, Guardians of the Galaxy, The Expanse and many more. I knew there were many other sci-fi settings out there, but I was really hoping that this specific idea of blending space fantasy with hard sci-fi would be original enough to stand out.

That said, it would have amounted to nothing if I didn't have help. From Large Language models too, putting so much words to, well, not paper but disk, but also, those people that listened to my pitches, rants, and ramblings, and gave me feedback along the way. Who were kind enough to sit down and play this with me when it was even bigger of a mess than it is now. I know most of you never expected yourself to appear in any sort of credits, but I hope this brings you some joy, or at least a good chuckle.

Special thanks to: Fábián János, Bangó Dávid

And an even bigger thanks to my wife and love of my life, **Farkas Ágnes**. I borrowed your ear more times than I can count, and you played a bigger role in making this a reality than anyone else.

Author & Lead Designer: Péter Csiszár
Version: 0.0.1

License: *Corsair* is published under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0 International License (CC BY-NC 4.0). © Péter Csiszár. You are free to share and adapt this material for non-commercial purposes with appropriate attribution.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

ACT 0: SYSTEM INTRODUCTION PAGE 1

Chapter 00: Front Matter & Overview 1

Who Are the Corsairs? 1

What is a Roleplaying Game? 2

What You'll Need to Play 2

Reader's Guide: How to Use This Book 3

ACT I: CORE RULES & ENGINE PAGE 7

Chapter 01: Core Mechanics & Resolution 7

Attributes & Attribute Pairs 8

Simple, Success & Complex Tests 10

Upgrades, Downgrades & Gambits 13

Scenes, Pacing & Action Points 15

Effects & Tactical Triggers 17

Interlude: 27th Hour 23

ACT II: CHARACTERS & CHASSIS PAGE 25

Chapter 02: Character Creation 25

Traits & Lineages Catalog 31

Advancement & Career Milestones 35

Chapter 03: Classes & The MANTLE System 39

The Five Chassis: Conduit, Hazard, Pilot, Vanguard, Weaver 41

Interlude: Post-War Headaches 79

ACT III: OPERATIONS & HARDWARE PAGE 81

Tactical Combat & Dynamic Cover 81

Chapter 04: The Armory & Equipment 87

Firearms, Melee, Armor & Exotic Hardware 91

Chapter 05: Starships & Naval Operations 101

The 24-Hour Downtime Cycle & Gigs 115

Interlude: Great Tithe 121

ACT IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE PAGE 125

Chapter 07: Worlds of the Sphere 125

Planetary Gazetteer & Clusters 127

Sovereign Powers, Corps & The Flotilla 135

Timeline of Arrival (0 to 518 AA) 149

Interlude: Space Tourism 155

ACT V: RUNNING THE GAME & LORE PAGE 161

Chapter 06A: Operational Systems 161

Chapter 06B: Bestiary & Threat Cards 171

The Procedural Mission Generator 185

Chapter 08: The Forbidden Archives 193

Chapter 10: Reference & Index 201

SYSTEM INTRODUCTION

THE ELEVATOR PITCH

Corsair is a tabletop roleplaying game of high-stakes frontier adventure, tactical problem-solving, and found-family camaraderie, set against the vast backdrop of a macro-engineered cosmos.

You and your crew portray a **Corsair Cell**: licensed, independent operatives flying a versatile starship with a cross-jurisdictional charter. When local planetary law ends at the clouds and the naval peacekeepers of the Flotilla are light-hours away, your sponsors call on you. Whether you are investigating corporate sabotage in a spinning orbital arcology, braving derelict Precursor ruins for lost technology, negotiating tense standoffs across a fraying border, or scraping together enough fuel credits to keep your reaction thrusters burning, your crew stands as the thin line holding a young civilization together.

WHO ARE THE CORSAIRS?

THE SPHERE AT A GLANCE

The game takes place within the **Sphere**, a breathtaking engineered solar system featuring over a hundred terrestrial, habitable worlds and moons locked in tight binary orbits around colossal gas giants, all circling a quiet Orange Dwarf star.

Circa five hundred years ago, automated seed arks brought the survivors of four dying worlds into this seemingly abandoned system. Arriving as the **Newcomers**, humanity and three alien lineages—the cold-blooded, crested **Naga**, the dense-skinned **Craggen**, and the chlorophyllic **Sylvan**—made their first historic landfall on a fertile moon appropriately named **Landfall**. Over five centuries of shared survival, exploration, and cultural blending across the moons, six natural hybrid lineages took root alongside them: **Drakelings**, **Elves**, **Gnomes**, **Dwarves**, **Kobolds**, and **Trolls**.

Today, civilization spans dozens of bustling worlds, gleaming orbital transfer stations, and remote mining habitats. Yet the laws of nature remain stubbornly grounded. There is no faster-than-light warp drive; ships burn continuous fusion engines along calculated orbital curves. There is no artificial gravity plating; you stay grounded either through the axial acceleration of your ship's thrusters, the gentle centrifugal spin of a habitat drum, or the solid click of magnetic boots against steel decks. And in the vacuum of space, waste heat is as dangerous as an enemy round.

YOUR ROLE: THE CORSAIR CELL

Civilization across the moons is divided by a historic treaty: planetary governments hold total jurisdiction within their atmospheric gravity wells, while the peacekeeping fleet known as the **Flotilla** polices the open void and interstellar shipping lanes. This separation creates a glaring legal seam. Smugglers, corporate raiders, rogue mercenaries, and political conspirators routinely commit crimes under planetary clouds and burn into orbit, daring local authorities to chase them past their legal boundaries.

To bridge this seam, authorities grant independent charters to **Corsairs**—small, autonomous crews given cross-jurisdictional warrants to cross from planetary mud to the cold vacuum of orbit without getting bogged down in red tape.

As players, you form a **Corsair Cell**—a tight-knit crew of 3 to 5 specialists sharing an agile starship. Every cell is distinct:

- **Conflicting Sponsors:** Legitimate Corsairs are typically backed by multiple, competing sponsors—such as a Flotilla naval commander, a planetary governor, a commercial trading guild, or an independent labor union. By balancing competing patrons, your crew maintains its operational independence.
- **The Omni-Role Ethos:** You are practical survivors, not rigid archetypes. While every operative has specialized training or hardware rigs, no Corsair is locked into a single duty. Every member of the crew knows how to draw a sidearm in a corridor firefight, monitor a sensor array, pilot a shuttle, patch a ruptured environmental suit, and haggle for spare parts at an orbital bazaar.
- **Freedom of Approach:** Whether your crew acts as principled investigators, gritty salvage hounds, diplomatic fixers, or razor-sharp troubleshooters, how you tackle your contracts is entirely up to you.

WHAT IS A ROLEPLAYING GAME?

A roleplaying game (RPG) is a collaborative storytelling experience. You and your friends create characters to portray, and together you navigate a living world full of adventure, intrigue, and danger.

One player takes on the role of the **Game Master (GM)**. The GM is the primary storyteller, the referee of the rules, and the voice of the non-player characters (NPCs) that inhabit the void. The other players portray the **Player Characters (PCs)**, the specialist operatives who make up the Corsair crew and drive the story forward.

The game unfolds through a natural conversation:

1. **The GM describes the situation:** The environment, the sensory details of the scene, and any imminent hazards or NPCs present.
2. **The players declare their intent:** You state what your characters do, say, or attempt—whether moving into cover, overriding an airlock seal, or negotiating terms with a tense frontier marshal.
3. **The mechanics determine uncertain outcomes:** When an action is routine, it simply succeeds. But when an outcome is uncertain, dangerous, or contested, the dice hit the table using the rules outlined in this book.
4. **The GM describes the consequences:** The fiction moves forward, the scene shifts, and the conversation continues.

There are no winners or losers in a roleplaying game. The goal is to collaborate, face tactical challenges, and tell a memorable, cinematic story together.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED TO PLAY

To play Corsair, you will need a few essentials:

TABLETOP ESSENTIALS	
Dice	The game uses three standard polyhedral die types: eight-sided (**d8**), ten-sided (**d10**), and twelve-sided (**d12**) dice. A handful of each die type (especially d10s, which form the primary resolution dice pool) is ideal for the table.
Sheets	Printable sheets for recording your operative's attributes, skills, equipment, and your starship's modules (Character Sheet & Crew Sheet).
Pencils	Pencils and scratch paper for tracking notes, tactical sketches, and fluctuating game states (Action Points, Light Wounds, Aggravated Wounds, and ammunition).
Tokens	Simple counters (coins, poker chips, or glass beads) are useful for tracking Action Points and tactical positions during moment-to-moment encounters.
Group	Corsair is designed for **3 to 5 players**, including the Game Master.

> **THE PRINCIPLE OF NARRATION**
>
> Dice never roll in a vacuum. A roll represents physical friction: boots catching against grated decking, capacitors whining under peak load, or thruster gimbal bearings fighting reaction torque. Describe what your character physically does before picking up the dice.

READER'S GUIDE: HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This rulebook is organized into five functional sections designed to take you from foundational mechanics to active campaign play, interleaved with narrative fiction capturing the lived reality of the void:

PART I: CORE RULES & ENGINE

The fundamental mechanics that power every test, decision, and scene in the game.

- **Core Mechanics:** The foundational rules of Attributes, Attribute Pairs, Simple Tests (binary success), Success Tests (degree of achievement), Complex Tests (action + quality), Upgrades & Downgrades, Contests, Gambits, and Teamwork.
- **Scenes, Pacing & Action Points:** Zooming between Day-to-Day shifts and high-stakes Moment-to-Moment rounds, the 3 Action Point economy, turn swaps, teamwork actions, and delayed actions.
- **Effects:** Activating dynamic tactical opportunities by sacrificing Hits on Action Rolls (Chain, Upgrade/Downgrade, Blocker) and Success Rolls (Crit, Push).
- **Interlude:** *A Point of Order on the Twenty-Seventh Hour*

PART II: CHARACTER CREATION & CLASSES

Everything you need to conceive, build, and advance your Corsair operative.

- **Player Characters:** Core Attributes, Derived Attributes, Skills, and Condition (wounds and stress).
- **Character Creation:** Step-by-step procedures for assigning attributes, training skills, and choosing starting equipment.
- **Traits & Lineages:** Origin traits, cultural adaptations, and operational quirks that distinguish your operative's physiology and background.
- **Classes & MANTLE Rigs:** The five operational chassis: the energy-channeling **Conduit**, the biochemical **Hazard**, the drone-linking **Pilot**, the frontline bulwark **Vanguard**, and the nanite-weaving **Weaver**.
- **Advancement:** How operatives earn experience, refine skills, upgrade attributes, and achieve career milestones during downtime.
- **Interlude:** *Post War Head- and Heartaches*

PART III: ADVANCED OPERATIONS

The tactical systems, armaments, voidcraft, and operational downtime that keep Corsairs alive and solvent.

- **Tactical Combat:** Movement, grid and abstract occupancy, close-quarters combat (CQC), dynamic cover, and damage resolution.
- **Personal Armory & Hardware:** Catalogs of Firearms, Melee Weapons, Armor, Field Gear, and rare Precursor Exotic Hardware.
- **Starships & Space Combat:** Comprehensive rules for Starship Operations, Brachistochrone burns, Ship Weapons, Internal Modules, and The Hangar Bay.
- **Downtime & Operations:** The 24-hour downtime cycle, shifts, long rests, medical recovery, starship maintenance, commercial bazaars, and the master d100 freelance odd jobs table.
- **Interlude:** *The Mathematics of the Great Tithe*

PART IV: WORLDS OF THE SPHERE

The celestial gazetteer, faction dossiers, history, and fiction of the setting.

- **Planetary Gazetteer:** Macro-engineering of the Sphere, the Newcomer heartland in the Fume Cluster, the cradle of Landfall, and the X'ara Cluster.
- **Factions & Powers:** Dossiers on the Sovereign Colonies, Megacorporations, the Flotilla, and the Underworld.
- **The Corsairs & Timeline:** The legal mandate of Corsairs, the 500-year history since arrival, and master anthology Stories of the Sphere.
- **Interlude:** *Space Tourism*

PART V: RUNNING THE GAME

Procedures, campaign structures, threat rosters, and mission generators for running the game.

- **Running the Game:** Core guidelines for Time Management, Social Interactions, Stealth & Infiltration, Investigation, Chases & Pursuits, and Tracks.
- **Threats of the Sphere:** Tactical profiles and statblocks for corporate security, pirates, drone swarms, void horrors, and NPC Guidelines.
- **Missions & Contracts:** Procedural Mission Generator and Open Play Contracts.

> **FLIGHT CLEARANCE APPROVED**
> Proceed to the foundational resolution mechanics: **Chapter 01: Core Mechanics →**

CORE MECHANICS & RESOLUTION

In Corsair, the story unfolds through a conversation between the players and the Game Master (GM). The players narrate the actions of their characters, describing what they want to do, where they want to go, and what they say. The GM, in turn, narrates the world around the characters. The GM describes the environment, controls the non-player characters, and explains how the world reacts to the players' actions.

Most of the time, this back-and-forth is all that's needed. If a player says, *"I walk across the room and open the door,"* and there's no reason they couldn't, the GM simply says, *"Okay, you open the door and see..."*

However, sometimes a character attempts an action where the outcome is uncertain. Can the character leap across a chasm? Can they persuade a fugitive with a gun to stand down? Can they land a hit with their sidearm if they don't? In these moments, when the drama and tension of the story hang in the balance, we turn to the dice to see what happens. This is the heart of the game's mechanics, and it's where the rules of Corsair come into play.

ATTRIBUTES

In Corsair, any significant feature of a person, creature, or object can be represented by an **Attribute**. Attributes are a way to assign a numerical value to a characteristic, making it a concrete element of the game world. Anything and everything can have Attributes.

While characters have core Attributes representing their physical and mental capabilities—**Strength**, **Agility**, **Finesse**, **Instinct**, **Knowledge**, and **Presence**—the concept extends to all corners of the game:

- **Strength:** Raw physical power, muscular force, and bodily mass. Used for lifting heavy cargo, forcing jammed airlocks, overpowering opponents in hand-to-hand combat, and carrying heavy equipment.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, and athletic coordination. Used for sprinting between cover, dodging incoming hazards, vaulting obstacles, and maneuvering in zero-gravity.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, surgical precision, and fine motor control. Used for aiming firearms, picking mechanical locks, performing delicate surgery, and manipulating intricate instruments.
- **Knowledge:** Formal education, technical literacy, and deductive reasoning. Used for slicing computer security, analyzing sensor telemetry, operating starship consoles, and understanding alien relics.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, charisma, and commanding social authority. Used for negotiating deals, intimidating rivals, inspiring companions, and maintaining composure under intense pressure.
- **Instinct:** Intuition, acute situational alertness, and gut-level reflexes. Used for sensing impending ambushes, detecting hidden hazards, reading an adversary's unspoken intent, and reacting in the chaos of battle.

Beyond living characters, the concept of Attributes extends to all corners of the game. A weapon might have **Rate of Fire** and **Accuracy** as Attributes. A jetpack could have a **Thrust** Attribute, while a cybernetic arm might have a **Power** rating. A starship is defined by a whole range of Attributes, such as its **Thrusters**, **Hull**, and **Scanners**. These ratings are the primary factor in determining the outcome of an action. A higher Attribute value signifies greater capability, directly impacting the dice rolls you'll make during the game.

ATTRIBUTE PAIRS

When a situation calls for a die roll, the GM will determine the two most relevant Attributes to form an **Attribute Pair**. This pair becomes the foundation of the test. The choice of Attributes is always dependent on the context of the action being performed.

It's important to note that the same Attribute can be selected twice if the action calls for a focused application of that single quality. For example, lifting a heavy crate might call for a **Strength + Strength** test, representing a pure application of raw power. Additionally, when a test specifies only a single Attribute, it should be understood as a test where both Attributes in the Attribute Pair are that specified Attribute.

Here are a few examples of how these might be combined into Attribute Pairs:

- **Accuracy (of the gun) + Finesse:** To fire a ranged weapon.
- **Manouverability (of the spaceship) + Instinct:** To carefully pilot a shuttle through a dense asteroid field.
- **Strength + Presence:** To intimidate a guard with a show of force.
- **Knowledge + Instinct:** To investigate a crime scene, look for clues and deduce what happened.

TESTS

When the outcome of an action is uncertain, the GM will call for a test. There are three types of tests in Corsair: **Simple**, **Success**, and **Complex**.

SIMPLE TESTS

A Simple Test is used when the outcome of an action is binary: you either succeed or you fail. There is no middle ground. To make a Simple Test, you form a dice pool by taking a number of ten-sided dice (d10s) equal to the higher of the two Attributes in the pair. In order to succeed, you need at least one of the dice to roll an 8 or higher (also called a *Hit*). If it does, you succeed; if it doesn't, you fail.

Examples of Simple Tests include:

- Leaping across a chasm.
- Sneaking through a patrolled corridor.
- Disarming a trap.

SUCCESS TESTS

A Success Test is used for actions that are certain to succeed, but the degree of success is variable. The question isn't *if* you can do it, but *how well* you do it in the time available. For a Success Test, you form a dice pool using a number of d10s equal to the *higher* of the two Attributes in the pair. The highest single die roll from the pool becomes your **success points**, which measures how effectively you performed the action.

Examples of Success Tests include:

- Applying first aid to a wounded crewmate to see how many wounds you can patch up.
- Spending a day in the workshop repairing your ship to see how much progress you make.
- Moving around the battlefield and seeing how much distance you cover.

COMPLEX TESTS

Complex Tests are for situations where you need to know both *if* an action is successful and *how* successful it is. This is most common in combat, where you need to know if an attack hits and, if it does, how much damage it deals. A Complex Test is a two-step process:

1. **The Action Roll:** First, you make a roll to see if you succeed at all. This is identical to a Simple Test: you roll a number of d10s equal to the **higher** of the two Attributes in the pair. If your highest die is a 7 or lower, your action fails.
2. **The Success Roll:** If your Action Roll is a success (at least one die shows 8 or higher), you then determine the *quality* of your success. You take a number of dice from the successful roll equal to the **lower** of the two Attributes. The highest value on these dice becomes your "success points."

Essentially, a Complex Test combines a Simple Test to see if you hit, and a Success Test to see how well you hit.

THE IMPORTANCE OF NARRATION

It is crucial to understand that the GM determines the type of test and the Attribute Pair based on *how you describe your character's actions*. Your narration matters. The choices you make in describing an action can change the Attributes used, and therefore the dice you roll.

For example, let's say your character is trying to persuade an NPC:

- If you say, *"I try to reason with him, surely he will see my point in all this,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Knowledge** test, splashing in Knowledge for the reasoning part.
- If you instead say, *"I put on all the charm my character has and try to appeal to him that way,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Presence** test.
- If you narrate, *"I get all up in his face and make it very clear to him in no uncertain terms that he will do as I say,"* the GM will call for a **Strength + Presence** test.
- And if you instead say, *"I hold my gun to his head and start counting,"* the GM could still ask for the **Damage** or the **Load** (size) of the gun and say roll that plus your **Presence**.

UPGRADES AND DOWNGRADES

Situational factors can influence the outcome of a test. A character might have a significant advantage, like using a high-quality tool, or a disadvantage, like working in a hazardous environment. These are represented by **Upgrades** and **Downgrades**:

- **Upgrade:** For each net **Upgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to a twelve-sided die (d12). If all the dice in your pool are already d12s, each further **Upgrade** adds a new d10 to the pool.
- **Downgrade:** For each net **Downgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to an eight-sided die (d8). If all the dice in your pool are already d8s, each further **Downgrade** forces you to remove a d8 from the pool.

Before any roll, the GM assesses the situation and assigns Upgrades for advantages and Downgrades for disadvantages. These cancel each other out on a 1-to-1 basis (e.g., 3 Upgrades and 2 Downgrades yields a net of 1 Upgrade).

The net number of Upgrades or Downgrades has a **maximum limit of 6**. If you have 8 Upgrades and 1 Downgrade, you have a net of 7 Upgrades, but you apply only 6 to the roll. In the rare case that you run out of all dice to downgrade, the test is extremely difficult: you roll two d8s and must take the lower result.

THE GAMBIT SYSTEM

Gambit is a special resource that allows players to snatch victory from the jaws of defeat. It's a pool of dice that you can use to turn a failed roll into a success.

EARNING GAMBIT

You earn **Gambit** by taking risks. After you roll your dice pool for a test, if any die shows its maximum possible value (e.g., a 10 on a d10, or a 12 on a d12), you have a choice. You can either use that die as part of your test as normal, or you can "bank" it for later. If you choose to bank it, you remove the die from your current roll and add it to your personal **Gambit** pool. This die can then be spent on a future roll.

SPENDING GAMBIT

You can spend a **Gambit** die from your pool on any test your character makes. You can declare you are spending **Gambit** at any point during the test—before you roll, after you see the results, anytime. When you spend a **Gambit** die, you simply add it to your current dice pool and roll it. Its result is added to the other dice, potentially changing the outcome of the test.

When a player spends a **Gambit** die, and the dice pool has already been modified by **Upgrades** or **Downgrades**, the newly added **Gambit** die retains its original die type.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF GAMBIT

There is one crucial restriction on using **Gambit**: **a player can either spend or gain Gambit during a test, but not both.** This means that if you spend any **Gambit** from your pool on a test, you cannot choose to bank any dice from that test to earn new **Gambit**. Conversely, if you bank a die from a roll to earn a **Gambit**, you cannot spend any **Gambit** on that same test.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER: AN EXAMPLE TEST

Let's see how all these elements come together in play:

- **The Scenario:** Serving an apprehension warrant against an armed syndicate cell in an unpoliced orbital warehouse, Jax, a nimble gunslinger, is pinned down behind a cargo container. An outlaw skirmisher is advancing on his position, laying down suppressing fire. Jax decides to pop up and take a quick shot at the suspect with his sidearm. The GM decides this is a **Complex Test**, as they need to know if the shot hits and how much damage it deals. Jax's player describes the action as a quick, precise shot, so the GM chooses the Attribute Pair: **Finesse + Accuracy**. Jax has **Finesse 4**, his sidearm has **Accuracy 3**, and he holds two d10s in his Gambit pool.
- **1. The Action Roll (Did the shot hit?):** For the first part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the higher of the two Attributes (**Finesse 4**), assembling a dice pool of **4d10**. He rolls `[2, 4, 5, 7]`. The highest result is 7 (a miss). Jax spends a Gambit die: *"I'm spending a Gambit."* He rolls the banked d10 and gets an `[8]`. His pool is now `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. With an 8, the shot hits!
- **2. The Success Roll (How much damage was dealt?):** For the second part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the lower Attribute (**Accuracy 3**), taking the 3 highest dice from his pool: `[5, 7, 8]`. The highest die is an 8 (8 points of damage). Jax decides to maximize the damage: *"I'm spending my second Gambit die."* He rolls his second banked d10 and rolls a `[9]`. His Success pool is now `[5, 7, 8, 9]`. The highest result is a 9.
- **Resolution:** Jax deals 9 points of damage to the outlaw, taking them down before they can breach his cover. Spending his banked Gambit turned a clean miss into a devastating shot.

CONTESTING A TEST

Often, a test isn't just against a static obstacle; it's against an active opponent who is trying to interfere. When a character is the target of another character's test (like being shot at, deceived, or tackled), they have the opportunity to contest.

In order to contest an action taken by another creature, you must be in close physical proximity to its target—typically sharing the immediate space with them. For example, you can contest an attack coming at you or an ally right beside you, and you can contest an enemy's movement crossing your space. On the other hand, you cannot contest a hostile creature reviving an ally 40 meters away by shooting at them.

To perform a **Contest**, the defending creature rolls a **Simple Test** determined by the GM (called a **Contest Roll**). Each die landing **8 or higher (a Hit)** eliminates the highest die from the roll you contested.

You **resist** a test if your Contest Roll eliminates every 8+ die from the contested roll.

You can contest **Success Tests** as well. If, after contesting, no 8+ dice remain in the contested character's pool, the Success Test generates **0 Success Points**, even if there are dice that are yet to be eliminated.

You can also contest actions that would normally not require a test (such as shushing someone before they can speak, or preventing an enemy you knocked prone from standing up). When this happens, you declare your intent to contest, and the contested creature must decide if they are willing to perform a **Simple Test** to complete their action—which you can then contest—or forego it altogether.

CONTEST EXAMPLE

Returning to our gunslinger Jax: suppose Jax fires at a fleeing syndicate smuggler trying to reach an airlock, rolling `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. The suspect has an **Evasion** of 3 and dives behind reinforced deck piping. The GM calls for an Evasion Contest Roll (**3d10**). The smuggler rolls `[3, 8, 9]`—scoring two Hits (8 and 9). These two Hits eliminate Jax's two highest dice (the 8 and the 7). Jax's remaining pool is `[2, 4, 5]`. With no die of 8 or higher remaining, the attack becomes a **Failure**; the round ricochets harmlessly off the reinforced piping as the suspect scrambles out of the line of fire.

TEAMWORK

Sometimes, a single character isn't enough for the job. When multiple characters cooperate on the same task at the same time—forcing open a hydraulic blast door, infiltrating past a vigilant patrol, or executing a coordinated breach—they can use **Teamwork**.

JOINING A TEAMWORK ACTION

Any character's action can be turned into a **Teamwork Test** by additional eligible characters declaring their intent to join. A character can join a Teamwork action if:

- **Proximity:** The participants are in close physical proximity to each other and their shared objective.
- **Appropriate Contribution:** Each participant rolls the Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon, gear, or method of action. Participants do not need to roll the same Attribute Pair! For example, two characters forcing a heavy blast door might both roll **Strength + Strength**, but in a coordinated combat assault, one character might swing a warhammer (**Strength + Finesse**, Striking) while an ally thrusts with a combat knife (**Agility + Finesse**, Piercing). Because all tests evaluate Hits on an 8 or higher, dice can be swapped freely between pools regardless of which attributes generated them.
- **Shared Target or Objective:** If the action has a target or destination, it must be identical for all participants (firing on the same enemy, treating the same wounded ally, forcing the same bulkhead).
- **Logical Feasibility:** The task must be something that multiple people can realistically cooperate on simultaneously.

THE DICE SWAP

After all participants declare their intent to cooperate, everyone rolls their respective test pools simultaneously. Once the dice hit the table, **any two participants can swap any amount of dice between their pools**. The strategic purpose of this exchange is mutual support: characters with surplus high-value dice (8+) pass extra results to allies who rolled low, ensuring the entire team achieves its goal or shaves away vulnerabilities.

CONTESTING TEAMWORK: DEFENDER'S ADVANTAGE

When an adversary is targeted by a Teamwork action, the defender gains the **Defender's Advantage**:

1. **Team Rolls:** All attacking participants roll their dice pools simultaneously.
2. **Team Swaps:** Attackers coordinate and commit their dice distribution.
3. **Defender Rolls:** The defender rolls their Contest pool *after* the attackers commit their dice swap.
4. **Targeted Elimination:** Each Hit (8+) on the Contest Roll allows the defender to eliminate the highest die from **whichever participating attacker's pool the defender chooses**. The defender can focus all Hits onto a single attacker to knock them out of the test, or split Hits across multiple foes.
5. **Knocking Attackers Out:** In a Complex Test, if the defender eliminates all 8+ dice from an attacker's pool, that attacker fails their Action Roll completely and **cannot advance to the Success Roll**. Only attackers who retain an 8+ move forward to roll damage!

COMPLEX TESTS & CONTESTS IN TEAMWORK

Teamwork can be employed across both stages of a Complex Test. Surviving attackers roll their Success pools and may **swap dice between their Success pools as well**, funneling high dice onto an operative with high-damage weapons or critical effects.

Defenders can also use Teamwork to resist incoming actions: when multiple defenders coordinate to resist an action, they roll their contest pools simultaneously, swap dice to maximize total Hits (8+), and allocate their combined eliminations against the attackers.

SCENES, PACING, AND ACTION

Corsair's gameplay is structured to keep the action moving and give every character a chance to shine. The story unfolds in Scenes, which are the fundamental building blocks of your adventure. However, not all scenes are paced the same. The GM can control the narrative flow by "zooming in" or "zooming out" on the action, changing the scope of a scene from a single, heart-pounding moment to the events of an entire day.

The game distinguishes between three types of scenes based on their scope: **Moment to Moment**, **Place to Place**, and **Day to Day**.

SCENE TYPES AND PACING

Think of the scene type as a camera lens. The GM can zoom in for a close-up on a dramatic confrontation or zoom out to quickly cover a long journey:

- **Day to Day:** This is the most "zoomed-out" level of play. It's used to cover long periods of time in which the characters are engaged in ongoing activities, but nothing requires immediate, second-by-second attention. This could be a day spent repairing the ship, a week of interstellar travel, or a month of downtime in a bustling city.
- **Place to Place:** This is the mid-level scope, focusing on a specific location and the events that unfold there. It's used for exploring a space station, navigating a dangerous asteroid field, or investigating a crime scene. Time is more fluid here than in Moment to Moment play, but the focus is on a single, contiguous area.
- **Moment to Moment:** This is the most "zoomed-in" level of play, where every second counts. This is for high-stakes situations like combat, a frantic chase, or a tense negotiation.

ACTION POINTS

Action Points are the currency you spend to perform significant actions, especially those requiring a Test. Every player has a maximum of **3 Action Points**.

Every test you take, whether it be Simple, Success, or Complex, requires **1 Action Point**. In some cases the GM might also call on you to spend an Action Point without taking a test, for example, to transit from one major location to the next.

ROUNDS

Within any scene, the action is broken down into **Rounds**. A round is a period of in-game time appropriate to the scene's pacing, where every character present has an opportunity to act. This ensures that the chaos of a situation is manageable and that the spotlight is shared.

A round in moment-to-moment pacing is only a dozen or so seconds long. In place-to-place pacing, a round might last from minutes to a few hours, while in day-to-day pacing, it's a full day.

At the start of every Round, every creature refills their Action Points to the maximum.

When the round ends, the GM gets an opportunity to introduce new characters into the scene, based on the broader scope of the scene that's playing out and the amount of time that passed during the round. This can be new reinforcements arriving in a moment-to-moment gunfight, or an inspection from the local authorities while you are going place-to-place. This also lets the GM advance the plot via NPCs that are acting outside the ongoing scene.

TURNS

Each round is divided into multiple turns of two different types: The **Player Turn** and the **GM Turn**.

- **Player Turn:** During the Player Turn, the players decide and declare what their characters are doing. A crucial aspect of the Player Turn is its free-form nature. **Players can act in any order they wish.** You can coordinate your actions, set up combos, and react to each other's decisions dynamically. One player might act, then another, then the first player might act again.
- **GM Turn:** During the GM Turn, the Game Master narrates the actions of the non-player characters (NPCs) in the scene. This is when every NPC makes their moves. If there are no NPCs in the scene other than the players, the GM turn is skipped, and it's the Player's Turn again.

The turn swaps from the players to the GM (or vice versa) after the active side has spent a total of **2 or more Action Points** and resolved their last action. The round concludes when both sides choose to "pass," meaning they have no further actions to take. Every round starts with the Player Turn first.

Most rounds will fly by due to the players being grounded with no NPCs, or NPCs that generally don't wish to affect the player characters. Therefore, most rounds will be rather one-sided, but that is a good thing as the GM already has a lot of work just arbitrating the player characters' narrations.

When a player action causes an NPC to go from a passive to an active participant in the scene, they become active and receive their Action Points next round, meaning each player character has a chance to act before the GM gets to react with NPCs.

GOING FIRST

Every round begins with the Player Turn. The players always act first, coordinating their moves and executing their strategies before the GM responds with the actions of non-player characters.

TEAMWORK ACTIONS

Teamwork allows multiple characters to contribute to a single goal. When characters use Teamwork, they can spend their Action Points to contribute to the collective effort. While players spending Action Points to participate in a Teamwork Test counts towards the 2AP per Turn limit, reaching the limit doesn't stop additional characters from participating. The turn will only end once the Teamwork Test has resolved.

TEAMWORK EXAMPLE: CHECKPOINT INFILTRATION

The crew is working an undercover assignment tracking a fugitive into an outlaw-run freeport. To reach the lower docks without tipping off the local syndicate, they must pass through an enforcer-controlled checkpoint. The GM rules this will be a Teamwork action, requiring each character to make a Success Test to see how well they blend into the underworld foot traffic:

- Silas, a master of disguise, creates a subtle diversion at a cargo terminal and scores 2 hits.
- Griz, a large and imposing figure, tries to look inconspicuous by pretending to be an off-shift maintenance hauler, but fails miserably, scoring no hits.
- Jax, ever the opportunist, strikes up a casual conversation with one of the gang lookouts to draw their attention, scoring just one hit.

The players have now collectively spent 3 Action Points. Silas swaps one of his hits for one of Griz's dice, representing the operatives covering for each other's slip-ups and successfully slipping past the checkpoint as a cohesive unit.

The flexibility of the turn structure and Action Point system is designed to encourage creative problem-solving and dynamic, cinematic action. Don't be afraid to combine actions, work together, and push your characters to their limits.

DELAYED ACTIONS

During high-stakes encounters, characters do not always act immediately; often, a disciplined Corsair holds their fire until an enemy leaves cover, waits for an incoming threat to breach a threshold, or readies a shot to interrupt a hostile move. You can prepare for such moments by declaring a **Delayed Action**:

- **Setting Up (1 AP):** On your turn, you spend **1 Action Point** to prepare a delayed action. When declaring a delayed action, you must specify two things:
  1. **The Trigger:** The observable event or condition you are reacting to (e.g., *"when an enemy steps out of cover," "if Brant draws a sidearm,"* or *"when the blast door starts to open"*).
  2. **The Planned Action:** The specific action you intend to take when the trigger occurs. The planned action must be manageable within **1 AP** (such as taking a shot with a firearm, swinging a melee weapon, making a Simple Test, or moving up to your base movement distance).
- **Declaring Timing (Before vs. After):** You have tactical freedom over when your action resolves relative to the trigger, but you must declare your timing beforehand when setting it up:
  - **Reacting Before (Interrupt):** You act *before* the triggering event resolves. For instance, declaring that you will shoot at a target the moment they attempt to fire at you allows you to shoot first, potentially eliminating or disrupting them before their attack can land.
  - **Reacting After (Response):** You act *after* the triggering event has completed. For instance, waiting until an enemy has moved completely out from behind heavy cover into open ground before firing ensures they cannot claim cover bonuses against your attack.
- **Action Point & Turn Accounting:** The 1 AP cost is paid **on the turn you set up the delayed action**, counting against the 2 AP limit of that turn. When the trigger condition occurs and you take your action, it requires **0 additional AP** in that moment, and it does not count against the AP limit of the turn in which it triggers.
- **Resolution and Expiration:** When the trigger condition is met, you immediately execute the declared test or action. If the triggering condition does not occur before the end of the round, the prepared action expires without effect—the spent Action Point represents the time, readiness, and vigilance invested in holding your position.
- **Delayed Teamwork Actions:** Multiple characters can coordinate to set up a shared delayed action (such as establishing a crossfire overwatch or setting a synchronized ambush):
  - **Setup:** All participants must share the same space, spend **1 AP** each, and agree upon the exact same **Trigger**, **Target**, and **Timing** (Before or After). Each participant prepares the action and Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon or tool. An ally can spend 1 AP on a subsequent turn to join an existing ally's delayed action if they enter their space.
  - **Triggering & Swapping:** When the trigger condition occurs, all linked participants roll simultaneously for **0 additional AP** and can swap dice between their pools under standard Teamwork rules. If the target contests, Defender's Advantage applies normally.
  - **Disruption:** If an individual participant is incapacitated, knocked out of the space, or forced to defend before the trigger occurs, their readied action is broken, but remaining allies can still execute their delayed action when the condition is met.

ZOOMING IN AND OUT

The GM can transition between scene types as the story demands:

- **Zooming In:** When a broader scene suddenly becomes more dangerous or dramatic, the GM can "zoom in." For example, while the crew is executing a recovery warrant aboard an abandoned freighter (Place to Place), they might be ambushed by barricaded pirate scavengers, instantly shifting the scene to Moment to Moment. When zooming in, all characters present in the scene synchronize their broader Action Points down to the lowest remaining AP among them (reflecting time elapsed together). They then refill their Action Points in the new, narrower pacing to their maximum (3 AP) and begin a fresh round. Any ongoing effects created in the broader pacing are retained.
- **Zooming Out:** When a high-stakes scene concludes, the GM "zooms out" back to the broader pacing. Players set aside their tactical Action Points and resume the broader pacing with their remaining broader Action Points. If characters still have Action Points remaining in that broader round, they continue their shift or day; if all broader AP have been spent, the broader round concludes at the End of the Round. Characters operating in parallel in other locations retain their unspent broader AP and can take actions during that same timeframe.

EFFECTS

While succeeding at a test achieves your immediate objective, game mechanics in Corsair invite you to shape the battleground, create tactical openings, and alter the narrative flow of a scene. This is accomplished through Effects. Rather than relying solely on standard outcomes, Effects allow you to convert exceptional rolls into dynamic opportunities—turning a single strike into a sweeping attack, driving an opponent backward, or setting up a defensive barrier for an ally.

ACTIVATING EFFECTS

To activate an Effect, you sacrifice **Hits**—dice displaying a result of 8 or higher—rolled during an Action Roll or a Success Roll, depending on the specific Effect's requirements.

Activating an Effect is an exercise in collaborative storytelling between you and the Game Master. The Effect you declare must align logically with your character's action, declared narration, and chosen Attribute Pair. For instance, you cannot use an attack roll with a rifle to push a heavy blast door shut across the room, but you could easily describe forcing an enemy backward into cover or shooting out a control panel. The GM retains final discretion on whether an Effect fits naturally into the unfolding fiction.

ACTION EFFECTS

Action Effects are activated during your **Action Roll**. By setting aside Hits before moving on to resolve your Success Roll, you can manipulate the immediate environment or extend the reach of your action:

- **Chain Effect:** When performing an action directed at a single target out of several eligible choices—most commonly during combat—you may spend Hits on a **Chain Effect**. For each Hit you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you select one additional eligible target to include in the action. When chaining a Complex Test, perform a single Success Roll using the lower Attribute; the highest die applies individually to every target caught in the chain. You cannot chain actions that naturally affect multiple targets by default. Furthermore, if the base action requires expending a specific resource (such as ammunition, power cells, or consumable gear), you must pay that resource cost separately for each chained target. When making a ranged attack, you can only chain targets in the same range band, and the combined use of Chain and Crit effects cannot exceed your weapon's Rate of Fire (RoF).
- **Upgrade and Downgrade Effect:** When your action creates a clear situational advantage for yourself or an impending disadvantage for an enemy, you can activate an **Upgrade or Downgrade Effect**. Each Hit spent from your Action Roll allows you to step up or step down a die on subsequent tests related to that altered circumstance. Crucially, if you are resolving a Complex Test, you may apply this effect immediately to step up dice on your own upcoming Success Roll without needing to specify the situational advantage.
- **Blocker Effect:** If your narration aims to hinder, interrupt, or prevent an enemy from carrying out a specific future action, you can establish a **Blocker Effect**. For every **2 Hits** you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you set aside 1 Hit to create a pool of defensive dice. When an opponent attempts the blocked action, each set-aside Hit negates the single highest die from their test pool before resolving. Once a set-aside Hit negates an opponent's die, that set-aside Hit is expended. The Blocker Effect persists until all set-aside Hits are exhausted. If an opponent attempts to perform an action that normally does not require a test (such as opening a latch or standing up), the Blocker forces them to execute a **Simple Test** first; failing to eliminate all set-aside Hits prevents them from completing the action.

SUSTAINED EFFECTS

Certain Effects can be sustained over time rather than depleting after a single use. An Effect can become a **Sustained Effect** whenever there is an active physical object (such as magnetic restraints, deployed gear, a smoke screen, or specialized equipment) or an ongoing continuous action sustaining it.

When an Effect is sustained, any set-aside Hits or mechanical benefits do not deplete when triggered. Instead, the full pool of set-aside Hits or advantages resets after each affected action or attempt. Sustained Effects can be applied to any Effect type where continuous operation makes logical narrative sense—most commonly Blocker Effects or ongoing Upgrade/Downgrade Effects. A Sustained Effect remains active until an opponent succeeds despite the penalty or until the physical object or continuous action sustaining it is removed, destroyed, or neutralized.

SUCCESS EFFECTS

Success Effects are activated during your **Success Roll**, allowing you to amplify the effectiveness or intensity of an action that has already proven successful:

- **Crit Effect:** The primary Success Effect across all Success Rolls. For every Hit (8+) sacrificed from your Success Roll pool, you add **+2 Success Points** directly to your highest remaining die value.
- **Push Effect:** Leverage raw momentum or physical force to reposition a target. For each Hit sacrificed from your Success Roll, you knock or force the target backward by up to 4 meters. If you wish to maintain pressure or stay in close proximity, you may move along with the target as they are displaced without spending additional movement. Push Effects can only be activated if **Strength** (or a similar physical power attribute) is included in the test's Attribute Pair; they cannot be activated with tests relying solely on finesse, mental, or social attributes.

REMOVING EFFECTS

Ongoing environmental hazards, physical restraints, and persistent blockers do not have to remain forever. If a character is in a position to eliminate or neutralize an active ongoing effect, they may spend **1 Action Point** on their turn to make a **Simple Test** determined by the GM. Each Hit scored on this Simple Test removes 1 set-aside Hit from the targeted effect, gradually breaking down the obstacle until it is completely eliminated.

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION: SYNDICATE CACHE BREACH

Acting under a Flotilla interdiction warrant, Jax and his team are raiding a fortified syndicate contraband cache defended by illegal combat drones. Engaging in close-quarters combat at the breached bulkhead, Jax declares, "I step in and swing my axe in a sweeping melee strike across the lead combat drone to tear open its plating while driving it back into its squadmate to clear the entryway."

The GM assesses the melee action and calls for a **Strength (5) + Strength (5)** Complex Test. Jax rolls 5d10 for his Action Roll based on his higher Attribute (**Strength 5**), producing `[3, 5, 8, 8, 9]`.

With three Hits (8, 8, and 9), Jax spends one Hit (8) to activate an Action Effect—an **Upgrade Effect**—stepping up one die on his upcoming Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**. He leaves his remaining Hits (8 and 9) to ensure his Action Roll succeeds.

Moving to his Success Roll for his lower Attribute (**Strength 5**), Jax rolls 4d10 and 1d12 (modified by his Upgrade Effect). His roll yields `[5, 6, 7, 8]` on the d10s and 8 on the d12.

Jax scores two Hits (both 8s) on his Success Roll. He decides to activate two Success Effects:

- He spends his first 8 to activate a **Push Effect** (valid since his test relies on Strength), shoving the lead combat drone back 4 meters directly into its squadmate.
- He spends his second 8 to activate a **Crit Effect**, granting **+2 Success Points** to his highest remaining die.

The highest remaining die on his Success Roll is 7. By sacrificing his second 8 for Crit instead of keeping it as his base die, Jax increases his total from 8 to **9 Success Points** (7 + 2 = 9), neutralizing the lead drone while driving it clear of the doorway.

A POINT OF ORDER ON THE TWENTY-SEVENTH HOUR

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

Jesse Haddon was fifty-eight years old, which was old enough to know that the universe was enormously large, profoundly strange, and mostly interested in generating paperwork.

As Speaker of the Crossroads Council, Jesse sat behind a heavy cedar table that he had planed and varnished with his own two hands thirty years ago. Outside the high arched windows, the twin world of Nimbus—a swirling sphere of purple and gold sixty thousand miles across—was casually drifting across the afternoon sky toward the sun. In about twenty minutes, it would block the light entirely. The thirty-hour day would pause, the valley would plunge into a sudden, freezing twilight, and the gas lamps out in the square would click on for *The Pause*.

To a poet, it was an awe-inspiring celestial dance. To Jesse, it meant he had exactly twenty minutes to get five very stubborn people to agree on a ditch before the room went dark and his tea went cold.

"It is not merely a question of the ditch," Councilwoman Vaelith was saying, leaning forward until her leafy green hair brushed the ceiling beams. She was an eight-foot-tall Sylvan elder with magnificent wooden tusks, peering down her nose through a pair of tiny brass spectacles. "It is a question of common decency. The new rocket shuttles taking off from the south field are blowing black soot all over the valley. My people hang their bedsheets out to dry in the morning, and by noon they look like chimney sweeps. My cousin's boy had to get married in a grey tunic, Jesse. A *grey* tunic."

On the other side of the table, Brom of the Stone-Carvers Guild gave a long, gravelly sigh that sounded like a wheelbarrow of river rocks being tipped into a creek. Brom was a Craggen, which meant his skin was solid grey granite, his eyes were cut gemstones, and his patience was measured in centuries.

"The shuttles carry iron sewer pipes," Brom rumbled, tapping a thick stone finger on his ledger. "Caldera Foundry makes the pipes on the other side of the mountain. The shuttles bring them here. If we tax the shuttles, the foundry raises the price of the pipes. If the price goes up, we don't finish the sewer. And with all respect to your cousin's wedding, Vaelith, if we don't finish the sewer before the rainy season, clean bedsheets will be the very least of our problems."

"Call the vote, Jesse," hissed Magistrate Ssisera. She was a slender Naga judge, currently coiled in a tight, shivering knot on top of the room's single cast-iron steam radiator, her scaly crest flushed an irritable yellow. "It is the twenty-seventh hour. I am cold, my crest is peeling, and if Nimbus covers the sun before I get a hot bowl of broth, I am going to bite the next person who mentions laundry."

From the open terrace behind the council table, a deep, resonant voice chimed in:

"I rather like the smell of the rockets," the voice rumbled. It was a magnificent sound, like a cathedral pipe organ being played through three feet of warm honey. "It smells like hot iron and ambition. But Vaelith is right about the sheets, Jesse. Grey linens are dreadfully dreary."

Jesse didn't turn around. He didn't need to. Resting his massive chin comfortably on the marble balustrade of the terrace was **Goldheart**.

He was a void dragon. Out in the deep, freezing silence between the stars, he was a creature of myth and terror, a living furnace of bio-fusion capable of outrunning warships and trading blows with alien dreadnoughts. Here in Crossroads Valley, however, where he had lived since the first colony ship opened its hatches five hundred years ago, he was essentially the town's overgrown grandfather. He liked roasted apples, he liked watching the village children play in the square, and above all, he dearly loved municipal meetings. To an immortal being that fed on cosmic energy, there was something endlessly soothing about mortal politics. It was like watching someone fold origami from a legal document so that in the end you could read a haiku from the back of a paper swan. That was the ideal anyway, but the dragon appreciated the effort too.

"Thank you, Goldheart," Jesse said mildly, tapping his wooden gavel. "Your thoughts on bedsheets are, as always, deeply valued. The chair recognizes the dragon's remark. Now, all those in favor of the shuttle drainage fee—"

A horrible, high-pitched whistling shriek tore through the clouds.

It wasn't the polite, muffled hum of a licensed cargo hauler. It was the frantic, screeching howl of a small, stolen hopper engine that was on fire, missing half its thruster nozzles, and falling out of the sky far too fast.

Jesse looked up. Through the hall's stained-glass skylight—an antique window commemorating the First Landing—he saw a streak of greasy black smoke, followed immediately by two pairs of boots. An instant later, the skylight gave way with a sound like a greenhouse being dropped from an orbital crane, showering shards of antique leaded glass and splintered roof tiles across the chamber.

A body struck the center of Jesse's beloved cedar table with the dull, violent impact of a side of beef dropped from a cargo gantry, snapping the center plank clean in half and sending water pitchers, ink pots, and tax ledgers flying in all directions.

Jesse closed his eyes, took a deep breath, and counted slowly to three. When he opened them, a twitchy kid in a grease-stained leather flight jacket was scrambling backward across the ruined table, clutching a humming, glowing hunk of alien metal wrapped in a dirty burlap sack. The object was pulsing with a strange, dull rhythm that made Jesse's front teeth ache. In his other hand, the kid was waving a dented, ugly little machine pistol.

"Stay back!" the kid shrieked, his eyes wild and bloodshot. "Don't touch me! I pulled this core straight out of the old war wreck in the crater! You take one step and I crack the casing! I'll level the whole street!"

Councilwoman Vaelith stared at the wreckage of the table, her wooden spectacles askew on her nose. "Young man," she said in a tone of voice that could freeze boiling water, "you have just ruined a thirty-year-old finish."

"I don't give a damn about your furniture!" the boy screamed, waving the gun at her. "Tell those Corsairs to back off! I'm not going to the penal mines! Tell them to back off!"

Above the hole in the roof, two thick steel cables snapped taut against the iron rafters with the sharp, mechanical bite of industrial winches. Two figures dropped through the opening, hitting the stone floor with the heavy, hydraulic crunch of powered armor. They were covered in soot, their grey metal plates were scraped to bare alloy, and they looked thoroughly, profoundly exhausted.

The lead Corsair brought a heavy, snub-nosed shotgun up to their shoulder in one smooth, practiced motion. Beside them, an elven partner leveled a taser rifle.

"Iron on the floor, kid," the one holding the shotgun rasped through her helmet grille. "Don't do anything stupid. Stupid is what got you into this mess. Put down the gun and live long enough to enjoy some variety in life."

The fugitive backed frantically toward the open terrace, his knuckles white against the grip of his machine pistol. "Stay back! I mean it! One step and I crack the casing! I'll take half the block with me!"

Jesse sighed. He picked up his bent glasses, rubbed the glass dust off them, and set them on his nose.

"Young man," Jesse said politely, "you are already facing three counts of grand larceny, an unlicensed atmospheric descent, and the destruction of a thirty-year-old cedar table. Do not make this afternoon any more expensive than it already is."

The kid's face twisted into desperation. He swiveled the gun straight toward Jesse's chest. "Shut up, old man, or I—"

He didn't finish.

From the sunlit terrace outside, a massive golden foreleg—roughly the thickness of an ancient cedar trunk—reached smoothly through the broken archway. With the gentle, practiced care of someone scooping up a wayward kitten, Goldheart curled his enormous paw around the boy, lifting him six inches clean off the floorboards.

The boy's arms were pinned neatly to his ribs inside a cage of golden, mirror-polished talons. He squirmed. He kicked his heels against empty air. He might as well have been trying to wrestle a mountain range.

Goldheart lowered his enormous horned head into the room. His golden eyes, each the size of a tavern tabletop, blinked down at the suspended thief with mild, grandfatherly reproach. When he exhaled, a warm, fragrant gust of air smelling of cinnamon, summer ozone, and woodsmoke gently ruffled the boy's greasy hair and blew his cap off.

"I wouldn't shoot Jesse if I were you," the dragon rumbled pleasantly, the sound vibrating through the boy's jawbone. "He made that table himself, you know. And when Jesse gets upset, he forgets to put sugar in my tea."

The boy stared into an eye the size of a wagon wheel. His fingers went limp. The machine pistol slipped from his hand and clattered harmlessly against the floorboards. He wondered how a dragon of Goldheart's size could drink a cup of tea.

"Thank you, honoured dragon," the lead Corsair murmured, exhaling in immense relief. Stepping in swiftly, she kicked the pistol into the corner and snapped heavy magnetic cuffs over the kid's wrists as Goldheart gently set him back onto his feet. The elven scout stepped forward with a lead-lined lockbox, popped the humming alien relic inside, and slammed the latches. The thrumming in Jesse's teeth vanished instantly.

The room fell dead silent, save for the tick of the wall clock and the cold wind blowing through the shattered skylight.

Only now, with the fugitive secured, did the two Corsairs seem to fully realize where their chase had ended. They looked around at the vaulted cedar rafters, the stone-faced Craggen, the imposing Sylvan elder, the magistrate shivering on her radiator, and finally up at the colossal golden dragon resting his chin on the balcony.

The lead Corsair hurriedly unlatched her helmet with a sharp hiss of pressurized seals, pulling it off to reveal a soot-streaked face and eyes wide with sudden, flustered mortification. Her posture snapped straight, instantly shifting from hardened void commando to an apologetic schoolchild who had just kicked a ball through the cathedral's finest stained glass.

"Speaker Haddon… Council elders… Honoured Goldheart," she said, her voice dropping into a hasty, respectful bow. "We are… profoundly sorry. For the roof, for the noise, and—most especially—for him. We had him boxed in over the reservoir, but his lateral thruster blew."

Beside her, her partner tilted his head back, stared up through the gaping crater in the ceiling, and muttered under his breath: "Fuck me, is that coming out of our paycheck?"

"Shut up," she hissed out the side of her mouth, bowing even lower toward Jesse. "The Corsair Oversight Committee will cover all structural damages, of course. Full restitution to the municipal treasury within two weeks."

Jesse looked at the broken glass. Then he looked up through the hole in the ceiling.

Outside, the enormous dark curve of Nimbus was sliding cleanly across the face of the sun. The amber sunlight faded into a soft, bruised violet. Down in the square, the gas streetlamps lit with a series of muffled *pops*, their yellow flames flickering in the chilly mountain breeze. *The Pause* had begun.

Jesse picked up the handle of his broken gavel and tapped it against the cedar stump.

"Take him down to the cellar lockup," Jesse said wearily. "Council is adjourned for the eclipse. We'll vote on the sewage pipes once the sun comes back."

Goldheart purred, tucked his great golden snout under his wing on the terrace, and went to sleep in the dark.

CHARACTER CREATION & ADVANCEMENT

Your character is your avatar in the world of Corsair. They are the protagonist of the stories you forge across the Sovereign Moons, and their attributes, learned skills, neural rig chassis, and tactical traits determine their survival on the high frontier.

In Corsair, characters are licensed peacekeepers, warrant-holders, or independent contractors operating under high-stakes institutional oversight. Before distributing attributes, the group decides on the campaign's **Mode of Play**, establishing your crew's legal authority, starship access, and relationship with sponsors.

THE 7-STEP CREATION SEQUENCE

Building an operative follows seven structured operational steps:

1. **1. Mode of Play & Sponsor:** Establish your legal standing (*Freelancers*, *Corsairs*, or *Rogue Corsairs*) and patron.
2. **2. Lineage (Race):** Choose your biological background among the ten lineages of the Sphere.
3. **3. Class MANTLE Chassis:** Choose your cybernetic rig (*Conduit*, *Hazard*, *Pilot*, *Vanguard*, *Weaver*), distribute 7 Class Creation Points, and select an Ability Package.
4. **4. Core Attributes & Derived Stats:** Spend 10 Creation Points across the six Core Attributes (rated 1 to 5), then derive **Endurance** and **Willpower**.
5. **5. Starter Kit & Load Capacity:** Select armor, weapons, and utility rigs within your Max Load: $12 + (\text{STR} \times 2)$.
6. **6. Starting Credits:** Bank your initial allowance of **5,000 Credits**.
7. **7. Starting XP (Skills & Traits):** Spend your Experience Points (6 XP base; 10 XP Humans; 8 XP Hybrids) on Skills (Levels 1–2) and tactical Traits.

MODES OF PLAY

1. FREELANCERS (ASPIRANTS)

- **Status & Resources:** Independent contractors with **no Sponsor** and **no starship**.
- **Campaign Premise:** Operating at ground level. Taking dirt-side security gigs, habitat contracts, bounties, or salvage jobs, operatives rely on passenger liners, cargo transports, and shuttles to travel between moons.
- **Crew Objective:** Building reputation, amassing credits for their own hull, or catching the attention of a major power for a formal charter. Skip the Sponsor step.

2. CORSAIRS (CHARTERED CELL)

- **Status & Resources:** Commissioned peacekeepers with an official cross-jurisdictional legal mandate, **individual Sponsors**, and a shared **Corsair Starship** (such as an RF "Kestrel").
- **Campaign Premise:** The standard Corsair experience. Autonomous cells dispatched to investigate incidents, enforce inter-jurisdictional law, conduct tactical strikes, and resolve geopolitical crises.
- **Sponsor Selection:** Each player chooses an active **Sponsor**. To maintain impartiality, it is recommended that **each player selects a different sponsor**.

3. ROGUE CORSAIRS (OUTLAWS)

- **Status & Resources:** Outlaws with **ex-sponsors** and an unregistered, jury-rigged **ship** (such as a GVI "Rusty Hook").
- **Campaign Premise:** Former Corsairs whose mandates were revoked. The crew takes on questionable contracts—black-market salvage, smuggling, shadow ops, and privateering—while dodging patrol cutters.

SPONSORS & JURISDICTIONS

Depending on your Mode of Play, select a **Sponsor** (for *Corsairs*) or an **Ex-Sponsor** (for *Rogue Corsairs*). Each player should ideally represent a distinct faction:

- **Flotilla:** The independent interstellar defense force. Focuses on fleet defense, orbital integrity, anti-piracy, and peacekeeping.
- **Colonial:** Planetary administrations across the Sovereign Moons. Focuses on territorial law, colonial defense, and resource stability.
- **Corporate:** Multi-system megacorporations. Focuses on corporate intelligence, trade protection, asset recovery, and security.
- **Civilian:** Labor unions, scientific consortiums, and NGOs. Focuses on worker rights, research ethics, and refugee relief.
- **Private:** Wealthy oligarchs or dynasties. Focuses on private collections, high-stakes personal vendettas, and shadow influence.

LINEAGES OF THE SPHERE

Over five centuries of isolation under varied radiation, centrifugal spin, and atmospheres, Newcomer civilization diversified into distinct biological lineages. Your lineage grants attribute adjustments or bonus starting XP:

HUMAN

Adaptable, ambitious, and widespread across every habitat. Possess cognitive versatility. Gain **+4 XP** at creation (total starting pool of **10 XP**).

CRAGGEN

Stout, small-sized humanoids with mineral-dense skin and gemstone eyes. Hardened in dense mine-vaults. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Finesse** and **Knowledge** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

NAGA

Cold-blooded, bipedal reptilians with vibrant cranial crests. Exceptional reaction speeds and thermal awareness. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Agility** and **Instinct** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

SYLVAN

Imposing, powerful humanoids marked by manes, tusks, and chlorophyllic skin. Biochemically robust. Gain **+2 points** distributed between **Strength** and **Presence** (+2/+0, +1/+1, or +0/+2).

DRAKELING

Nimble, scaly humanoids with swept horns and serpentine tails. Reptilian reflex with human drive. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**.

ELF

Graceful, slender humanoids with pointed ears and chlorophyllic pigmentation. Sylvan resilience with human social drive. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**.

GNOME

Inquisitive, slender humanoids with iridescent eye/hair pigmentation. Natural curiosity and technical dexterity. Gain **+2 XP** (8 XP total), plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

DWARF

Dense, subterranean humanoids combining crystalline deposits with reinforced frames. Sylvan bulk with Craggen endurance. Gain **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**, plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

KOBOLD

Cunning reptilians crowned with natural bone masks. Naga reflexes with Craggen precision. Gain **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**, plus **+1 Finesse** or **+1 Knowledge**.

TROLL

Towering, horned humanoids with thick hides and tusks. Sylvan mass with Naga predatory instincts. Gain **+1 Strength** or **+1 Presence**, plus **+1 Agility** or **+1 Instinct**.

> **RACIAL BONUS TIMING**
>
> Racial attribute adjustments are applied prior to Creation Point distribution. Stepping an Attribute from 4 to 5 always costs 2 Creation Points regardless of racial bonuses.

CORE ATTRIBUTES

Every operative is defined by six Core Attributes representing baseline physical conditioning and cognitive capacity on a scale from 1 to 10 (with 1 being standard untrained ability and 10 representing peak potential).

PHYSICAL ATTRIBUTES

- **Strength:** Muscular force, skeletal leverage, and athletic power. Used for forcing jammed bulkhead seals, grappling opponents, wielding heavy ordnance, and carrying combat loads.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, kinesthetic coordination, and physical reflexes. Crucial for dodging fire, vaulting obstacles, and zero-gravity maneuvering.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, fine motor skills, and surgical hand-eye coordination. Used for precision marksmanship, field surgery, lockpicking, and delicate electronics work.

MENTAL ATTRIBUTES

- **Knowledge:** Technical education, data analysis, and memory recall. Used for slicing computer nodes, repairing starship reactors, and deciphering Precursor archives.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, commanding bearing, and social resolve. Vital for interrogations, diplomatic de-escalation, and tactical command.
- **Instinct:** Gut intuition, situational awareness, and split-second subconscious perception. Used for spotting concealed ambushes, reading body language, and reacting to surprise hazards.

DERIVED ATTRIBUTES

From your Core Attributes, calculate two vital derived ratings:

- **Endurance:** Physical resilience and pain tolerance. Equal to your **second-highest Physical Attribute** (Strength, Agility, or Finesse).
- **Willpower:** Mental fortitude, stress management, and emotional resistance. Equal to your **second-highest Mental Attribute** (Knowledge, Presence, or Instinct).

DISTRIBUTING CREATION POINTS

All six Core Attributes start at a baseline rating of **1** (`1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1`). You have **10 Creation Points** to distribute:

- Increasing an Attribute from **1 to 4** costs **1 point** per increase.
- Increasing an Attribute from **4 to 5** costs **2 points**.
- **Starting Cap:** The maximum rating for any Core Attribute at creation is **5**.

CLASS CHASSIS (MANTLE RIG)

Your Class is a proprietary **MANTLE** (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—an aerospace-grade cybernetic or technological chassis interfacing directly with your nervous system via a permanent **Neural Control Chip (NCC)** and spinal shunt.

Due to neural bandwidth limits, an operative can have only **one active MANTLE chassis equipped at a time**.

THE FIVE STARTING CHASSIS

- **Conduit:** Elemental shock trooper channeling electrical and thermal volatility. *Class Attributes:* Flame, Frost, Lightning.
- **Hazard:** Combat alchemist armed with a pressurized Catalyst Chamber. *Class Attributes:* Venom, Hazard, Serum.
- **Pilot:** Neuro-synced exoskeleton and autonomous exodrone operator. *Class Attributes:* Power, Speed, Precision.
- **Vanguard:** High-mobility frontline breaker with a morphing kinetic board. *Class Attributes:* Shield, Glider, Cannon.
- **Weaver:** Nanite artisan manipulating a living fluid swarm. *Class Attributes:* Create, Control, Modify.

CLASS ATTRIBUTES BUDGET

All three Class Attributes start at **1** (`1 / 1 / 1`). Spend **7 Class Creation Points** to increase them (1 to 4 costs 1 point; 4 to 5 costs 2 points; starting cap is 5). Select **one starting Class Ability Package** from your class chapter.

STARTER KIT & OUTFITTING

Every operative receives standard survival gear for life on the fringe, including tactical communications, protective armor, weapons, and a specialized utility rig.

THE LOAD CAPACITY SYSTEM

All gear is governed by the **Load** system, representing mass, bulk, and holstering awkwardness. An operative's carrying limit is determined directly by their physical power:

> **Maximum Load Capacity = 12 + (Strength × 2)**

This capacity is an absolute operational limit; an operative cannot carry gear exceeding this value under any circumstances. Reserve spare Load for field salvage, power cells, and munitions.

1. UNIVERSAL COMMUNICATIONS

- **1 Commlink** (Load 0 | Long-Range Tactical Comms).

2. PERSONAL ARMOR (CHOOSE 1)

- **Padded Flightsuit** (Protection 2 | Load 1) — *Lightweight, pressurized jumpsuit with minimal bulk.*
- **Armored Jacket** (Protection 3 | Load 2) — *Durable ballistic coat lined with reinforced composite inserts.*

3. MELEE WEAPON (CHOOSE 1)

Select one melee tier your **Strength** satisfies (1H weapons require two hands if below Min STR). Pick the damage type matching your favored attribute pair:

- **Piercing (Agility + Finesse):** Adds lower of Agility or Finesse to damage.
- **Slashing (Agility + Strength):** Adds lower of Agility or Strength to damage.
- **Striking (Strength + Finesse):** Adds lower of Strength or Finesse to damage.

Light Melee (Min STR 1 | Load 1/2 | Dmg +0):

- Shiv / Stiletto (Piercing)
- Combat Knife (Slashing)
- Knuckleduster (Striking)

Tactical Melee (Min STR 2 | Load 1 | Dmg +1):

- Dagger (Piercing)
- Hatchet / Machete (Slashing)
- Baton / Club (Striking)

Heavy Melee (Min STR 3 | Load 2 | Dmg +2):

- Shortsword (Piercing)
- Boarding Axe (Slashing)
- Mace / Crowbar (Striking)

4. FIREARM (CHOOSE 1)

Select one firearm based on desired engagement range. Ranged tests always pair weapon **Accuracy** at the target's range band with **Finesse**:

Close-Quarters (Short Range: 0–5 spaces / ~0–20m):

- **Service Pistol:** 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +1 | RoF 1 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / -
- **Compact SMG:** 2H | Load 2 | Dmg +1 | RoF 2 | Acc: 4 / 3 / 1 / -
- **Combat Shotgun:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +3 | RoF 1 | Acc: 4 / 3 / 0 / -

Mid-Range & General (Medium Range: 6–12 spaces / ~20–40m):

- **Heavy Revolver:** 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +2 | RoF 0 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / -
- **Assault Carbine:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +2 | RoF 2 | Acc: 3 / 3 / 2 / 1
- **Assault Rifle:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +2 | RoF 2 | Acc: 2 / 4 / 3 / 1

Long-Range & Standoff (Long/Extreme: 13–20+ spaces / ~40–80+m):

- **Battle Rifle:** 2H | Load 3 | Dmg +4 | RoF 0 | Acc: 2 / 3 / 4 / 2
- **Marksman Rifle (DMR):** 2H | Load 4 | Dmg +4 | RoF 1 | Acc: 1 / 3 / 5 / 3
- **Sniper Rifle:** 2H | Load 4 | Dmg +5 | RoF 0 | Acc: 0 / 2 / 5 / 4

5. SPECIALIZED UTILITY KIT (CHOOSE 1)

- **Medic Kit:** 1 Field Medi-Kit (Medicine 3 | Cap 3 | Lesser Physical) & 1 Neuro-Stabilizer Inhaler (Medicine 3 | Cap 3 | Lesser Mental).
- **Grenadier Kit:** 1 Tactical Grenade Rig (Cap 3) & 1 Grenade Launcher Rig (Medium Range | Load 2).
- **Techie Kit:** 1 "Spider" Cyberdeck (Interfacing 3, Hacking 2 | Load 2) & 1 Proximity Sensor (Scouting 4m | Load 1/2).
- **Mobility Kit:** 1 Standard Grapple Launcher (Mobility 3 | Range 8m | Cap 3) & 1 Gecko Climbing Kit (Surface Adhesion | Load 1).
- **Trench Kit:** 1 Deployable Cover (Medium Cover +2 | 24 HP | Load 3) & 1 Mechanic's Kit (Tinkering 2, Locksmith 2 | Load 2).

STARTING CREDITS

Every operative begins with **5,000 Credits** to purchase additional specialized ordnance, reserve ammunition, or bank for operational expenses.

SKILLS & STARTING EXPERIENCE

While Attributes represent raw physical and mental power, Skills represent trained operational expertise in specific fields, providing reliable Upgrades when the pressure mounts.

SKILL RATINGS & UPGRADES

Skills are rated from 1 to 3. When you make a test using the Attribute Pair associated with your skill, you automatically receive a number of **Upgrades** equal to your skill rating:

- **Skill Level 1:** Trained operative. You receive **+1 Upgrade** on relevant tests.
- **Skill Level 2:** Seasoned specialist. You receive **+2 Upgrades** on relevant tests.
- **Skill Level 3:** Sector-renowned authority. You receive **+3 Upgrades** on relevant tests.

FLEXIBLE SKILL NAMING

A core feature of the Corsair engine is narrative flexibility. You are encouraged to invent descriptive, character-defining names for your skills. The only mechanical rule is that the skill must logically connect to its assigned Attribute Pair:

- **Accuracy + Finesse:** *Gunslinging, Precision Marksmanship, Standoff Sniping.*
- **Finesse + Agility:** *Zero-G Acrobatics, Sleight of Hand, Blade Dancer.*
- **Knowledge + Presence:** *Corporate Law, Crisis De-escalation, Xeno-Linguistics, Tactical Analysis.*
- **Strength + Agility:** *Boarding Breacher, Free-Running, Kinetic Wrestling.*
- **Knowledge + Finesse:** *Cyber-Infiltration, Field Surgery, Explosive Ordnance Disposal.*
- **Instinct + Presence:** *Hostage Negotiation, Streetwise Grift, Interrogation.*

While the skill name injects distinct flavor into your character, the mechanical Upgrades apply to **any test** rolled with that Attribute Pair.

STARTING XP BUDGET

Rather than tracking separate pools of skill points and talent slots, characters receive flat **Experience Points (XP)** at creation.

You may spend this starting XP freely to purchase Skills, acquire Traits, or combine both:

- **Baseline Starting Pool: 6 XP**.
- **Human Operatives:** Gain +4 XP for **10 XP total**.
- **Hybrid Lineages (Drakeling, Elf, Gnome):** Gain +2 XP for **8 XP total**.

SKILL COSTS

- **Level 1 Skill:** Costs **2 XP** (+1 Upgrade).
- **Level 2 Skill:** Costs **4 XP** (6 XP cumulative; +2 Upgrades).
- **Level 3 Skill:** Costs **6 XP** (12 XP cumulative; +3 Upgrades).
- **Creation Skill Cap:** The maximum rating for any Skill at character creation is **Level 2** (preserving Level 3 as an elite distinction earned in active play).

PURCHASING TRAITS

Operatives can spend starting XP directly to acquire standalone **Traits** from the catalog. Each Trait has a flat cost between **2 XP and 8 XP** with zero prerequisite tree gatekeeping.

SAMPLE STARTING BUILDS

With a baseline pool of 6 XP, operatives enjoy complete freedom to define their starting tactical profile:

- **The Generalist:** Purchase three separate Level 1 Skills (3 × 2 XP = 6 XP) for broad coverage.
- **The Dedicated Specialist:** Invest all 6 XP into a single signature Level 2 Skill (2 XP + 4 XP = 6 XP).
- **The Pure Tactician:** Purchase standalone Traits, such as *Tough as Nails* (6 XP) or *Brawler* (2 XP) + *Counter Striker* (4 XP).
- **The Balanced Operative:** Combine one Level 1 Skill (2 XP) and one 4 XP Trait (such as *Marksman*, *Iron Will*, or *Healer*).
- **Human Versatility:** A Human with 10 XP can acquire a Level 2 Skill (6 XP) plus two Level 1 Skills (4 XP), or pair a top-tier Trait like *Controlled Blast* (8 XP) with a Level 1 Skill (2 XP).

TRACKING SHEETS

Record your stats, load, and chassis abilities on the official printable **Corsair Character Sheet**. For crews operating a shared vessel, use the **Corsair Crew Sheet** to manage bridge stations, vessel damage, and collective cargo.

CREATION IN ACTION: JAX

To illustrate how the creation sequence operates in practice, here is the complete build walkthrough for **Jax**, a licensed Corsair peacekeeper operating under a Flotilla interdiction warrant:

STEP 1: MODE OF PLAY & SPONSOR

Jax's cell plays a standard **Corsair (Chartered Cell)** campaign aboard an RF "Kestrel" light cutter. Jax selects the **Flotilla** as his sponsor, granting him a lawful cross-jurisdictional warrant to apprehend system fugitives, investigate orbital breaches, and intercept pirate raiders.

STEP 2: LINEAGE (RACE)

Jax is a **Human**. Rather than innate attribute adjustments, Jax receives **+4 bonus starting XP** (for a starting budget of **10 XP**).

STEP 3: CLASS MANTLE CHASSIS

Jax equips the **Vanguard** chassis—a high-mobility frontline rig featuring a morphing kinetic board. His three Class Attributes start at `1 / 1 / 1`. With **7 Class Creation Points**, he allocates:

- **Shield 4** (3 pts from 1 to 4)
- **Cannon 4** (3 pts from 1 to 4)
- **Glider 2** (1 pt from 1 to 2)

Starting Package: He selects the **Vanguard Defense Package** (unlocking *Bulwark Anchor*, *Aegis Intercept*, and *Kinetic Deflection*).

STEP 4: CORE ATTRIBUTES & DERIVED STATS

Jax starts at `1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1 / 1` and allocates his **10 Creation Points**:

- **Strength 4** (3 pts) & **Finesse 4** (3 pts)
- **Agility 3** (2 pts)
- **Knowledge 2** (1 pt) & **Instinct 2** (1 pt)
- **Presence 1** (0 pts)

Derived Stats: Second-highest Physical is **Endurance 4**. Second-highest Mental is **Willpower 2**. Physical Condition tracks have **8 segments each** (4 + 4); Mental tracks have **6 segments each** (4 + 2).

STEP 5: STARTER KIT & LOAD BUDGETING

Carrying limit: $\text{Max Load} = 12 + (\text{STR } 4 \times 2) = 20 \text{ Load}$.

- **Commlink:** Load 0 (Tactical communications).
- **Armored Jacket:** Protection 3 | Load 2.
- **Boarding Axe:** Heavy Melee Slashing | Load 2 | Dmg +2 | Pairs *Agility + Strength*.
- **Heavy Revolver:** Handgun, 1H | Load 1 | Dmg +2 | RoF 0 | Acc: 3 / 2 / 1 / - | Pairs *Accuracy + Finesse*.
- **Trench Kit:** Deployable Cover (Load 3) & Mechanic's Kit (Load 2) = Load 5.

Total Load: 10 / 20 Load (leaving **10 spare Load** for ammo, field salvage, and contraband evidence).

STEP 6: STARTING CREDITS

Jax banks his baseline reserve of **5,000 Credits**.

STEP 7: SKILLS & TRAITS (STARTING XP)

With **10 XP** as a Human, Jax purchases:

- **Skill — Gunslinging 1 (Accuracy + Finesse):** Costs 2 XP (+1 Upgrade on ranged marksmanship tests).
- **Trait — Gunslinger:** Costs 4 XP. Ignores the 3 Downgrades for firing ranged weapons while in Close Quarters Combat (CQC).
- **Trait — Marksman:** Costs 4 XP. Treats targets as 1 Range Band closer or further for weapon Accuracy.

JAX — CHARACTER SUMMARY

Human Corsair | Flotilla Sponsor | Vanguard Chassis Lvl 1
Attributes: STR 4, FIN 4, AGI 3, KNO 2, INS 2, PRE 1
Derived: Endurance 4, Willpower 2 | **Load:** 10 / 20
Class Attributes: Shield 4, Cannon 4, Glider 2
Skills: Gunslinging 1 (Accuracy + Finesse; +1 Upgrade)
Traits: Gunslinger (4 XP), Marksman (4 XP)
Armory: Armored Jacket (Prot 3), Heavy Revolver (Dmg +2), Boarding Axe (Dmg +2), Trench Kit, Commlink | **Credits:** 5,000

CONDITION & TRAUMA

Condition represents an operative's capacity to endure trauma. Instead of tracking an abstract pool of hit points, resilience is divided into two distinct categories: **Physical Condition** and **Mental Condition**.

Physical Condition measures structural bodily integrity against kinetic trauma, thermal burns, and toxins, governed by **Endurance**. **Mental Condition** measures cognitive resilience, emotional fortitude, and sanity under sensory shock and psychological terror, governed by **Willpower**.

THE THREE SEQUENTIAL TRACKS

Both Physical and Mental Condition are divided into three sequential **Tracks** (Track I, Track II, and Track III). Whenever your character suffers damage or mental stress, mark off segments starting on Track I. Once a Track becomes completely full, any subsequent damage naturally overflows into the next Track:

> **Track Capacity = 4 + Derived Attribute**

(4 + Endurance for Physical Tracks; 4 + Willpower for Mental Tracks)

DAMAGE TYPES: LIGHT VS. AGGRAVATED

Damage is tracked as either **Light Wounds** (standard combat fatigue and surface trauma) or **Aggravated Wounds** (severe tissue destruction or psychic fracture):

- **Light Wounds:** Standard damage instances that fill open segments. Readily restored through basic medical supplies and short rests.
- **Aggravated Wounds:** When an incoming source of damage overflows the remaining capacity of a Track, the excess points convert filled Light Wounds on that filled Track into **Aggravated Wounds**. Aggravated Wounds represent deep structural trauma that cannot be healed through basic Lesser Healing.

ATTRIBUTE PENALTIES: IMPAIRED & CRIPPLED

Filling a Condition Track inflicts severe strain on an operative's capabilities:

- **Impaired (Light Wounds):** When a Track is completely filled with Light Wounds, select and mark one corresponding Attribute on your sheet (a Physical Attribute for Physical Tracks, or a Mental Attribute for Mental Tracks). That Attribute becomes **Impaired**. From that moment forward, any test involving that Impaired Attribute suffers **1 Downgrade**.
- **Crippled (Aggravated Wounds):** If an individual Track becomes completely filled with Aggravated Wounds, the marked Attribute becomes **Crippled**. Any test involving a Crippled Attribute suffers **2 Downgrades** instead.

CONSEQUENCES OF FULL CONDITION

Filling all three sequential Tracks brings critical consequences:

- **Physical Collapse:** When all three Physical Tracks are filled with any combination of Light or Aggravated Wounds, your character falls **Unconscious** and cannot act until at least one segment is cleared. If every single segment across all three Physical Tracks becomes filled with **Aggravated Wounds**, your character **Dies**.
- **Mental Breakdown:** When all three Mental Tracks become filled, your character is mentally overwhelmed and **cannot earn or spend Gambit Dice** (though existing Gambit dice remain banked) until at least one segment is cleared. If all three Mental Tracks are filled entirely with **Aggravated Wounds**, your psyche collapses, leaving your character **susceptible to suggestions, commands, and intimidation** in the exact same manner as non-player characters.

HEALING ACROSS SCOPES

Recovery is divided into two distinct medical methodologies based on trauma severity: **Lesser Healing** restores standard Light Wounds, while **Greater Healing** represents intensive medical intervention capable of repairing Aggravated Wounds.

Opportunities for recovery depend directly on the scene's pacing:

- **Moment-to-Moment Pacing:** Under active fire, healing is restricted to rapid tactical items (such as Field Medi-Kits, Neuro-Stabilizers, or class chems), functioning according to their specific item capacity.
- **Place-to-Place Pacing (Short Rest):** When the cell catches its breath during exploration, operatives access Lesser Healing through a Short Rest. Roll a **Success Test** using **Endurance + Willpower**. For every **2 Success Points** generated (rounded down), heal 1 Light Wound segment on Physical or Mental Condition.
- **Day-to-Day Pacing (Long Rest):** During extended downtime, operatives gain access to Greater Healing. Roll a **Success Test** using **Endurance + Willpower**. Generated Success Points can be allocated freely:
  - **1 Success Point:** Heals 1 Light Wound segment.
  - **2 Success Points:** Clears 1 Aggravated Wound segment.

  Dedicated ship medbays and planetary clinics provide additional diagnostic bonuses.

CONDITION & RECOVERY IN ACTION

During a fierce orbital warehouse raid, Jax takes **8 physical damage** from a close-range shotgun blast. Jax has an **Endurance of 3**, giving his Physical Condition three sequential Tracks of **7 segments each** (4 + 3).

The first 7 points of damage fill **Track I** completely with Light Wounds. Jax marks his **Strength** Attribute as **Impaired**, meaning any future test involving Strength suffers **1 Downgrade**.

The 1 point of overflow damage turns 1 Light Wound on Track I into an **Aggravated Wound** (leaving Track I with 6 Light Wounds and 1 Aggravated Wound). Any subsequent damage will now overflow into Track II.

Later, back aboard their cutter during a **Long Rest**, Jax makes an **Endurance (3) + Willpower (2)** Success Test rolled with his lower Attribute (**Willpower 2**), rolling `[4, 9]`. The `9` yields **9 base Success Points**.

Jax spends **2 Success Points** to clear the 1 Aggravated Wound on Track I (costing 2 SP per segment), and spends **6 Success Points** to heal the remaining 6 Light Wounds on Track I (costing 1 SP per segment).

Because Track I is completely cleared and no longer full, Jax removes the **Impaired** condition from his Strength Attribute, restoring his rolls to full baseline capability.

TRAITS CATALOG

Beyond raw Attributes and learned Skills, operatives are defined by unique Traits—specialized operational doctrines, combat reflexes, and tactical habits forged on the fringe.

Traits grant distinctive mechanical exceptions, alter action economies, enhance team coordination, or unlock decisive reactions.

ACQUIRING TRAITS

Operatives acquire Traits by spending **Experience Points (XP)**. Each Trait is an independent asset with a flat XP cost between 2 XP and 8 XP. There are no prerequisite trees or artificial gatekeeping:

- **Character Creation:** Spend your starting XP pool (6 XP base; 8 XP hybrids; 10 XP humans) on any Traits.
- **Campaign Advancement:** Spend earned mission XP during day-to-day downtime training to unlock new Traits permanently.

TRAITS IN ACTION: CATWALK INTERDICTION

Jax breaches an orbital cargo bay holding the **Duelist** (3 XP) and **Counter Striker** (4 XP) Traits.

Rushing onto an isolated gantry to intercept an outlaw enforcer, Jax and the target are the only occupants on that space, immediately activating **Duelist** for **+2 Upgrades** on his melee strike.

When the outlaw counter-attacks with a combat knife rolling a single Hit (an 8), Jax spends 1 AP to react with a **Contest Roll**, rolling `[4, 7, 9]`. Scoring a `9`, Jax eliminates the outlaw's Hit. Thanks to **Counter Striker**, Jax doesn't just parry—he redirects the blade's momentum to deal **9 damage** (his highest contest die) directly to the attacker.

MELEE COMBAT TRAITS

Optimized for hand-to-hand engagements, boarding operations, and close-quarters scuffles:

BRAWLER

Cost: 2 XP

You cannot be outnumbered in melee; hostile creatures gain no Upgrades from Outnumbering when attacking you.

COMBO MASTER

Cost: 5 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform an additional melee attack (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

COUNTER STRIKER

Cost: 4 XP

If you fully eliminate all Hits when contesting a melee attack, you can deal damage to one attacking creature equal to the highest value you rolled on the **Contest Roll**.

DUELIST

Cost: 3 XP

You gain +2 **Upgrades** on all melee attacks and contests against a creature in your space if you two are the only ones occupying that space.

INTERCEPTOR

Cost: 2 XP

When you successfully contest a creature's movement, you can deal damage to that creature equal to the highest value you rolled on the **Contest Roll**.

STRIKER

Cost: 3 XP

Your unarmed attacks deal bonus damage equal to your **Endurance**.

RANGED COMBAT & ORDNANCE

These traits refine firearms handling, tactical marksmanship, and the lethal deployment of heavy explosives under suppressive fire.

MARKSMAN

Cost: 4 XP

You can treat your target as being one **Range Band** closer or further for the purpose of determining weapon **Accuracy**.

RAPID FIRE

Cost: 6 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform an additional ranged attack (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

GUNSLINGER

Cost: 4 XP

You ignore the 3 Downgrades for firing a ranged weapon while engaged in Close Quarters Combat (CQC).

SHARPSHOOTER

Cost: 7 XP

You ignore Protection bonuses granted by cover and the 2 Downgrades from firing into Close Quarters Combat (CQC).

BOMBARDIER

Cost: 3 XP

When you activate a **Crit Effect** on a test made with Ordnance, each spent Hit increases Success Points (damage) by +3 instead of +2.

CONTROLLED BLAST

Cost: 8 XP

When you use an item or ability that deals damage to all creatures in one or more spaces, you can choose any number of creatures in the area of effect to be completely unaffected by the blast.

DEFENSE & RESILIENCE

Bolstering physical endurance, mental grit, and bodyguard interception when under heavy hostile barrage.

BODYGUARD

Cost: 5 XP

When you contest an attack targeting an ally in your space, you gain +2 **Upgrades** on your **Contest Roll**.

IRON WILL

Cost: 4 XP

You gain +2 **Willpower**. This does not increase any other Attributes.

STOIC

Cost: 5 XP

You gain Mental Protection equal to your **Willpower**.

LIGHTNING REFLEXES

Cost: 8 XP

Once per round, you can contest one incoming attack targeting you without spending an Action Point (0 AP).

TOUGH AS NAILS

Cost: 6 XP

You gain +2 **Endurance**. This does not increase any other Attributes.

THICK SKIN

Cost: 7 XP

You gain Physical Protection equal to your **Endurance** while not wearing armor.

STEALTH & INFILTRATION

Specialized doctrines for operatives moving through enemy sensor sweeps and ventilation shafts.

SEASONED STALKER

Cost: 5 XP

If the turn ends with you hidden from all non-ally creatures, you can pay one **Gambit** die to take one more action, paying its Action Point cost (1 AP) as normal.

SNEAK ATTACK

Cost: 3 XP

When you make an attack against a creature that has not detected you yet, the attack deals +3 bonus damage.

MEDICAL & FIELD SUPPORT

HEALER

Cost: 4 XP

Once per round, when you heal your own or another creature's Physical or Mental Condition, you can heal one additional segment.

TEAMWORK & LEADERSHIP

Synchronizing fireteams, executing delayed actions, and pooling tactical momentum.

COORDINATOR

Cost: 3 XP

When you take part in a **Teamwork** Action, every other participant receives 1 **Upgrade**.

LEADER

Cost: 5 XP

Once per round, when you take part in a **Teamwork** Action, a chosen ally can join the action without spending an Action Point (0 AP).

PLANNER

Cost: 3 XP

When two or more Delayed Actions are triggered in the same turn, you gain a d10 **Gambit** die.

HEART OF THE TEAM

Cost: 4 XP

Allies can freely transfer any Gambit dice they earn to your **Gambit** pool, and you can transfer **Gambit** dice from your pool to allies whenever they are eligible to spend Gambit.

SOCIAL & NEGOTIATION

CLOSER

Cost: 5 XP

You can spend one **Gambit** die to perform a test that involves communication (paying 1 AP as normal), even if the Player Turn would normally end.

IMPRESSIVE

Cost: 2 XP

Your first social interaction test with a creature you have never met before gains +1 **Upgrade**.

GAMBIT & MOMENTUM

CALLED SHOT

Cost: 4 XP

When you add a **Gambit** die to a dice pool before rolling, you can re-roll that **Gambit** die once after the roll.

DOUBLE DOWN

Cost: 5 XP

When you spend two or more **Gambit** dice on a single test, those **Gambit** dice step up to d12s.

DRAW TWO

Cost: 4 XP

When you earn a **Gambit** die, if your **Gambit** pool was previously empty, you gain an additional d8 **Gambit** die.

CHARACTER ADVANCEMENT

As operatives execute warrants, survive firefights, and navigate corporate intrigues, they accumulate Experience Points (XP) to advance their innate capabilities.

EARNING EXPERIENCE POINTS

XP is earned through two primary engines: **operational missions** and **downtime training**.

MISSIONS & CONTRACT TIERS

When a cell successfully completes an operational warrant, each participating operative receives a flat XP award based on threat tier:

CONTRACT THREAT TIERS & REWARDS

TIER	SCOPE & THREAT LEVEL	XP AWARD	REPUTATION
Tier 1	Local interdictions, precinct patrol, minor asset recovery	**+4 XP**	+1 to +2 Rep
Tier 2	Cross-jurisdictional strikes, black-ops, hostile boardings	**+8 XP**	+3 to +5 Rep
Tier 3	Systemic crises, Precursor incursions, fleet actions	**+12 XP**	+7 to +10 Rep

DOWNTIME TRAINING DRILLS

Between contracts, operatives can spend downtime studying tactical theory or practicing combat drills. Spending **1 Day-to-Day Action Point (AP)** on training awards **1 XP**.

- **Strict Daily Limit:** To reflect biological conditioning limits, an operative can earn a **maximum of 1 XP from Training per 24-hour round** (spending at most 1 Day-to-Day AP on training). The remaining 2 AP must be allocated to other activities (medical rest, starship maintenance, odd jobs, personal research).
- **Closing the Gap:** Downtime training serves primarily to top off the final 1 or 2 XP needed for a new Trait, Skill rank, or Attribute increase before deployment.

IMPROVING ATTRIBUTES

To improve an Attribute, pay XP equal to **three times the new target level**. You can only advance one level at a time:

ATTRIBUTE ADVANCEMENT COSTS

TARGET LEVEL	XP REQUIRED	NARRATIVE CAPABILITY SCALE
Level 2	6 XP	Basic operational competency.
Level 3	9 XP	Standard field agent proficiency.
Level 4	12 XP	Highly trained veteran specialist.
Level 5	15 XP	Elite sector-level capability.
Level 6	18 XP	Master-class human conditioning.
Level 7	21 XP	Peak biological performance.
Level 8	24 XP	The absolute physical/cybernetic limit.

LEARNING & UPGRADING SKILLS

To learn or improve a Skill, pay XP equal to **two times the new target level**. Advance one level at a time:

SKILL ADVANCEMENT COSTS

TARGET LEVEL	XP REQUIRED	FIELD COMPETENCY SCALE
Level 1	2 XP	Basic field familiarity (+1 Upgrade).
Level 2	4 XP	Advanced specialist standard (+2 Upgrades).
Level 3	6 XP	Elite master-class authority (+3 Upgrades).

CHASSIS HARDWARE UPGRADES

In Corsair, your Class is manufactured hardware interfacing with your neural port—not biological experience. Consequently, chassis do not advance via XP.

Operatives upgrade their MANTLE chassis by financing precision biomedical retrofits, micro-machined parts, and firmware overclocks with **Credits** during day-to-day downtime.

STANDARDIZED CHASSIS PROGRESSION

All five MANTLE chassis follow an identical five-tier upgrade path:

CHASSIS LEVEL PROGRESSION

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	COST	MILESTONE
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (1/1/1 base), Starting Package, Engine	**Free***	Commissioning as an operative.
Level 2	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Cr**	Field-tested optimization.
Level 3	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Ability Package	**40,000 Cr**	Unlocks first signature overclock.
Level 4	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package (All Packages Unlocked)	**75,000 Cr**	Complete omnirole flexibility.
Level 5	+1 Class Attribute Point, +1 Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Cr**	Dual-overclock peak capability.

*The Level 1 chassis chosen at character creation is free. Purchasing an additional chassis during downtime costs 100,000 Credits.

CLASS MODS (HARDWARE OVERCLOCKS)

Class Mods represent high-end firmware alterations and mechanical customizations that bend the chassis's core operating rules:

- **Fixed Cost:** Each Class Mod costs **25,000 Credits**.
- **Mod Sockets:** Operatives unlock **Mod Slot 1 at Level 3** and **Mod Slot 2 at Level 5**, supporting up to two active mods simultaneously per chassis.
- **Swapping Mods:** Operatives can freely swap between owned mods during day-to-day downtime at zero cost.

CHASSIS OWNERSHIP & SWAPPING

Due to metabolic strain and neural bandwidth limits, an operative can have **only one active chassis equipped at a time**.

During downtime, an operative can purchase additional chassis frames for **100,000 Credits** each and calibrate them to their neural port. Upgraded levels, attribute ratings, and installed mods are tied to each physical chassis frame and are permanently preserved whenever an operative swaps suits in the hangar.

> **THE CREDIT ECONOMY BALANCE**
>
> Because gear, starship components, and chassis levels all compete for earned contract Credits, players face meaningful strategic decisions between buying heavy ordnance, upgrading their personal MANTLE frame, or investing in the cell's shared starship.

CELL ADVANCEMENT & STANDING

While individual operatives advance their personal conditioning and gear, the Corsair Cell also possesses its own collective advancement system.

The Cell is both an asset and an investment in the eyes of its Sponsors. Cells hold a letter-grade clearance rank from **Grade D to Grade S**, advancing based on accumulated **Reputation**.

THE REPUTATION LADDER

Crossing reputation thresholds triggers a formal **Rank Evaluation** with your Sponsors:

RANK PROMOTION REWARDS & CLEARANCES

RANK	REP	DISCRETIONARY BONUS	SHIP FUNDS	MARKET CLEARANCE
Grade D	0–14	—	—	Greenhorn charter; local contracts.
Grade C	15 Rep	$20,000 Cr / op	$5,000,000 Cr	Regional trade networks, commercial hull mods.
Grade B	40 Rep	$45,000 Cr / op	$10,000,000 Cr	Restricted EW packages, medium frigate hulls.
Grade A	75 Rep	$75,000 Cr / op	$25,000,000 Cr	Military spinal mounts, heavy destroyers.
Grade S	120 Rep	$100,000 Cr / op	$50,000,000 Cr	Sponsor black-tech, flagship-tier hulls.

Discretionary Bonuses are distributed directly to each operative. **Ship Funds** are restricted strictly to purchasing, repairing, and refitting the cell's starship.

POST-GRADE S PRESTIGE: THE LEGEND CYCLE

Achieving Grade S represents the summit of the Sphere's operational hierarchy. To reward continued legendary service:

- **The Legend Cycle:** Every time a Grade S Cell accumulates an additional **+30 Reputation** beyond the 120 baseline (e.g., hitting 150, 180, 210 Rep), they trigger a **Prestige Evaluation**.
- **The Recurring Payday:** Clearing this evaluation grants each operative a fresh **$100,000 Credit Discretionary Bonus**, and injects **$20,000,000 Credits** into the ship fund.
- **High Stakes:** Reputation losses are doubled for an active Grade S Cell.

REPUTATION FLUX & DEMOTIONS

Reputation is volatile and reflects institutional trust:

- **Mission Rewards:** Tier 1 (+1 Rep), Tier 2 (+3 Rep), Tier 3 (+7 Rep), with sponsor bonus consensus adding up to +1 to +3 Rep.
- **Objective Failure:** -2 to -5 Rep (asset destroyed, target escapes).
- **Illegal Activity:** -3 to -8 Rep (caught operating outside mandate).
- **Sponsor Slight:** -1 to -3 Rep (defying sponsor directives).
- **Idle Penalties:** If a full **5-Day Upkeep Cycle** passes without completing a contract, standing decays.
- **Rank Demotions:** If Reputation drops below a rank threshold, the cell enters a 1-cycle grace period to restore standing. Failing to recover strips the rank. A cell falling below Grade D is expelled from the Corsair program.

THE MATHEMATICS OF THE GREAT TITHE

A CORSAIR STORY • FICTION INTERLUDE

The primary difficulty with possessing four arms, Skrix had long concluded, was that it gave the universe four distinct opportunities to make you drop something valuable.

Floating in the zero-gravity cargo hold of the *Rust-Weevil*, Skrix used his two upper hands to cling stubbornly to an overhead structural pipe while his two lower hands wrestled with a rusty iron pry-bar. His multifaceted compound eyes, each made of three thousand iridescent hexagonal lenses, twitched with focused irritation as he attempted to unjam the lid of a dented steel crate. Around him, the air smelled of scorched insulation, old sweat, and the sharp, sour tang of cheap hydrazine thruster exhaust—the universal scent of Scavenger domesticity.

"Mind the seal, Skrix," muttered Krikk, who was suspended upside-down three feet away, his magnetic boot-clamps locked onto the ribbed steel deck-plate. Krikk was young, had an unbroken glossy sheen to his dark-brown chitin, and still possessed that tragic, starry-eyed optimism common to third-tier raiders who had not yet been shot in the thorax. "The Raiding Captain said if we dent the casing, he's deducting two marks of ration chits from our tally."

"The Raiding Captain," Skrix rasped, his lower mandibles clicking together in a dry, rhythmic clatter that sounded like two dry sticks being snapped in an empty tin, "can take his *krskva* ration chits and shove them straight up his *skvskrsk*. Sideways, if he prefers. Without grease, if he insists on this being finished before the third shift."

With a screech of protesting iron, the crate lid popped free, drifting lazily into the center of the hold.

Inside, cushioned in layers of scorched thermal insulation, lay the true prize of their lightning raid on a frontier research dig along the Wanabo border: an intact Precursor catalytic core. To the ivory-tower physicists at the Sphere Research Center, it was a priceless impossibility—a brick-sized slab of seamless black glass whose non-baryonic lattice resonated with the diffuse dark matter halo of the Sphere, silently transmuting invisible cosmic mass into a steady, boundless flow of direct electrical current. To Skrix and Krikk, it was something far simpler and infinitely more sacred: a battery that never ran dry. You could clamp copper leads to either pole of the cold glass, bolt it into the belly of an asteroid scow, and run life-support scrubbers, target radars, and railgun capacitor banks for two centuries without burning a single droplet of precious helium-3 fuel. Right now, it pulsed with a slow, dull violet rhythm that made the magnetic clamps on Skrix's boots tingle—pulled straight from a freshly unearthed Vault trench before the Sphere Research Center could slap their quarantine beacons on it.

And stuffed around the edges—crammed into the empty corners by two greedy grunts while the perimeter sirens were still wailing—lay the common salvage they had snatched for personal keeping: seven copper water-pipe elbows, a cracked diagnostic slate, a spool of braided wire, and four dented cans of preserved Landfall peaches in heavy syrup.

Krikk's antennae stood straight up in predatory excitement. His upper claws reached reverently toward the black glass, but his lower claws drifted immediately toward the food.

"Look at that catalytic core, Skrix! Pure Vault stock! The Collector himself will sing through the comms when the Chief slides that down the chute! And real fruit! Skrix, by the holy chitin of the Maker, between the relic bounty and the scrap, we're going to buy ourselves onto the second deck! I'm taking one of the peach tins. I've never tasted fruit that didn't come out of a nutrient paste injector."

Skrix sighed—a wet, rattling hiss that escaped through six thoracic spiracles along his ribcage. He reached down with his lower-left claw, plucked the boy's reaching hand out of the air, and shoved him back toward his tether.

"You are not taking the peaches, Krikk. You are not taking the wire. The core belongs to the Chief the second we clear the airlock, and if you are exceptionally lucky with the rest, you might be allowed to keep three shavings of copper dust to scrape between your molars for flavor."

"That's against the rules!" Krikk protested, his four hands waving in symmetrical indignation. "We were the breach-runners! We bled for this salvage! The rules say raiders get fifty percent of whatever personal pickings they haul out!"

"The rules," Skrix said patiently, wrapping a frayed webbing strap around the copper pipes so they wouldn't float into the ventilation grille, "were written by someone who had four arms, six eyes, and an immense ledger, and who was standing behind a reinforced blast bulkhead twelve decks above your head. Allow me to explain the holy mathematics of the Great Tithe, as revealed to our ancestors by the Collector himself."

Skrix held up the four cans of peaches, two in each upper hand, like a priest demonstrating the mysteries of the cosmos to an especially dim-witted acolyte.

"There are four cans," Skrix began. "A clean, harmonious number. You and I bled for them. Therefore, we present them to Raiding Captain Vorash alongside the Vault relic. Captain Vorash looks at the four cans and immediately discovers that the holy cause requires two of them. One for ship's maintenance—because hydrazine doesn't grow on space rocks—and one as the Captain's Discretionary Tithe, which he will eat while watching us scrub the bilge on the bridge camera. That leaves two cans."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "One for you, one for me."

"Do not gallop ahead of the theology," Skrix snapped, tapping Krikk on the head with the flat of the pry-bar. "Captain Vorash does not own this bucket of rust. The *Rust-Weevil* belongs to Clan Vrag-Kresh. When we dock at the Outward Spire of the Hoard, Clan Chief Gresh-Mor will board the vessel with eight enforcers wearing powered carapaces. The Chief will take the Precursor core—naturally—and then he will inspect our remaining two cans. He will explain that Clan Vrag-Kresh is currently in an expensive trade dispute with the Iron Fang cartel over salvage rights to a derelict ore barge, and therefore the Clan requires a mandatory fifty percent sovereignty tax on all personal scrap. There goes the third can."

Krikk's antennae drooped, folding flat against the crown of his carapace. "Leaving... one can."

"Leaving one can," Skrix agreed somberly. "And then, young Krikk, comes the majesty of creation itself. Our great, sprawling, glorious junk-world: the Hoard. A moon made entirely of four centuries of stolen titanium, twisted bulkheads, dormant Precursor coils, and crushed dreams, all orbiting the outer dark like a massive, metallic tumor. At the center of the Hoard sits the Collector."

Skrix paused, bowing his head slightly and making the ceremonial four-fingered sign of the Clasped Fist over his primary heart.

"Our father. A veritable God of Greed. An immortal cosmic intelligence capable of calculating the trajectory of every photon in the cluster, who uses that unfathomable intellect to catalog every bent nail and canned peaches we bring them. When Clan Chief Gresh-Mor approaches the Golden Chute to present the Clan's monthly tribute, the Collector's automated collection maw will descend from the vaulted ceiling. The Collector will receive the catalytic core with divine satisfaction, look down upon the final can of peaches, register its barcode, determine that canned sugar is a rare and unique cultural complexity not currently cataloged in the Archives, and suck it into the celestial vaults forever. In return, he will radiate a warm, benevolent wave of cosmic static that bestows a five-percent reduction on our Clan's annual reproductive licensing fee."

Krikk stared at the empty space between Skrix's hands, his multifaceted eyes dimming in profound, bureaucratic despair. "So... what do we get?"

"We get the lid," Skrix said brightly, handing him the jagged circle of stamped tin. "If you lick the rim very carefully, you can sometimes detect the phantom molecular ghost of high-fructose corn syrup without severing your tongue. It builds character. It makes you lean and hungry for the next raid."

Krikk drifted backward into his safety webbing, curling all four limbs inward until he looked like an oversized, disgruntled walnut. "The Sphere is a miserable place, Skrix. Everything out there wants to kill us, and everything in here wants to charge us for the privilege."

"Of course it is," Skrix said, securing the cargo straps with brisk, practiced yanks. "Survival is purely an exercise in knowing which particular horror is currently attempting to turn your thorax inside out, and running in the opposite direction with your loot tucked securely under your second pair of arms."

"What's the worst one?" Krikk asked quietly, peering out through the small, thick quartz viewport at the cold, star-dusted blackness of the frontier void. "The Orks?"

"The Orks are loud, but they are honest," Skrix muttered, pulling a greasy rag from his utility pouch to polish the grit from his leg joints. "An Ork doesn't bother with subtlety. Their entire design philosophy is taking a heavy naval hull, strapping four times as much reactor thrust to the back as the frame was built to handle, and bolting the biggest, ugliest cannons they can forge to the front. You run into an Orkish gunboat in the Wanabo buffer, and what happens? They don't hail you. They don't threaten to board. They just roll out heavy broadside macro-cannons the size of factory smokestacks and fire eight-hundred-millimeter high-explosive shells until the space around you is mostly shrapnel and expanding fire. If an Ork hits you, you don't need a medical kit, Krikk; you need an envelope so your clan can mail your ashes home. But an Orkish ship is the size of an apartment block and burns hot enough to light up the passive sensors three sectors away. You see his drive flare coming from half an astronomical unit out, and you run."

"And the Flotilla?"

Skrix shuddered, his carapace plates shivering against one another with a dry, papery rustle. "The Flotilla isn't scary until you look at the sensor board. With an Ork, you can hear him screaming through the bulkhead. With the Flotilla, you're drifting through an orbital lane three light-seconds out, thinking you're completely alone, and suddenly your console pings with a prerecorded, agonizingly polite radio chime. A calm, bored voice informs you that under Section 123, Sub-clause XYZ of the whatever mumbo jumbo, your unregistered transponder has violated sovereign orbital clearance. And while the voice is still reading the second paragraph of the legal citation, an eight-hundred-meter capital frigate three thousand kilometers away fires a two-ton solid tungsten dart from an electromagnetic spinal railgun. You don't even see the ship. You just see a flash of relativistic light, and suddenly your engine block is a cloud of hot copper vapor. They don't even raise their voices, Krikk. It's just clerks with three-mile kinetic lances."

"What about the tall ones on X'ara?" Krikk asked, his voice hushed. "The Ancestrals?"

"Worse," Skrix hissed. "They don't even have the decency to use radios. You land on an Ancestral moon by mistake to pick through an ancient spire, and they don't shout, they don't shoot slug-throwers, they don't even breathe. They just step out of the shadows in those shimmering, bone-white silks, gliding across the floor without touching the dust. You point your rifle at them, you pull the trigger, and the slug just stops in mid-air, drops to the floorboards, and then a singing spear made of hard light slides through your primary breastplate before you can finish blinking all your eye-facets. And they look at you while you die—not with hatred, mind you. Hatred would be flattering. They look at you the way a fastidious housekeeper looks at an oily smudge on an antique crystal goblet."

"And the dragons?"

"The dragons?" Skrix shuddered violently, all four of his claws locking tight around his pry-bar. "Do not even speak of the dragons, Krikk. Those are not beasts. They are giant, hungry nightmares living out in the black. You see a shadow in the dark that blots out the stars, and then two eyes open that burn like suns. They chew through ten inches of hull plating like dried kelp just to drink the fuel from your engines. When a dragon finds you, there is no fight, no boarding, and no escape—just a flash of fire, your ship crushed like an eggshell, and you're gone. But even a dragon is huge. You see the heat on your screens from millions of miles off. You keep your lights off, you drift cold, and you pray to the Collector it finds someone else to eat."

Krikk uncurled slightly, scratching at his mandible. "So what is it, then? If you can run from an Ork gunboat, avoid a Flotilla frigate, and drift cold past a dragon... what is the worst thing in the Sphere?"

Skrix lowered his tools. His four hands settled flat against his chitinous knees. When he spoke, his voice was barely a dry scrape of wind through his spiracles.

"Corsairs."

Krikk blinked his upper four eyes, then his lower two. "Corsairs? The Chief said they're just small-time scavengers. A few people in a little boat."

"The Chief," Skrix said with venomous precision, "is an old fat tick who hasn't left his cushioned couch in twenty years, and the only exercise he gets is chewing synthetic kelp and counting his share of our misery. Listen to me, boy. The Orks, the Flotilla, the dragons—what do they all have in common? They are big. They are loud. You can see them coming. An Ork gunboat spits fire across half the sky. A Flotilla warship lights up the void like a lantern. Even a wild dragon burns hot enough to blind your sensors. If you keep your eyes open, you can see them from millions of miles away. You cut your engines, tuck behind an asteroid, hold your breath, and let them pass."

Skrix leaned in close, his antennae twitching against Krikk's forehead.

"You don't see a Corsair coming, Krikk. That's what makes them terrifying."

"Why? Are their ships fast?"

"Their ships look like *nothing*," Skrix whispered. "They don't fly battleships. They fly a tiny little boat no bigger than a cargo hopper. No giant guns. No big glowing engines. They run cold and quiet through the dark. You glance at your sensor screen, you think it's a drifting rock or an empty piece of scrap. You don't run, because you don't even know you're being hunted. And then—their clamps hit your hull."

Krikk's mandibles clicked rapidly. "And then?"

"And then three people climb through your hatch. Maybe four. Not an army. Just three or four small creatures in plain, scuffed suits."

"Just three?" Krikk asked, his antennae tilting with skepticism. "Against a whole raiding crew?"

"That's the trap, boy. You look at them and think, *'There's only three of them. We have claws, we have guns, we can kill them.'* And before you even raise your weapon, you're already on the deck."

"How?"

"Because they don't yell. They don't posture. They just move. Fast. Faster than you can think. One of them grabs your barrel, snaps your wrist like a dry twig, and pins you to the wall with one hand. Another one slips right past you, clears the whole corridor in four seconds, and puts a dart into the Captain before he even gets out of his chair. They don't look like monsters, Krikk. They look like tired people doing a chore. And by the time your brain figures out that you're under attack, your arms are zip-tied behind your back, your loot is in their bag, and they're walking back to their ship complaining about the draft."

Krikk swallowed hard, his throat clicking. "Have you... seen that happen?"

"Three years ago," Skrix whispered, shivering until his carapace plates rattled against his ribcage. "On an abandoned fuel station. Our raiding team was stripping copper conduits when their cutter docked. No warning sirens, no drive flare. Just a quiet hiss, and suddenly three of them were in the corridor."

"What did you do?" Krikk asked wide-eyed. "Did you fight them?"

"Fight them?" Skrix looked at the boy like he had suggested chewing on a live plasma torch. "I fell face-first into a puddle of cold machine oil, curled all four of my arms tight against my belly, tucked my antennae under my collar, and played dead. I played so dead I stopped my secondary heart from beating."

"Did it work?"

"One of them walked right past me," Skrix said, his voice dropping to a trembling rasp. "Tapped my shell with the toe of a scuffed boot. Said to the other one: *'Don't bother with that one, it's already popped.'* I lay in that puddle of freezing oil for four hours without blinking an eye-facet, Krikk. Four hours. I didn't dare breathe until their thruster wake was two light-minutes out."

Krikk looked around the dimly lit cargo hold, suddenly finding the cold shadows between the storage lockers far more threatening than he had two minutes ago. "Well... at least we're four days out from the Wanabo frontier line. Nothing can track a dead-burn ballistic vector through the outer asteroid belt without active radar, and if anyone lit up active radar, our passive sensors would—"

A sharp, shrill electronic ping chimed across the sensor console.

Skrix froze. All four of his hands remained locked in place, suspended in mid-air.

Then came the urgent, double-pulsed chime of an emergency proximity alarm.

From the cockpit three compartments forward, a muffled, panicked scream tore through the intercom, followed immediately by the frantic clicking of Raiding Captain Vorash's terrified mandibles:

"All hands! All hands to breach stations! We've got an un-identified contact on our dorsal blind spot! No drive plume! No transponder! They were riding our exhaust shadow!"

Before Krikk could even reach for his slug-thrower, the entire five-hundred-ton hull of the *Rust-Weevil* groaned with a sickening shudder, like an iron anvil dropped onto an empty steel drum.

It wasn't the violent, tearing collision of an Orkish cannon shell. It was the heavy, precision bite of pneumatic magnetic harpoons—four heavy steel tethers punching through the outer micrometeorite shielding and locking onto the structural keel with hydraulic finality.

Directly above their heads, on the exterior surface of the cargo bay's primary airlock hatch, came the heavy, rhythmic vibration of magnetic boots pacing across the hull.

Then, through the heavy steel hatch, came a sound that made Skrix's compound eyes dilate in absolute, paralyzing horror.

It was the high-frequency, pressurized hiss of a thermal cutting torch, tracing a neat, rectangular line through the exterior blast seal.

Skrix looked at Krikk. "So, the trick to playing dead is this..."

CLASSES & THE MANTLE SYSTEM

In *Corsair*, your Class is not an abstract RPG profession, cultural caste, or permanent biological destiny. Instead, it represents an advanced, proprietary MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—a specialized, aerospace-grade cybernetic and technological chassis engineered for high-intensity tactical operations across planetary gravity wells and the void.

While civilian spacers and commercial security guards rely on standard vac-suits and off-the-shelf ballistic armor, Corsair operatives and fleet specialists wear MANTLEs. These fully integrated tactical rigs synchronize directly with the wearer's central nervous system, translating split-second subconscious impulses into overwhelming kinetic, thermal, chemical, or molecular force.

1. THE NEURAL CONTROL CHIP (NCC)

At the heart of every MANTLE rig lies the **Neural Control Chip (NCC)**. Permanently fused into the base of the operative's skull and cervical spine, the NCC interfaces directly with major motor nerve clusters and sensory pathways through an array of sub-dermal optical conduits and cranial shunt ports.

Operating a MANTLE is not like picking up a rifle or donning a set of body armor; it requires extensive neuro-physical conditioning, biometric calibration, and mental discipline. When an operative jacks into their chassis, the NCC establishes a closed-loop telemetry bridge:

- **Reflex Synchronization:** Actuator servos, capacitor banks, and manifold solenoids respond to motor intentions at the speed of neuro-chemical impulse—bypassing the mechanical latency of physical triggers or levers.
- **Sensory Telemetry:** The operative feels the condition of their chassis as a natural extension of their physical anatomy. A Conduit feels electrostatic charge prickling along their peripheral nerves; a Hazard perceives fluid pressure within their Catalyst Chamber as visceral chest tension; a Pilot senses external drone hull-stress as direct proprioceptive pressure.
- **Air-Gapped Isolation:** Because early neural experiments in human history proved vulnerable to electronic intrusion, all NCC architectures utilize strict, air-gapped optical buses. A MANTLE never communicates with external wireless networks without hardware-isolated firewalls, protecting the operative's brain from cyber-warfare intrusion or rogue signal resonance.

Once surgically installed and bonded to the operative's spinal column, the Neural Control Chip remains a permanent part of the character's body, ready to interface with any authorized MANTLE chassis they acquire.

2. ORIGINS & DISCOVERY

The technology underpinning modern MANTLE rigs was born out of survival and desperation across two centuries of Newcomer history.

THE VAULT DISCOVERIES & EARLY COVENANT (14-60 AA)

Following the founding of Crossroads and the historic alliance with Stormdrinker on Nimbus, early Newcomer researchers venturing into dormant Precursor Vaults discovered fragments of ancient, air-gapped optical-neural bus architecture. While the cosmic purpose of these relics was kept contained under the Covenant's charter to prevent cosmic beacons from firing, cyberneticists studied their inert conductive pathways, laying the theoretical groundwork for bio-compatible neural interfaces.

THE SCAVENGER INCURSIONS & ABE-REDMANE SKUNKWORKS (315-320 AA)

In 315 AA, the peaceful expansion of the Fume cluster was shattered by the **Scavenger Incursions**—brutal raider armadas composed of biologically modified Scav clans. When Scav boarding parties sacked Cloudspire and ambushed civilian transports, Newcomer defense militias were outmatched in close-quarters void combat by the raiders' terrifying biological reaction speeds.

Facing fleet extinction, Commander **Velen Redmane** rallied an independent coalition of spacers and engineers at the **Port Zenith Orbital Engineering Yards**, suspended in the upper atmosphere of Landfall. Redmane commissioned Chief Fleet-Engineer **Kira Abe** to weaponize vault-derived neural bus conduits into an emergency combat harness.

Working around the clock in Port Zenith's zero-gravity skunkworks, Abe's team created the first generation of closed-loop **MANTLE** prototypes. By linking heavy tactical systems directly into the wearer's motor reflexes, strike teams could match and exceed Scav agility in zero-g boarding actions. Equipped with these experimental rigs, Redmane's coalition routed the raiders at the decisive **Battle of Fume Rings (320 AA)**, leading directly to the birth of the Flotilla and the signing of the Skyline Accords (335 AA).

In the two centuries following the Battle of Fume Rings, MANTLE technology evolved through continuous refinement across dozens of production blocks. Early military engineers incorporated dragon biology research—studying the efficient bio-electric resonance of dragon scales and nerve tissue—alongside new discoveries extracted from deep Precursor vaults and hard-won industrial telemetry from the Drift Wars. By the time of the Frontier War (485-508 AA), the MANTLE had matured into the defining tactical platform of modern void combat.

3. THE 518 AA REALITY

In the present day of **518 AA**—ten years after the Fall of the *Evergaol* and the signing of the Great Truce—the production, possession, and maintenance of MANTLE rigs are shaped by post-war realities.

MANTLE ACQUISITION PIPELINES (518 AA)

- **1. Sponsor Candidate Pipelines:** Official patron underwrites NCC surgery and issues a certified fleet rig during elite training, pending Oversight Committee charter.
- **2. The Freelancer Network:** Grassroots fraternity of Corsair veterans and dockside armorers passing down repaired, surplused, or salvaged frames to promising aspirants.
- **3. Post-War Salvage & Black Markets:** Decommissioned war stock or battlefield salvage from the Frontier War repaired in orbital chop-shops and retrofitted with jailbroken firmware.

FLOTILLA CONTROL & LEGAL STATUS

Under the Law of the Void, the Flotilla High Council classifies combat-grade MANTLEs as **Tier-1 Restricted Military Hardware**. Licensed production is tightly restricted to major orbital naval foundries (such as the Bastion Yards at Port Zenith), and unauthorized possession in orbital transit lanes carries severe criminal penalties. However, under the **Skyline Accords (335 AA)**, planetary governments hold sovereign authority within their atmospheric gravity wells, allowing surface colonies, private corporations, and frontier syndicates to license and deploy their own proprietary variants.

For commissioned **Corsairs**, possessing a top-tier MANTLE is an official entitlement of their charter. When an operative joins a chartered cell, their individual Sponsor (Flotilla, Colonial administration, Megacorporation, Union, or Private patron) legally registers and underwrites their chassis, granting them cross-jurisdictional authorization to carry lethal tactical hardware across both orbital space and planetary soil.

Uncommissioned **Freelancers (Aspirants)** acquire starting frames through sponsor candidate pipelines, the informal **Freelancer Network** of veterans and dockside armorers, or restored Frontier War battlefield salvage calibrated in dockside cyber-clinics.

4. THE FIVE BESPOKE CHASSIS

While every MANTLE interfaces through the standardized Neural Control Chip, physical chassis are **not** interchangeable modular shells. Each class represents an entirely bespoke, dedicated full-body frame engineered from aerospace alloys, micro-servos, and specialized tactical hardware:

- **The Conduit:** Engineered as a living capacitor suit, featuring spine-mounted graphene-dielectric plates, subcutaneous energy conduits, and shoulder Peltier thermoelectric heat sinks that vent excess thermal and cryogenic bleed during high-voltage Amp and Burst cycles.
- **The Hazard:** An armored chemical warfare harness housing a pressurized thoracic Catalyst Chamber, micro-solenoid mixing valves, hermetically sealed reagent reservoirs, and chemical-resistant fluoropolymer conduits routed to transdermal dermojets.
- **The Pilot:** A motorized bio-mechanical exoskeleton frame equipped with cranial high-frequency telemetry uplinks, heavy solid-state battery banks, reinforced skeletal shock-absorbers, and dorsal magnetic docking clamps that host an autonomous, articulated Exodrone.
- **The Vanguard:** A high-mobility kinetic assault platform featuring articulated dorsal locking collars, calf-to-spine inertial balance nodes, and micro-servo shock mounts built to catch, wield, and redirect the tremendous torque of a morphing multi-segment kinetic Board.
- **The Weaver:** An advanced molecular fabrication chassis centered around thoracic titanium-ceramic reservoirs housing millions of microscopic alloy nanites, governed by high-frequency magnetic confinement conduits and fluid-fabric kinetic shrouds.

5. NEURO-PHYSICAL INVARIANTS

SINGLE ACTIVE CHASSIS LIMIT (SYNAPTIC SATURATION)

Because the Neural Control Chip establishes a comprehensive bidirectional map between the operative's motor cortex, autonomic nervous system, and suit telemetry, the biological brain can only sustain **one active chassis mapping at a time**.

Attempting to cross-link or equip multiple MANTLE frames simultaneously causes immediate sensory confusion and neurological overload—a life-threatening condition known as **Synaptic Burnout** that results in violent motor seizures, cardiovascular shock, and permanent neural scarring. Consequently, an operative can have **only one MANTLE chassis equipped and active at any time**.

CLASS ATTRIBUTES & STARTING CREATION

Every MANTLE chassis is governed by **three specialized Class Attributes** (e.g., *Flame, Frost, Lightning* for the Conduit; *Venom, Hazard, Serum* for the Hazard; *Power, Speed, Precision* for the Pilot).

- **Starting Values:** All three Class Attributes begin at a baseline of **1** (`1 / 1 / 1`).
- **Creation Budget:** At character creation, spend **7 Class Creation Points** across your three Class Attributes.
- **Point Costs:** Increasing an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs **1 point** per step; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs **2 points**. Maximum starting rating is **5**.

DOWNTIME ACQUISITION & SWAPPING (100,000 CR)

Operatives are not locked into a single chassis for their entire career. During campaign downtime, an operative can purchase an additional bespoke MANTLE chassis for **100,000 Credits**.

This substantial investment reflects the true cost of acquiring an aerospace-grade military frame on the open or grey market, purchasing proprietary firmware licenses or black-market decryption keys, and spending an extended shift in an orbital cyber-clinic to undergo neuro-pod recalibration. During recalibration, the operative's NCC is flushed and flashed with the telemetry profiles of the new frame, preventing synaptic rejection.

Preserved Investment: Attribute ratings, unlocked ability packages, and purchased class mods belong permanently to each specific chassis. When an operative spends downtime swapping from their Conduit MANTLE to their Vanguard MANTLE in the ship's armory, their Vanguard attributes and unlocked combos remain exactly as they left them.

CLASS: THE CONDUIT

The Conduit is the cell's living capacitor and high-intensity shock trooper, defined by total neuro-synaptic integration with a specialized Conduit-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*). Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cranial shunt, the rig synchronizes layered graphene-dielectric capacitor plates and a dense network of subdermal energy conduits mounted along the operative's spine and major limb axes. Translucent fluoropolymer conduits trace along the limbs and torso, glowing with sharp chromatic pulses—radiant amber, sub-zero cerulean, or electric violet—that correspond to their current electromagnetic and thermal saturation. Thermoelectric Peltier arrays and micro-vent heat sinks embedded across the shoulders continuously dissipate ambient thermal bleed, surrounding the Conduit in a shimmering haze of superheated air, drifting ice vapor, or crackling static discharge.

In active combat, the Conduit operates under hard-science principles of rapid energy accumulation, capacitive storage, and directed discharge. Rather than relying on external power cells, the operative's internal plates draw kinetic recoil, thermal friction, and metabolic potential, converting them into a high-density internal charge. As these capacitor banks saturate through tactical Amp maneuvers, the Conduit channels this power into devastating physical and technical feats—accelerating muscle contraction for near-instant bounds, flash-freezing deckplates, or discharging high-voltage arcs across enemy formations. Yet this stored power creates immense systemic tension: holding peak voltage strains internal insulation and elevates core temperatures, demanding that the operative periodically vent their fully saturated plates in catastrophic, encounter-shifting Burst releases.

The modular versatility of the Conduit MANTLE chassis makes them an invaluable asset across every operational theater. An operative can tune their capacitor discharge to deliver high-yield explosive breaching charges and searing thermal barrages to crack armored strongpoints, flash-freeze corridors into impenetrable crystalline barricades to secure a defensive retreat, or defibrillate flatlined cell members with calibrated neuro-electric pulses during frantic firefights. When technical systems fail, the Conduit can overcharge friendly electronics, fabricate temporary tactical gear from polarized plate residue, or surge bodily across the battlefield to dismantle enemy squads. Whatever the mission requires, the Conduit controls the flow of battlefield energy.

ATTRIBUTES

A Conduit's capabilities are governed by three specialized Class Attributes:

- **Flame:** The generation and vectoring of high-thermal incendiary blasts, concussive pressure waves, and kinetic combustion.
- **Frost:** The rapid endothermic extraction of heat, cryogenic crystallization, and molecular structural stabilization.
- **Lightning:** The accumulation and discharge of high-voltage galvanic arcs, electromagnetic pulses, and synaptic acceleration.

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** across your Flame, Frost, and Lightning Attributes (baseline 1 / 1 / 1). Raising an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs 1 point per increase; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs 2 points. The maximum starting rating for any Class Attribute is **5**.

BASIC MECHANICS

MINOR TOUCH EFFECTS

Even without a test, you can channel low-voltage currents, focused heat, or endothermic siphons through your bare hands to produce minor narrative effects:

- **Flame:** Warm an object, ignite a pilot light or fuse, dry wet fabric, thaw thin frost, or cauterize a minor surface abrasion.
- **Frost:** Chill a beverage, flash-freeze standing water, solidify a viscous chemical puddle, or soothe a localized burn.
- **Lightning:** Deliver a mild static shock, illuminate a low-voltage LED indicator, ground static interference on a console, or clear visual distortion from a monitor.

MELEE COMBAT

You can channel raw elemental energy through your fists, limbs, and close-quarters weapons, making melee attacks using your Conduit Attributes paired with their corresponding physical Core Attributes:

- **Flame (Thermal / Incendiary):** Favored pair **Flame + Strength**. Unleash concussive kinetic blasts and searing thermal strikes, directing explosive force with muscular might.
- **Frost (Cryogenic Piercing):** Favored pair **Frost + Finesse**. Wield and drive crystalline ice daggers into structural seams and joint seals with pinpoint precision.
- **Lightning (Galvanic Arc):** Favored pair **Lightning + Agility**. Blitz opponents with high-voltage arcing strikes and rapid-fire blows, using electrical potential to augment raw speed.
- **Favored Pair Damage Bonus:** When you make a melee attack using the weapon's favored Attribute Pair, you gain a damage bonus equal to the **lower attribute** in that pair.

EFFECT SYNERGIES

Channeling specific elemental frequencies through your Conduit Attributes enhances the potency of standard tactical Effects:

- **Flame:** When taking a test that uses your Flame attribute, your **Crit Effects** grant **3 Success Points** instead of the standard 2 per Hit sacrificed.
- **Frost:** When taking a test that uses your Frost attribute, any **Blocker Effects** or **Downgrade Effects** you establish become **Sustained Effects** until the end of the round, resetting after each affected attempt until overcome or cleared.
- **Lightning:** When taking a test that uses your Lightning attribute, your **Chain Effects** also increase your total **Success Points by +1**, and you can spend any dice that rolled **7 or higher** to activate them instead of the normal 8 or higher.

THE CHARGE ENGINE

Conduit abilities revolve around the dynamic accumulation and venting of **Charges** held within your subcutaneous capacitor plates:

- **Capacity & Starting State:** Your capacitor plates can hold a maximum of **3 Charges**. You begin every combat encounter at **0 Charges**.
- **Amp Abilities (Charge Generators):**
  - Amp abilities channel raw energy into your plates, building up elemental Charge while delivering immediate tactical advantages.
  - Activating an Amp ability with 0 Charges grants you **1 Charge** of that ability's element type.
  - Activating an Amp ability of the *same* element as your current Charges increases your stored **Charges by 1** (up to the maximum of 3 Charges).
  - Activating an Amp ability of a *different* element than your current Charges immediately resets your stored Charges to 0 before granting 1 Charge of the new element (unless modified by Class Mods).
  - You cannot activate an Amp ability if you already hold the maximum of 3 Charges for that element (unless modified by *Infinity*).
  - You can only activate a single Amp ability per action.
- **Burst Abilities (Charge Venters):**
  - Burst abilities vent your fully saturated capacitor plates in devastating, encounter-defining releases.
  - Burst abilities can only be activated when you hold **exactly 3 Charges** (unless modified by *Finality*).
  - You can only activate the Burst variant corresponding to your currently stored elemental Charge.
  - Activating a Burst ability consumes and vents **all 3 Charges**, resetting your stored Charges to 0.

CLASS ABILITIES

Conduit abilities are organized into **7 thematic packages**, each featuring a paired **Amp Ability** and **Burst Ability** with distinct Flame, Frost, and Lightning branches. Operatives select **1 starting package** at character creation, and unlock **1 additional package** at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

Every ability explicitly declares its **Action Economy Tag**:

- **[Rider]:** Costs **0 additional AP**; enhances or triggers during an existing action (such as a firearm attack, melee strike, or movement action).
- **[Reaction]:** Costs **0 AP**; triggered in response to an external event (such as being targeted by an incoming attack). Limited to once per turn unless noted.
- **[Action]:** Costs **1 AP**; requires rolling a test or deploying an immediate tactical effect.

1. RANGED PACKAGE

The Ranged Package integrates subcutaneous capacitor lines directly with chambered ammunition and ballistic rails, infusing firearm projectiles with elemental payload before venting residual energy in devastating area bombardments.

Amped Shot [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a ranged attack with a Firearm.
- **Effect:** *Capacitor shunts bleed raw energy directly into the chambered round as the firing pin strikes.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching effect to the attack:
  - **Flame:** Ranged attacks deal a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained) as superheated thermal jackets detonate on impact.
  - **Frost:** You may reroll a number of dice across all rolls in the test equal to your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained), freezing your targeting reticle onto structural weak points.
  - **Lightning:** When activating your first **Chain Effect** during the attack test, you can target a number of additional creatures equal to your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained) without expending additional ammunition.

Blast Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Capacitor plates vent their entire reserve through external projector nozzles in a catastrophic ranged detonation.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Conduit Success Test** using the attribute matching your consumed Charges:
  - **Flame:** Searing incendiary blast waves scour the impact zone. You inflict thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your Flame Attribute** to every creature occupying an **8-meter radius** centered on the target space.
  - **Frost:** A pressurized cryogenic shockwave flash-freezes the atmosphere. You inflict cryogenic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Frost Attribute** to every creature caught in a **90-degree cone, 12 meters long**, originating from your space. In addition, every space caught within the cone becomes **Difficult Terrain** until the end of the round.
  - **Lightning:** A piercing bolt of stepped-leader plasma lances forward. You inflict galvanic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Lightning Attribute** to up to **three chosen creatures** in your space, the target space, or any space intersecting the straight line of fire between them. You can activate **Chain Effects** on this roll to increase the number of targets.

2. MELEE PACKAGE

The Melee Package routes high-density capacitor currents directly through forearm plates and knuckles, supercharging physical strikes with kinetic backblast before venting in an earth-shattering point-blank impact.

Amped Strike [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a melee attack or elemental melee strike.
- **Effect:** *Subdermal conduits flash with kinetic energy, amplifying close-quarters impact.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching effect to the strike:
  - **Flame:** Thermal backblast detonates on contact. The attack deals a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained), or you may spend your strike's momentum to **Push** the target 1 space (2 meters) per active Charge.
  - **Frost:** Sub-zero frost coats the target's limbs and servos. For each **active Charge** you hold (including the Charge just gained), apply **1 standard Downgrade** to the target's physical tests until the end of the round.
  - **Lightning:** High-voltage static leaps between targets. If the attack hits, you can chain the strike to **1 additional adjacent enemy per active Charge** (including the Charge just gained) without sacrificing Hits.

Impact Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *All capacitor banks vent simultaneously through your striking limb, detonating a point-blank kinetic catastrophe.* Target a creature or reinforced structure in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Conduit Success Test** using the attribute matching your consumed Charges:
  - **Flame (Inferno Impact):** You deliver an explosive punch that inflicts massive thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your Flame Attribute + 4 bonus damage** to the primary target. In addition, an outward shockwave inflicts damage equal to your **Flame Attribute** to all other hostile creatures in your space and adjacent spaces.
  - **Frost (Glacial Impact):** You drive a flash-freezing spike of solid ice into the target, inflicting damage equal to your **Success Points + your Frost Attribute** and encasing them in dense crystalline frost. This establishes a **Blocker Effect of 3 dice** against all physical and movement actions attempted by the target until the ice is shattered or cleared.
  - **Lightning (Thunder Impact):** A devastating galvanic arc vaporizes air between you and the target, inflicting damage equal to your **Success Points + your Lightning Attribute**. You instantly arc-discharge through the target, reappearing in any unoccupied space up to **8 meters away**; all hostile creatures caught in the line between your starting space and destination take damage equal to your **Lightning Attribute**.

3. MOBILITY PACKAGE

The Mobility Package siphons stored energy into myofibril micro-servos and personal propulsion vents, converting raw electrical and thermal voltage into blinding battlefield traversal.

Amped Sprint [Rider]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When declaring a Movement Action.
- **Effect:** *Internal capacitor loops flood motor pathways and directional thrusters with accelerated voltage.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and execute your movement with enhanced parameters scaling with your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Vector thrusters ignite with thermal fury. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, and you may **Fly** for the duration of this movement action.
  - **Frost:** Frictionless cryogenic frost glazes the deck beneath your boots. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, ignore Difficult Terrain, and leave a trail of **Difficult Terrain** behind you through every space traversed (persisting until the end of the round).
  - **Lightning:** Hyper-accelerated neuro-muscular reflexes twitch at microsecond speeds. You gain **+2 meters of movement per active Charge**, and your movement is **completely uncontested** (it cannot trigger reactions, intercept fire, or blocker effects).

Motion Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *You dump all three capacitor banks into full-body acceleration, executing a supersonic blitz across the battlefield.* You move a number of meters equal to your **active Conduit Attribute × 4**, followed immediately by an elemental impact or tactical release:
  - **Flame:** You fly at extreme velocity directly into a hostile target's space. All creatures occupying your destination space suffer thermal collision damage equal to your **Flame Attribute + your Strength Attribute**.
  - **Frost:** You skate across the engagement zone, turning every space traversed into **Difficult Terrain** for enemies. In your final destination space, you instantly manifest a jagged wall of reinforced ice that acts as **Medium Cover (Cover Rating 2, 24 HP, Innate Protection 8)**.
  - **Lightning:** You blitz across the battlefield with blinding speed, making an elemental melee attack against a creature along your path (inflicting standard melee damage + your Lightning Attribute). You may use any remaining movement after the attack to disengage freely. Furthermore, you can activate **Chain Effects** on this attack against **any creature in any space you traversed** during this movement.

4. DEFENSE PACKAGE

The Defense Package channels stored capacitive reserves into reactive dispersion meshes, endothermic kinetic barriers, and high-frequency deflector fields to nullify incoming assaults.

Amped Defense [Reaction]

- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** Once per turn, when you are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *Reactive capacitor circuits discharge defensively before the incoming strike lands.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and apply the matching defensive protection scaling with your **active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Thermal flare vents outward. If the attacker occupies your space or an adjacent space, they immediately take thermal counter-damage equal to your **Flame Attribute + your active Charges**.
  - **Frost:** Endothermic plates flash-freeze ambient moisture across your torso. You gain **+1 Physical Protection per active Charge** against this incoming attack.
  - **Lightning:** An electrostatic distortion field crackles around your chassis. If you contest the incoming attack, you gain a number of **Upgrades to the Contest Roll equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained).

Shield Burst [Reaction]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *You dump your entire capacitor reserve in an emergency defensive surge, contesting the incoming attack for free (0 AP) using your active Conduit Attribute:*
  - **Flame:** A concussive thermal explosion engulfs your perimeter. All creatures other than you in your space take damage equal to **Flame Attribute + Your Conduit Level**.
  - **Frost:** A reinforced crystalline ice cocoon locks across your position. You may create **Medium Cover** in your current space.
  - **Lightning:** You dodge the attack with immense speed. You can move a number of meters equal to your highest die plus your **Lightning Attribute**.

5. RESTORATION PACKAGE

The Restoration Package routes delicate micro-currents and regulated thermal gradients through cardiovascular pathways, stimulating cellular mitosis, stabilizing shock, and defibrillating flatlined allies.

Amped Regen [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 AP (0 AP if activated as a Reaction via Lightning)
- **Trigger:** Once per Player Turn, as long as you have Light Wounds (or Light Stress in the case of Frost), or immediately after taking damage if using Lightning.
- **Effect:** *Precision bio-electric currents stimulate rapid cellular granulation and synaptic stabilization.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and heal **Light Wounds equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained). In addition:
  - **Flame:** Searing thermal cauterization closes hemorrhaging instantly; heal **+1 additional Light Wound** (healing total Light Wounds equal to your **active Charges + 1**).
  - **Frost:** Endothermic biogel soothes trauma; you may choose to heal either **Light Wounds** or **Light Stress**.
  - **Lightning:** Galvanic defibrillation triggers on instinct; this ability can be activated as a **Reaction (0 AP) immediately after taking damage**, but if activated in this way, you cannot activate Amped Regen on your next Player Turn.

Healing Burst [Free Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Target:** You or a single ally occupying your current space.
- **Effect:** *Your plates release a massive metabolic and neuro-electrical surge to reconstruct damaged tissue, supercharge adrenaline, and restart stopped hearts.* The chosen target heals **Light Wounds or Light Stress** (recipient's choice) equal to your **chosen elemental Attribute + your Willpower or Toughness** (your choice). In addition, based on the element consumed:
  - **Flame:** Searing thermal stimulation and metabolic overdrive stoke fiery vigor; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Strength** and **Presence** tests for the rest of the round.
  - **Frost:** Endothermic crystalline biogel flash-freezes across vitals; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Finesse** tests for the rest of the round, and gains **+4 Protection** against the next attack targeting the recipient that would hit.
  - **Lightning:** Galvanic cardiac-synaptic resuscitation surges through reflexes; the target gains **+1 Upgrade** on all **Agility** tests for the rest of the round, and this ability can resurrect the target if they died during the current round, immediately reviving them to consciousness with their healed Light Wounds.

6. PROWESS PACKAGE

The Prowess Package bridges internal capacitor storage with everyday physical, mental, and sensory operations, channeling elemental reserves into non-combat challenges, investigations, and technical feats.

Amped Prowess [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Restriction:** Strictly for non-combat, narrative, and downtime challenges (cannot be used during combat rounds).
- **Effect:** *Internal energy reservoirs focus body, mind, or senses into effortless mastery.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and make a non-combat test using an attribute matching your element, gaining **Upgrades equal to your active Charges** (including the Charge just gained):
  - **Flame:** Channel thermal combustion into athletic feats, heavy labor, physical intimidation, or commanding social presence (tests using **Strength** or **Presence**).
  - **Frost:** Channel endothermic calm into micro-manipulation, technical repair, hacking, forensic investigation, or surgery (tests using **Finesse** or **Knowledge**).
  - **Lightning:** Channel galvanic reflexes into navigation, stealth, environmental awareness, or rapid zero-g traversal (tests using **Agility** or **Instinct**).

Overdrive Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *You dump all three capacitor banks into an overwhelming surge of biological, analytical, or sensory hyper-performance.* When taking any test that includes an attribute matching your consumed Charges (Flame: **Strength / Presence**; Frost: **Finesse / Knowledge**; Lightning: **Agility / Instinct**) that is **not an attack action** (usable in or outside of combat):
  - You set up to **3 dice in your Success Roll to their maximum possible face value** (10 on a d10, 12 on a d12).
  - These maximum-value dice can be banked for **Gambit Points**, sacrificed for **Hits** and **Crit Effects**, or kept to guarantee extraordinary Success Points.

7. GEAR SYNTHESIS PACKAGE

The Gear Synthesis Package links capacitor output directly with field equipment, boosting active hardware with elemental frequencies or condensing energy into short-lived physical munitions, barriers, and electronic rigs.

Amp Gear [Rider / Action]

- **Cost:** 0 AP as a Rider when utilizing eligible gear, or 1 AP as an Action to calibrate gear.
- **Effect:** *Capacitor shunts couple directly into handheld tools, weapons, and devices.* You gain **+1 Charge** of the chosen element and select one of two calibration options corresponding to your element:
  - **Flame (Strength-Linked Gear):** *Thermal Striker:* Equipped melee weapon gains a flat **+1 Damage Bonus per active Charge** until end of round. *Pyrotechnic Fuse:* On Ordnance tests, dice equal to your active Charges score **Crit Effects on 7+** instead of 8+.
  - **Frost (Finesse-Linked Gear):** *Cryo Calibrator:* When performing tests requiring Finesse gear, reroll dice equal to your active Charges. *Endothermic Coagulant:* Medical items gain bonus **Success Points equal to active Charges**.
  - **Lightning (Agility-Linked Gear):** *Vector Supercharger:* Mobility equipment gains **Upgrades equal to active Charges**. *Conductive ICE-Breaker:* Hacking or Interfacing tests gain **Upgrades equal to active Charges**.

Synthesis Burst [Action]

- **Resource Cost:** Requires and consumes 3 Charges
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Condense high-density energy into single-use hardware (Load 0, lasts one activation or until encounter ends):*
  - **Flame:** *Thermal Grenade:* Frag or HE grenade with **Ordnance equal to Flame**. *Vectored Jump-Rig:* Jetpack with **Mobility equal to Flame** (grants 1 flight move).
  - **Frost:** *Cryo Trauma Kit:* Field Medi-Kit with **Medicine equal to Frost**. *Glacial Barricade:* Medium Deployable Cover (**+2 Cover, 24 HP, Protection 8**) in your space.
  - **Lightning:** *Arc Flashbang:* Flashbang with **Ordnance equal to Lightning** (Stun, 4m radius). *Virtual Cyberdeck:* Cyberdeck with **Hacking/Interfacing equal to Lightning**.

CLASS MODS

Class Mods represent advanced dielectric overclocks and firmware overrides installed directly into the Conduit's chassis. The Conduit has access to **5 distinct Class Mods** (25,000 Credits each, socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **1. Duality:** You can store Charges of **two different elements simultaneously** (maximum 3 Charges shared). Burst consumes all stored charges, venting the majority element (your choice if split).
- **2. Infinity:** Continue activating Amp abilities even when holding **maximum 3 Charges**. Resolves active mechanical effects while stored Charges remain capped at 3 without resetting.
- **3. Intensity:** Whenever scoring a **Hit (8+)** on any test using Conduit Attributes, sacrifice that Hit to **generate 1 Charge** of that element type (up to max capacity).
- **4. Finality:** Activate Burst abilities with **fewer than 3 Charges** (even at 0 Charges). Consumes all charges; you **cannot gain Charges of any element until end of round**.
- **5. Ingenuity:** Activating an Amp of a different element does not reset charges; choose to **convert all existing Charges into the new element type** and increase by +1.

PROGRESSION

The Conduit chassis can be upgraded at specialized cybernetic armories and neuro-clinics by spending Credits during downtime. Each upgrade level expands attribute capacity, unlocks advanced ability packages, and opens hardware Mod slots. At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** among Flame, Frost, and Lightning (base 1 / 1 / 1, starting cap 5). You begin with **1 Ability Package** of your choice.

CONDUIT CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Package (Amp & Burst), Charge Engine (Max 3)	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Ability Package	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Ability Package	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL CONDUIT ARCHETYPES

- **The Pyromancer Breacher:** Maximizes *Flame* paired with Strength and Melee/Ranged. Uses Amped strikes to shatter barricades, venting Inferno Impacts to wipe enemy assault squads.
- **The Cryo Sentinel:** Prioritizes *Frost* paired with Finesse and Defense/Mobility. Freezes hostile corridors, locks down heavy threats in crystalline ice, and protects allies with reactive armor.
- **The Galvanic Blitz:** Combines high *Lightning* with Agility and Mobility. Chains high-voltage arcs through multiple enemies at once, blitzing across the battlefield without provoking intercept fire.
- **The Field Resuscitator:** Invests in Restoration, balancing Frost biogels with Lightning defibrillation to heal wounds, soothe stress, and revive fallen allies mid-firefight.

CLASS: THE HAZARD

The Hazard is the cell's combat alchemist and chemical warfare specialist, defined by their neural synchronization with a specialized Hazard-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) and its pressurized ChemPack manifold. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cervical shunt, the rig coordinates an intricate network of reinforced subcutaneous fluid lines and an armored dorsal harness. Mounted between the operative's shoulder blades, the Catalyst Chamber houses high-pressure reaction vessels, micro-solenoid valves, and high-frequency acoustic mixers that synthesize complex biochemical compounds in fractions of a second. Translucent fluoropolymer conduits trace along the operative's arms and torso, pulsing rhythmically with luminous reagents as transdermal dermojets and wrist-mounted atomizers prepare volatile mixtures for instant deployment. Often seen wearing a low-profile negative-pressure respirator to withstand their own toxic microclimates, the Hazard operates in an unmistakable aura of ozone, sharp ether, and metallic vapor.

In active combat, the ChemPack functions under principles of rapid binary synthesis and extreme hydraulic pressure. Rather than hauling bulk quantities of unstable compounds, the Hazard stores stabilized base reagents in three hermetic reservoirs, combining them within the central Catalyst Chamber only at the moment of discharge. This internal pressure dictates the potency of every brew: as the operative redlines the chamber, internal atomizers produce hyper-reactive mists, searing incendiaries, and accelerated stimulant cocktails. Yet this power demands disciplined regulation. Pushing the Catalyst Chamber beyond its mechanical tolerance risks catastrophic blowout, violently rupturing safety gaskets and spewing caustic backwash across the operative's own chassis.

The modular versatility of the Hazard MANTLE chassis makes them an indispensable tactical pivot across all combat scenarios. In heavy firefights, the operative can lay down blinding aerosol screens and adhesive polymer barriers to disrupt enemy advances, dissolve armored bulkheads with hyper-reactive acids, or detonate thermal blasts that scour entrenched firing nests. When cell members fall under heavy fire, the Hazard shifts immediately from biohazard offensive to frontline triage, injecting neuro-metabolic stimulants to restore spent action potential, dosing wounded allies with coagulant biogels, or shocking flatlined comrades back to consciousness. Whatever the operational theater demands, the Hazard controls the biochemical battlefield.

ATTRIBUTES

A Hazard's capabilities are governed by three specialized Class Attributes:

- **Venom:** The synthesis and delivery of debilitating neurotoxins, systemic bio-agents, and corrosive acids that degrade enemy resilience from within.
- **Hazard:** The compounding and detonation of volatile, hypergolic, and thermal reagents engineered to deliver catastrophic concussive force on impact.
- **Serum:** The precision compounding and rapid administration of restorative bio-gels, clotting coagulants, and cellular metabolic stimulants.

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** across your Venom, Hazard, and Serum Attributes (baseline 1 / 1 / 1). Raising an Attribute from 1 to 4 costs 1 point per increase; raising an Attribute from 4 to 5 costs 2 points. The maximum starting rating for any Class Attribute is **5**.

BASIC MECHANICS

THE CATALYST CHAMBER & PRESSURE ENGINE

The Hazard's abilities are powered by the internal pressure of their ChemPack's Catalyst Chamber. Internal pressure dictates chemical atomization velocity, mixture density, and overall potency:

- **Pressure Range:** Chamber Pressure is measured on a scale from **0 to 3**. Operatives begin every combat encounter at **Pressure 0**.
- **The Volatile Die:** As chamber pressure climbs, internal agitation supercharges your tests with an additional **Volatile Die**. The size of the Volatile Die corresponds directly to your current Pressure:
  - **Pressure 0:** No Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 1: d8** Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 2: d10** Volatile Die.
  - **Pressure 3: d12** Volatile Die.
- **Inherent Volatility:** Whenever Pressure is **1 or higher**, rolling your active Volatile Die is **mandatory** on all tests using Hazard Attributes. The Volatile Die cannot be stepped up, stepped down, or modified by standard Upgrades or Downgrades.
- **Test Pool Integration:** In Simple and Success Tests, roll the Volatile Die alongside your standard test pool. In Complex Tests, the Volatile Die is added to your Action Roll pool; if selected as one of your kept dice during the Success Roll, its face value determines your Success Points as normal.

RUPTURE RESOLUTION (CHAMBER BLOWOUT)

Pushing the Catalyst Chamber to high pressure offers immense tactical reward, but risks catastrophic mechanical failure:

- **Triggering a Rupture:** Whenever the Volatile Die rolls a **Hit (8 or higher)** on any test, a **Rupture** occurs immediately.
- **The Hit Counts:** The Hit rolled on the Volatile Die is valid and contributes to the success of your action, Success Points, or Hit-spending effects as normal.
- **Blowout Consequence:** The chamber's emergency pressure seals blow out under the stress. You immediately suffer **2 Light Wounds** (bypassing Physical Protection) and your Chamber Pressure **instantly vents to 0**.

REGULATE CHAMBER [ACTION]

To ensure you never become tactically deadlocked when your active abilities require specific pressure conditions, you can manually modulate the Catalyst Chamber's valves:

- **Action Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** You manually cycle the ChemPack's pneumatic purge valves or stroke the primer pump. Choose one of the following:
  - **Pump:** Increase Chamber Pressure by **+1** (to a maximum of Pressure 3).
  - **Vent:** Decrease Chamber Pressure by **-1** (to a minimum of Pressure 0).

BASELINE ATTRIBUTE ACTIONS

Every Hazard Attribute provides a baseline combat application that can be executed without unlocking specific ability kits. Each baseline action costs **1 AP** and standardizes around spending rolled **Hits**:

- **Venom — Debilitating Dose [Action]:** Administer a debilitating dose against a creature in your space or an adjacent space (which can be delivered as a melee strike or applied **covertly**, such as a subtle touch or concealed contact), rolling a **Venom Success Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice from the roll, apply **1 Downgrade** to that creature. This Downgrade is permanent until treated or removed. A creature can be affected by only one of your Venom Downgrades at a time, and you can maintain a maximum number of active Venom Downgrades equal to your **Venom** Attribute rating.
- **Hazard — Explosive Strike [Action]:** Make a melee attack using your **Hazard** Attribute to detonate a pressurized binary charge against a target in your space or an adjacent space. This attack deals your standard melee striking damage plus **bonus damage equal to your Hazard Attribute rating** (and you can spend Hits on effects as normal).
- **Serum — Performance Dose [Action]:** Administer a fast-acting metabolic cocktail to yourself or a willing creature in your space or an adjacent space, rolling a **Serum Success Test**. When administered, bind the dose to a specific **Core Attribute** (Strength, Agility, Finesse, Knowledge, Presence, or Instinct). For each **Hit** you sacrifice from the roll, apply **1 Upgrade** that triggers specifically on tests using that chosen Attribute. This Upgrade is permanent until removed or expended. A creature can benefit from only one of your Serum Upgrades at a time, and you can maintain a maximum number of active Serum Upgrades equal to your **Serum** Attribute rating.

CLASS ABILITIES

Hazard abilities are grouped into specialized **Kits**, each containing three synergized chemical techniques. Operatives select **1 starting Kit** at character creation, and unlock **1 additional Kit** at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

Every ability explicitly specifies its **Pressure Cost/Change** and **Action Economy Tag**:

- If an ability's Pressure change would cause your Pressure to exceed **3** or drop below **0**, that ability **cannot be used** (unless modified by hardware such as the *Redline Engine*).

MEDIC KIT

The Medic Kit packages rapid-clotting bio-foams, transdermal tissue reconstructors, and defibrillating micro-currents for frontline surgical stabilization.

First Aid [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized bio-gel seals lacerations and stabilizes hemorrhaging flesh.* Target yourself or a creature in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Wound** on the target. In addition, heal a flat number of extra Light Wounds equal to your current **Pressure** level.

Regenerator [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Neuro-calming biogels soothe frayed synapses and alleviate cognitive overload.* Target yourself or a creature in your space or an adjacent space and make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Stress** (Mental Wound) on the target. In addition, heal a flat number of extra Light Stress equal to your current **Pressure** level.

Defibrillator [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum / Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A high-voltage chemical electrode discharges either restorative stimulus or lethal concussive shock.* Target a creature in your space or an adjacent space:
  - **Unconscious Target (Serum):** Make a **Serum Success Test**. For every 2 Success Points, heal **1 Light Wound**. In addition, if your Pressure is at least 1, heal **1 Aggravated Wound**.
  - **Conscious Enemy (Hazard):** Make a melee attack using **Hazard**. The attack deals standard melee damage plus bonus damage equal to your current **Pressure** level.

BOOSTER KIT

The Booster Kit delivers aggressive neuro-stimulants, respiratory dilators, and muscular overclocks to shatter biological limits under fire.

Micro-Booster [Rider]

- **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space or an adjacent space declare an action.
- **Effect:** *A pressurized transdermal jet releases a micro-dose of hyper-stimulant into the bloodstream.* Add your active **Volatile Die** to all rolls involved in the declared action's test. If the Volatile Die rolls a Hit (8+), it triggers a Rupture on your ChemPack as normal.

Maximum Effort [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Adrenal superchargers flood motor neurons, amplifying raw physical output.* Roll a **Serum Simple Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice, grant **+1 Upgrade** to all physical tests made by a creature in your space or an adjacent space until the end of the round.

Adrenaline Rush [Free Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Effect:** *An emergency surge of neuro-stimulants accelerates synaptic transmission to hyper-reflexive speeds.* Target yourself or an ally in your space or an adjacent space. The next action taken by the target does not count against the Player Turn limit.

POISON KIT

The Poison Kit synthesizes necrotic toxins, respiratory agents, and systemic catalysts that break down biological structures over sustained engagements.

Envenom [Rider]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you declare a melee strike (against a target in your space or an adjacent space) or fire a weapon at Short range.
- **Effect:** *Pneumatic conduits coat your weapon edge or ammunition jacket in virulent neurotoxin.* The attack gains **+1 bonus damage per Pressure level**. Additionally, you may sacrifice **Hits** rolled on the attack to apply **1 Venom Downgrade per Hit** to the target (subject to your active Venom limit).

Decay [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A resonant acoustic pulse or catalytic compound triggers violent cellular breakdown in previously dosed targets.* Make a **Venom Success Test**. All creatures within Medium range currently suffering from your Venom Downgrades take damage equal to your **Success Points + your Venom Attribute rating**. This action immediately consumes and clears those active Downgrades.

Cloudkill [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom | **Pressure:** `+3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized aerosol grenade shatters on impact, releasing a swirling fog of dense, corrosive vapor.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Venom Success Test**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice, apply **1 level of a Venom Downgrade** to every creature occupying the target space. The cloud heavily obscures vision into, out of, and through that space until the end of the round.

PYRO KIT

The Pyro Kit arms the Hazard with hypergolic liquid mixtures and acoustic atomizers that ignite violently upon atmospheric contact.

Firebolt [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+1 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A focused pneumatic nozzle hurls a pressurized stream of self-igniting chemical gel.* Make a ranged attack using **Hazard** against a target within **Short range (0–5 spaces)**. The attack inflicts thermal damage equal to your test result plus **+1 bonus damage per Pressure level**.

Flamestrike [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *An explosive aerosol canister detonates overhead, bathing the target zone in clinging liquid fire.* Target a space within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** and make a **Hazard Success Test**. All creatures and flammable structures within the chosen space suffer thermal damage equal to your **Success Points + your current Pressure level**.

Flame Ward [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `-3 Pressure` | **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you are targeted by an incoming attack.
- **Effect:** *Emergency purge valves vent a concussive thermal flash outward, deflecting the blow and scorching attackers.* Contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**, rolling your contest pool using your **Hazard** Attribute. If the attacker occupies your space or an adjacent space, they immediately take damage equal to the highest die remaining in your contest pool.

CAUSTIC KIT

The Caustic Kit utilizes hyper-concentrated fluorosulfuric acids and molecular solvents to dissolve inorganic armor plating, vehicle chassis, and structural cover.

Acid Strike [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `+2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized burst of fuming acid coats the target, eating away structural seals and composite armor.* Make a melee attack against a creature or object in your space or an adjacent space using **Venom**. For each **Hit** you sacrifice from your roll, you set aside that Hit as an armor-melting effect on the target. You or an ally can expend a set-aside Hit when dealing damage to the target to completely ignore the target's Physical Protection for that instance of damage.

Caustic Bullets [Rider]

- **Pressure Change:** `+1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you declare a ranged attack with a Firearm.
- **Effect:** *Chambered ammunition is coated in high-potency molecular acid jackets prior to firing.* The attack **ignores the target's Physical Protection entirely**. However, the weapon loses any standard flat Damage Bonus it would normally provide for this shot.

Metal Transfer [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `-2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 0 AP
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in Short range are targeted by an attack or suffer damage.
- **Effect:** *Catalytic bio-conduits siphon dissolved metallic residue from active corrosive agents, instantly flashing a protective metallic film across allied hulls and armor.* Every friendly creature in **Short range (0–5 spaces)** gains **+1 Physical Protection** against the next instance of damage equal to the number of **Hits** you currently have spent and active across your ongoing Venom abilities and Downgrades.

OOZE KIT

The Ooze Kit synthesizes rapid-curing visco-elastic polymers and non-Newtonian fluids to tether adversaries, restrict limbs, and reshape tactical terrain.

Rubberband [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum
- **Pressure Change:** `+1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A high-tensile polymer filament launches from your wrist harness at an anchor point or creature within Short range (0–5 spaces / 16 meters):*
  - **Inanimate Anchor & Terrain:** You are immediately winched in a straight line directly to the anchor point.
  - **Hostile Creature:** Roll a **Serum Simple Test**. If you score at least one Hit, the tether latches on; you can spend any **Hits** from the roll to activate **Push Effects** that pull the target creature 1 space (4 meters) directly towards you per Hit spent (spending a single Hit on this Push Effect still counts the action as a success). Following the pull, you may advance along the tether line any number of spaces towards the target (up to entering its space). If you and the target make contact (ending in the same space), you deal collision damage to the target equal to the highest die rolled.

Slimeball [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom
- **Pressure Change:** `-2 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A pressurized globule of heavy, quick-curing resin engulfs the target's extremities.* Make a ranged attack against a target within **Short range (0–5 spaces)** using **Venom**. Instead of dealing damage, sacrifice **Hits** from the roll to establish a **Blocker Effect**:
  - **Locomotion Blocker (Legs/Thrusters):** Negates the target's highest die on movement tests.
  - **Manipulation Blocker (Hands/Weapons):** Negates the target's highest die on weapon attack or manipulation tests.

Slip and Slide [Action]

- **Attribute:** Serum
- **Pressure Change:** `-1 Pressure`
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized nozzles coat deck plates in an ultra-slick surfactant polymer.* Choose a number of adjacent spaces up to your current **Pressure** level (minimum 1 space). Until the start of your next turn, these spaces become **Difficult Terrain** for hostile creatures, and you and your allies gain **+1 Upgrade** on any movement tests made through them.

SMOKE KIT

The Smoke Kit deploys dense chemical aerosols, thermal-scattering smokescreens, and dual-agent particulate clouds to control visual sightlines and tactical positioning.

Smoke Screen [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Dense micro-particulate smoke scatters visual and IR spectrums.* Roll a **Hazard Simple Test**. For each Hit spent, deploy smoke in one chosen space within Short range. Creatures inside cannot see out, and creatures outside cannot see in/through (2 Downgrades to tests requiring vision). Persists until end of round.

Gas Canister [Action]

- **Attribute:** Venom / Serum | **Pressure:** `+2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Dual-stage aerosol disperses tailored compounds.* Target space within Short range, rolling Venom (applies Venom Downgrade to all enemies) or Serum (applies Serum Upgrade to all allies). Sacrifice 1 Hit to isolate to a single target.

Gas Turbine [Action]

- **Attribute:** Hazard | **Pressure:** `-2 Pressure` | **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pneumatic exhaust turbines cycle high-pressure gas into vectored thrust.* Next movement test rolls using Hazard. You ignore Difficult Terrain, can fly, gain +4 SP per Hit on Crit Effects, and ignore all falling damage until end of round.

CLASS MODS

Class Mods cost 25,000 Credits each (socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **Dart Launcher:** Execute baseline actions (Debilitating Dose, Explosive Strike, Performance Dose) at **Short range (0–5 spaces)** instead of melee reach.
- **Pressure Controls:** Alter an ability's Pressure cost/change by **+1 or -1** (cannot shift positive to negative or vice versa).
- **Critical Rupture:** When Volatile Die rolls a Hit (8+), score the Hit and reroll the Volatile Die (chaining bonus Hits), suffering a Rupture (2 Light Wounds, Pressure vents to 0) for each Hit scored in the chain.
- **Catalyst Controls:** At the start of each combat round, freely set your Catalyst Chamber Pressure to **any value of your choice (0, 1, 2, or 3)**.
- **Redline Engine:** Activate abilities even if positive cost exceeds Pressure 3 (resolves at max Pressure 3, then triggers an automatic Rupture: 2 Light Wounds, vents to 0).

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Points** among Venom, Hazard, and Serum (base `1 / 1 / 1`, max 5). You begin with **1 Kit**.

HAZARD CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Kit, Pressure Engine (Max 3)	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Kit	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Kit	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Kit	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL HAZARD ARCHETYPES

- **The Toxic Saboteur:** Focuses on Venom, Envenom, and Cloudkill. Scours cover with acidic gas, sets up crippling neurotoxin Downgrades, and collapses enemy formations with Decay.
- **The Combat Alchemist:** Balances Hazard with Pyro and Smoke. Dominates corridors with high-pressure Flamestrikes and thermal smoke screens, controlling lines of sight.
- **The Field Surgeon:** Maximizes Serum with Medic and Booster kits. Delivers combat-critical heals, clears mental stress, and overclocks allied initiative with emergency stimulants.

CLASS: THE PILOT

The Pilot is defined by direct neuro-synaptic synchronization with a specialized Pilot-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*)—a motorized bio-mechanical frame that serves as both a wearable exoskeleton and an autonomous tele-operated Exodrone. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cranial shunt ports along the neck and temples, the rig allows the Pilot to operate the external frame as a natural extension of their own nervous system. Visually, a Pilot presents an imposing, industrial silhouette. Lightweight ceramic-composite plating and subdermal shock-absorbing harnesses fit beneath the Exodrone's shifting mechanical carapace. In its dormant, docked configuration, the chassis folds tightly along the Pilot's spine like a segmented pair of metallic wings, its hydraulic solenoids hissing softly in rhythm with the user's pulse and cooling fans humming against the operative's back.

In active combat, the Exodrone acts as an instrument of overwhelming mechanical force, driven by high-density solid-state battery banks and pneumatic actuators. When locked to the operative's spinal harness in Attached Mode, the Exodrone reinforces the Pilot's skeletal structure, allowing them to sprint through heavy automatic fire, shatter reinforced security bulkheads with hydraulic strikes, or stabilize heavy squad weapons without recoil fatigue. The true tactical genius of the chassis emerges when the locking pins disengage, allowing the Exodrone to detach and operate as an independent avatar. Governed by high-frequency telemetry feeds, the detached drone can advance into hazardous breaches, lay down suppressive fire from elevated vantages, provide physical barricades for pinned allies, or administer emergency trauma triage in hot landing zones while the Pilot directs operations from secure cover.

The operational versatility of the Pilot MANTLE chassis is defined by its modular firmware architecture. Rather than locking the operative into a singular battlefield duty, the Exodrone can be reconfigured with specialized hardware packages between engagements. A Pilot can optimize their frame for close-quarters breach and clear with high-frequency vibro-blades, calibrate its hardpoints into a heavy shoulder-mounted ballistic and laser artillery platform, mount pneumatic vector thrusters for frictionless three-dimensional boarding actions, or equip surgical micro-manipulators for life-saving combat stabilization. In any theater of operations, the Pilot ensures the cell possesses both a fortified anchor and a versatile remote presence capable of shifting the tactical balance at a moment's notice.

ATTRIBUTES

The Exodrone possesses its own signature set of physical Attributes that reflect its mechanical capabilities:

- **Power:** The raw mechanical torque, hydraulic lifting capacity, and kinetic impact force generated by the Exodrone's articulated frame (corresponds to **Strength**).
- **Speed:** The rapid servo response, thruster acceleration, and swift evasive articulation of the Exodrone (corresponds to **Agility**).
- **Precision:** The micrometric fine-motor dexterity, targeting telemetry, and sensor alignment of the Exodrone (corresponds to **Finesse**).

MECHANICS

EXODRONE MODES

The Exodrone operates in two distinct operational states: Attached Mode and Detached Mode.

- **Attached Mode:** While docked to your spinal interface, the Exodrone reinforces your natural anatomy. Whenever you make a test involving **Strength**, **Agility**, or **Finesse**, you may choose to substitute your own Core Attribute with the Exodrone's corresponding Attribute (**Power**, **Speed**, or **Precision**).
- **Detached Mode:** When decoupled from your harness, the Exodrone acts as an autonomous tele-operated proxy. The Exodrone can navigate and take actions independently on the battlefield. When the Exodrone makes a test, it forms test pools using its own physical Attributes (for example, a test requiring Strength and Agility resolves using **Power + Speed**, while a pure Strength test resolves using **Power + Power**). If a test requires an Attribute the Exodrone does not possess (such as mental Attributes like **Knowledge**, **Presence**, or **Instinct**), the Exodrone cannot perform that action independently.

CORE CHASSIS OPERATIONS

Every Pilot understands the foundational operation of their Exodrone chassis:

- **Detach [Free Action]:** You decouple the Exodrone from your spinal harness for **0 AP** and **0 Batteries**. The Exodrone deploys into your current space and enters Detached Mode. You may perform this action once per turn.
- **Attach [Free Action]:** You magnetically dock the Exodrone onto your spinal interface for **0 AP** and **0 Batteries** while occupying the same space as the Exodrone. The Exodrone enters Attached Mode. You may perform this action once per turn.
- **Drone Commands:** While the Exodrone is in Detached Mode, you command it over your neural link. Directing the Exodrone to move, make an attack, or perform a test costs **1 AP** from your standard 3 Action Point pool.
- **Overdrive Command [Free Action]:** You transmit an overclocked neural surge to the detached Exodrone, expending **4 Batteries**. The Exodrone immediately gains **1 Action Point** to take an action for **0 of your own AP**.

BATTERY POWER CELLS

The Exodrone's high-torque actuators, energy carbines, and specialized modules are powered by a central bank of high-density solid-state batteries:

- **Capacity:** The Exodrone can store a maximum of **10 Batteries**.
- **Expenditure:** Activating specialized Pilot abilities expends a designated number of Batteries from this reserve.
- **Recharging:** At the beginning of each Round, the Exodrone automatically recharges **2 Batteries** if it is in Attached Mode. While in Detached Mode, it recharges 0 Batteries. During place-to-place or day-to-day pacing, the Battery pool automatically refills to maximum (10).
- **Damage & Shutdown:** When the Exodrone suffers damage while in Detached Mode, its physical casing and capacitors absorb the shock: it loses **1 Battery for every 4 points of damage suffered**, rounded down. If the Exodrone's Battery pool drops to **0 Batteries**, it enters an emergency shutdown state, collapsing and ceasing all functions until it recharges at least 1 Battery.

PILOT ABILITIES

The Pilot customizes their Exodrone through specialized hardware and software **Modules**. Each Module is a cohesive package of three coordinated abilities designed for a distinct tactical focus. Operatives learn one complete Module (3 abilities) at Level 1, and unlock an additional Module at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

WINGMAN MODULE

The Wingman Module emphasizes tactical synergy and coordinated maneuvers between the operative and their detached Exodrone.

Boost [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Limit:** Max 3 per turn
- **Effect:** You route auxiliary current to the Exodrone's primary servos. The Exodrone gains **+1 Upgrade** to any one chosen Exodrone Attribute until the beginning of the next Player Turn.

Double Move [Rider]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Trigger:** When you take a Movement Action during the Player Turn.
- **Effect:** Fluid coordination allows the Exodrone to reposition alongside you. The Exodrone immediately executes a full Movement Action for **0 additional AP**.

Tag Team [Rider]

- **Cost:** 3 Batteries
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode, occupying the same space as the Pilot.
- **Trigger:** When you declare an action or attack.
- **Effect:** The Exodrone coordinates seamlessly with your strike. The Exodrone participates in your action using **Teamwork** for **0 additional AP**.

WARDEN MODULE

The Warden Module configures the Exodrone into a hardened defensive bastion, absorbing ballistic trauma and providing mobile cover for the cell.

Armadillo [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Limit:** Once per round
- **Requirement:** Attached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone shifts its interlocking ceramic plates across your vitals. Your Physical Protection increases by **+2** until the end of the Round.

Guardian [Reaction]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Trigger:** When the Exodrone is targeted by an attack.
- **Effect:** Automated counter-deflection routines engage. The Exodrone can contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**.

Barricade [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone drops into a low-profile posture and drives hydraulic anchoring spikes into the deck, converting itself into deployable mobile cover until the end of the round. The Cover Rating of the Exodrone's current space increases by **+1**. While configured as a barricade, the only action the Exodrone can take is to disengage its anchors and revert to standard mode for **0 AP**.

DUELIST MODULE

The Duelist Module transforms the Exodrone into a lethal close-quarters combatant, mounting high-frequency cutting edges for silent breaches and melee skirmishes.

Shadow Strike [Rider]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Requirement:** Attached Mode, or occupying the same space as the target in Detached Mode.
- **Trigger:** After successfully landing a melee attack.
- **Effect:** The Exodrone executes an immediate hydraulic follow-up blow. Add bonus damage to your attack equal to the Exodrone Attribute corresponding to the Physical Attribute used in your attack.

Power Weapons [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** The Exodrone extends twin wrist-mounted powered weapons of your choice between vibro-blades, shock-batons, or pneumatic spikes, remaining active until the end of the round. They function as dual-wielded 1H melee weapons with a **Damage Bonus of 1 plus your Pilot Level**, allowing you to choose between **Slashing** (favored pair **Agility + Strength**), **Striking** (favored pair **Strength + Finesse**) or **Piercing** (favored pair **Agility + Finesse**) damage for your melee attacks.

Plasma Lance [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone locks its articulated frame and unleashes a superheated thermal cutting lance in a devastating thrust against a target or structural barrier. Make a single melee attack using any melee attribute pair. On a hit, this attack deals damage with a **Damage Bonus equal to 2 plus your Pilot Level**. This damage completely ignores the target's Physical Protection (including armor, shields, and cover).

ARSENAL MODULE

The Arsenal Module outfits the Exodrone with heavy ranged weaponry, transforming it into a versatile mobile weapons platform.

Laser Carbine [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** The Exodrone deploys a wrist-mounted pulsed laser carbine, remaining active until the end of the round. It features the following firearm profile: `Acc: [3/2/1/-], Dmg: +1 + Pilot Class Level, RoF: 2`.

Shoulder Cannon [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone locks its chassis and discharges a concentrated high-output optical blast from its shoulder-mounted heavy laser: `Acc: [1/4/3/2], Dmg: +4 + Pilot Class Level, RoF: 0`.

Plasma Grenade [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Effect:** The Exodrone produces a small blob of superheated plasma and lobs it at any target space within Short range (0–5 spaces). The blob acts as a grenade with the following profile: `Ordnance: 3 + Pilot Class Level, 2m Radius`.

ASSAULT MODULE

The Assault Module enhances dynamic movement, enabling the Exodrone to scale vertical obstacles, drop from high altitudes, and close combat distances rapidly.

Full Throttle [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Effect:** Overcharging hydraulic leg actuators, you or your Exodrone sprint up to 12 meters in a straight line directly into a hostile creature's space and execute a melee attack as part of the same action.

Spider Climb [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery
- **Effect:** Micro-fiber magnetic clamps engage across the Exodrone's extremities. Until the end of the round, the Exodrone gains **Surface Adhesion**, allowing it to move across vertical bulkheads and sheer ceilings as regular terrain.

Jump Pack [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone fires integrated vector thrusters, gaining the **Mobility** virtual item attribute equal to 3 + Pilot Class Level. Until the end of round, the Exodrone's and the wearer's base movement speed becomes 12, it may sacrifice Hits on movement tests to gain +4 meters of movement per Hit spent and it and its wearer ignores difficult terrain and all damage from falling until end of turn. If in mid-air, it falls at the end of the Player Turn, taking no damage.

RECON MODULE

The Recon Module equips the Exodrone with adaptive optical cloaking, remote neural telepresence, and electronic infiltration tools.

Active Camouflage [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone activates adaptive light-refracting micro-panels, establishing a Persistent Blocker Effect against hostile detection from outside your space until the end of the round. Any tests that benefit from remaining unseen gain **+1 Upgrade**.

Neural Relay [Passive]

- **Effect:** The direct duplex telemetry feed between your NCC and the Exodrone streams full sensory perception. While the Exodrone is in Detached Mode, it can utilize your own mental Attributes (**Knowledge**, **Presence**, and **Instinct**) to perform tests, allowing it to scout hostile spaces, slice electronic terminals, or perform technical analysis remotely.

Omni Tool [Action]

- **Cost:** 1 Battery, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone interfaces directly with an electronic terminal, locked hatch, or sensor console in its space, forcing the device to perform any standard function without requiring an external tool. When executing the hack, roll the Exodrone's highest physical Attribute in place of Finesse.

SERAPH MODULE

The Seraph Module equips the Exodrone with emergency trauma medicine and vital-sign resuscitation hardware, allowing it to stabilize wounded operatives under fire.

First Aid [Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries (increasing by +1 Battery for each additional use within the same Round)
- **Effect:** In Attached Mode, the Exodrone administers rapid trauma coagulants and painkillers to you, immediately healing **2 Light Wounds**. In Detached Mode, the Exodrone injects a target friendly creature occupying its current space, healing **2 Light Wounds**.

Healer Darts [Free Action]

- **Cost:** 2 Batteries
- **Effect:** The Exodrone deploys a pneumatic dart projector, active until the end of the round. It features the following profile: `Acc: [2/-/-/-], Dmg: 0, RoF: 0`. On a successful hit against an ally, rather than dealing damage, the dart injects stimulant biomaterials that heal **1 Light Wound for every 2 Success Points** scored on the attack roll.

Trauma Protocol [Action]

- **Cost:** 4 Batteries, 1 AP
- **Requirement:** Detached Mode
- **Effect:** The Exodrone moves into the space of an incapacitated or dying ally, locking its armored chassis around the patient. Make an emergency medicine test using the Exodrone's Precision + your Instinct: each 2 SP heals 1 Light Wound, or each 4 SP clears 1 Aggravated Wound. If the target was killed during the current Round, scoring at least 2 SP revives the target with 1 Light Wound. While clamped onto an ally, all incoming damage targeting that ally is redirected to the Exodrone until it detaches.

CLASS MODS & PROGRESSION

Pilot Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each and can be installed into open chassis mod slots (unlocked at Levels 3 and 5; maximum 2 active mods):

- **Solid-State Expansion Bank:** Auxiliary battery capacitors expand the Exodrone's total storage capacity from 10 to **12 Batteries**.
- **Tethered Inductive Field:** Hardened induction coils reinforce the Exodrone's damage dissipation. While in Detached Mode, the Exodrone loses 1 Battery per **6 points of damage suffered** (instead of 4). In addition, the Exodrone recharges 1 Battery at the start of each round even while in Detached Mode.
- **Biomechanical Dynamo:** Micro-generators capture the kinetic energy of your physical movements. While in Attached Mode, whenever you score Hits on a physical test, you may convert 1 Hit into **1 Battery** recharged (up to your maximum capacity).
- **Kinetic Overclock:** Activating any Pilot ability routes surplus current to all secondary actuators, granting **+1 Upgrade** to the Exodrone's next test before the end of your turn. This effect stacks up to twice per turn.
- **Standby Capacitor Loop:** If no Battery abilities were activated during a Round, the Exodrone's idle induction cycle automatically stores **2 additional Batteries** at the end of the Round.

PILOT CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Module, Battery Engine	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Module (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

CLASS: THE VANGUARD

The Vanguard is the cell's frontline breaker and kinetic specialist, defined by their neural synchronization with a specialized Vanguard-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) and its adaptable multi-segment Board. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cervical shunt, the rig interfaces with subdermal balance nodes embedded along the user's calves, spine, and forearms. Mounted along the operative's spine via a high-torque magnetic docking latch, this articulated piece of aerospace-grade hardware consists of interlocking ceramic-composite plates, micro-servos, and pneumatic locking pins that read minute shifts in center of mass, transmitting physical balance feedback at the speed of reflex. In its dormant state, the folded chassis rests as a compact, streamlined dorsal carapace across the operative's back, often scarred by shrapnel deflection or thermal wash from high-speed descents.

In active combat, the Board functions as an instrument of relentless momentum, transforming between three distinct operational geometries at a moment's notice. When facing suppressive fire, the chassis snaps forward into the Vanguard's off-hand, locking into a broad, reinforced **Shield** engineered to disperse heavy ballistic impacts and batter through enemy barricades in close-quarters breaches. When rapid repositioning or flanking becomes necessary, the mechanism deploys beneath the user's boots as a hoverboard **Glider**, engaging vectored thrusters to skim over hazardous terrain, traverse zero-gravity gaps, and launch the operative into aerial drop attacks. When distant threats demand decisive force, the Board hinges outward into a heavy shoulder-slung or hip-braced **Cannon**, cycling heavy penetrator rounds capable of punching clean through bulkhead plating and mechanized armor.

The true tactical depth of the Vanguard MANTLE chassis lies in the fluid, stance-dancing rhythm of its kinetic engine. Rather than committing to a single combat posture, an experienced Vanguard continuously reconfigures the Board mid-assault, converting the mechanical torque of each form swap into banked **Boost** dice that fuel explosive combo techniques. Whether shattering enemy defensive lines with a boosted shield charge, surfing over crossfire to extract a pinned ally, or laying down devastating artillery blasts from elevated vantage points, the Vanguard commands the pace of engagement. Their presence ensures the cell possesses an immovable defensive anchor, an agile vanguard scout, and a heavy fire-support platform unified in a single operative.

ATTRIBUTES

The Vanguard's three primary Attributes correspond to the different forms their Board can take:

- **Shield:** The toughness, structural mass, and kinetic impact absorption of its shield form.
- **Glider:** The speed, vector acceleration, and frictionless maneuverability of its hoverboard form.
- **Cannon:** The penetrative power, optical range, and ballistic precision of its ranged weapon form.

MECHANICS

VANGUARD FORMS

The Vanguard's Board has three different forms, corresponding to the three Attributes in its kit. Each form provides distinct tactical benefits:

- **Shield:** While in Shield Form, your Physical Protection increases by half your Shield Attribute, rounded down. You can also use the Shield as a Striking melee weapon (rolling **Strength + Shield**), dealing bonus damage equal to the lower Attribute in the pair (Strength or Shield). You can also use your Shield Attribute to contest most forms of incoming harm. You have one hand occupied while in Shield Form. You typically rely on **Strength** in Shield Form.
- **Glider:** While in Glider Form, you can use your Glider Attribute in any movement action you take. You also ignore Difficult Terrain and fall damage. While in the air, you can move horizontally or downward, but not upward, and only using your Glider Attribute. You have both hands free while in Glider Form. You typically rely on **Agility** in Glider Form.
- **Cannon:** While in Cannon Form, you can make a ranged attack using your Board. Its Accuracy is equal to your Cannon Attribute at short range and one less at every subsequent range band. If you would get negative Accuracy, you cannot shoot at that range. You have both hands occupied in Cannon Form. You typically rely on **Finesse** in Cannon Form.

SWITCHING & SWAPPING FORMS

The Board is an adaptable kinetic weapon chassis capable of rapid mechanical reconfiguration. Its operational state is governed by two core concepts:

- **Current Form & Shifting Forms:** Whenever you roll a test that uses one of your Vanguard Attributes (such as a melee attack with **Shield**, a Movement Action with **Glider**, or a ranged attack with **Cannon**) or activate a Vanguard ability, your Board automatically shifts into that Form immediately prior to resolving the action. You remain in that form until your Board transforms again. Taking a test with a Vanguard Attribute or executing an ability inherently counts as a **Form Move** for that Form during the current turn.
- **Specific Form & Setup Requirements:** While most abilities automatically shift your Board into their associated Form upon activation, certain abilities have specific prerequisites:
  - **Required Starting Form:** Reactions and defensive stances (such as *Repulse* and *Brick Wall*) require you to *already* be in that specific Form when triggered.
  - **Form Moves:** Kinetic combo follow-ups (such as *Turbo Slam*) require a preceding Form Move to build the necessary momentum.
  - **Situational Requirements:** Aerial maneuvers (such as *Meteor Crash*) require specific environmental positioning (e.g. being at least 4 meters above your target space).

BOOSTS & FORM MOMENTUM

To channel kinetic momentum into explosive combos, the Vanguard banks kinetic energy as **Boost** dice. A **Boost** is a single banked **d10** die. You can hold only **one** Boost die at a time in your reserve (unless increased by Class Mods like *Twin Turbo*). Banked Boost dice power signature Vanguard combo finishers and riders, or bolster regular actions.

Gaining a Boost: There are two ways to generate and bank a Boost die:

1. **Active Form Swap (1 AP):** Spend **1 AP** to swap into any of your three forms (Shield, Glider, or Cannon). Swapping immediately places you in that form, counts as a **Form Move**, and grants a banked **d10 Boost die** (replacing any previously held Boost).
2. **Banking a Hit:** When rolling a test using a Vanguard Attribute while holding no Boost die, you may bank one **Hit (8+)** from the roll into your reserve as a **d10 Boost die** (that die does not contribute to successes or effects).

Spending a Boost: Spend your Boost die by rolling it and adding it to any Vanguard test pool (before or after the roll). Many abilities also consume your active Boost die to unleash devastating kinetic strikes, high-altitude maneuvers, or heavy artillery blasts.

The Golden Rule of Boosts: You can either spend or gain a Boost during a test or action, but never both. You cannot gain a Boost on an action where you spent a Boost, and a newly gained Boost is banked to fuel future actions.

VANGUARD ABILITIES

The Vanguard reconfigures their Board into coordinated combat routines called **Combos**. Each Combo contains three synergized abilities: an opening setup, a devastating finisher, and a responsive tactical rider or passive.

Operatives learn one complete Combo (3 abilities) at Level 1, and unlock an additional Combo at Levels 2, 3, and 4. Activating an ability automatically shifts your Board into that ability's **Form**, unless noted.

SENTINEL COMBO

The Sentinel Combo emphasizes frontline defense, utilizing shield throws to scatter enemy formations and reactive bracing to protect against incoming fire.

Shield Throw [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Effect:** You hurl your Board in Shield Form up to 20 meters as a ranged melee attack (rolling **Strength + Shield**). The Shield ricochets off the target and snaps immediately back to your magnetic gauntlet. It deals your standard Shield melee damage at range.

Ricochet [Rider]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Trigger:** When your **Shield Throw** successfully hits a target.
- **Effect:** You may expend your active **Boost** die. If you do, kinetic resonance arcs through the target's space: every other hostile creature in that space suffers damage equal to the damage dealt to the primary target.

Repulse [Reaction]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Shield Form (must already be in Shield Form)
- **Trigger:** When you are targeted by an attack while in Shield Form.
- **Effect:** You can contest the incoming attack using your Shield Attribute for **0 AP** by expending your active **Boost** die. Add the **Boost** die directly to your contest roll.

FALLINGSTAR COMBO

The Fallingstar Combo harnesses explosive vertical lift and high-altitude drops, crushing enemy clusters beneath devastating shockwaves.

Rocket Jump [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** You angle your Cannon directly into the ground beneath you and fire a high-pressure kinetic blast, rolling a **Cannon Success Test** (you may expend and add your active **Boost** die to this test). The blast deals damage to all creatures in your space equal to your Cannon Attribute; if you expended a **Boost** die on the test, it instead deals damage to all creatures in your space equal to the highest die rolled. The explosion immediately lifts you 4 meters straight up into the air, and you can spend any **Hits** from the test to activate **Push Effects** on yourself. This action also counts as a **Glider Move**.

Meteor Crash [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Elevated position (must fall or dive from at least 4 meters above your target space).
- **Effect:** You slam directly into the space beneath you, ignoring all fall damage. You deal damage equal to your Shield Attribute to all creatures in the target space. If you expend an active **Boost** die, roll the Boost die and add the rolled result to the total damage dealt.

Air Trick [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Trigger:** When taking a Movement Action using your Glider (Glider Move) starting from solid ground.
- **Effect:** You can convert horizontal thrust into vertical flight for up to 4 meters of your movement, easily leaping 4 meters into the air to set up a devastating **Meteor Crash**. You fall at the end of the Player Turn unless sustained by another ability.

FALCON COMBO

The Falcon Combo is engineered for rapid skirmishing, frictionless traversal, and high-altitude momentum, allowing the Vanguard to reposition across the battlefield and strike without becoming pinned.

Rocketeer [Action]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Effect:** You make a Glider Movement Action and fly for the entire duration of the movement. If you expend an active **Boost** die, add the Boost die to your movement test roll; you double the rolled movement distance and fly at extreme velocity without altitude loss until the end of the Player Turn.

Hit and Run [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Requirement:** Glider Move (must have completed a Glider Move this turn).
- **Trigger:** As part of declaring any melee attack.
- **Effect:** You can move a number of meters equal to your **Glider Attribute × 4 meters** either immediately before or immediately after making the attack. This movement is completely fluid and cannot be contested by enemies.

Windsurfer [Passive]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Effect:** While in Glider Form, you do not fall at the end of the Player Turn. Instead, you remain suspended at your current altitude. You can maneuver horizontally across the airspace as long as you use your Glider to move. If you swap out of Glider Form, you fall at the end of that Player Turn.

SCORPION COMBO

The Scorpion Combo converts the Vanguard's Board into a heavy ballistic platform, laying down sustained automatic suppressive fire and punishing openings with devastating follow-up cannonades.

Assault Cannon [Passive]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Your Board reconfigures into an Assault Cannon. While in Cannon Form, your weapon gains a **Damage Bonus of +2** and a **Rate of Fire of 2**, but suffers **-1 Accuracy** across all range bands. This configuration cannot be combined with *Long Cannon* (if you possess both abilities, you choose which configuration your Cannon Form takes during downtime).

Charged Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Make a ranged attack using your Cannon, expending your active **Boost** die. Add the **Boost** die to your attack roll. On a hit, you puncture the target's armor, dealing bonus damage equal to your Cannon Attribute.

Follow Up [Rider]

- **Form:** Any Form
- **Trigger:** After successfully landing any attack in any form (Shield, Glider, or Cannon).
- **Effect:** You can immediately pay **1 AP** to deliver a point-blank snap shot with your Cannon against the target, dealing bonus damage equal to your Cannon Attribute. If you expend an active **Boost** die, roll the Boost die and add damage equal to the result you rolled. This attack immediately swaps your Board into Cannon Form. You can execute this follow-up even if the Player Turn would otherwise end.

RHINO COMBO

The Rhino Combo focuses on battlefield displacement and immovable close-quarters enforcement, harpooning priority targets, smashing them into structural barriers, and locking down all movement.

Hook Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** You fire a high-tensile magnetic kinetic tether from your Cannon at an anchor point or creature up to Short range (16 meters):
  - **Inanimate Anchor:** You are immediately winched in a straight line directly to the anchor point.
  - **Hostile Creature:** Roll a **Cannon + Finesse Simple Test**. If no Hits are scored, the shot misses and the tether snaps back. If you score at least one Hit, the tether latches on; you can spend any **Hits** from the roll to activate **Push Effects** that pull the target creature 1 space (4 meters) directly towards you per Hit spent (even if you only roll a single Hit, spending it on this Push Effect still counts the Hook Shot as a success). Following the pull, you may advance along the tether line any number of spaces towards the target (up to entering its space). If you and the target make contact (ending in the same space), you deal collision damage to the target equal to the highest die rolled. This action also counts as a **Glider Move**.

Turbo Slam [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Glider Move (must have completed a Glider Move this turn, such as advancing via *Hook Shot* or Glider movement, to convert kinetic momentum into impact force).
- **Effect:** Make a melee strike with your Shield, dealing bonus damage equal to your Shield Attribute. If the target is large or smaller, you may push it a number of meters equal to the damage dealt. If the pushed creature collides with solid cover, a bulkhead, or another combatant, it suffers bonus damage equal to your Shield Attribute again.

Brick Wall [Reaction]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Requirement:** Shield Form (must already be in Shield Form)
- **Trigger:** When a creature attempts to move across or out of your space while you are in Shield Form.
- **Effect:** Contest the creature's movement using your Shield Attribute. If you succeed, their movement is halted, and they take damage equal to the highest die you eliminated from their roll. You can also trigger this reaction to contest forced movement triggered by your allies during the Player Turn, even if the Player Turn would normally end.

ROOK COMBO

The Rook Combo transforms the Vanguard into an immovable battlefield bastion, deploying reinforced fortifications to shelter squad members, ferrying allies rapidly across hostile firing lanes, and returning heavy ranged fire from behind hardened ballistic plating.

Gun Shield [Passive]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Effect:** Your Board's Shield Form incorporates an articulated weapon brace and magnetic clamp. You can wield and fire a two-handed firearm while in Shield Form, retaining your Shield Form's Physical Protection bonus (+SHD/2).

Hitchhiker [Rider]

- **Form:** Glider
- **Requirement:** Glider Move
- **Trigger:** When declaring a Movement Action using your Glider.
- **Effect:** One willing ally in your space or an adjacent space can latch onto your harness or board. They are carried with you for the full duration of your movement for **0 AP**, ending their movement in your destination space. If you end your movement by swapping into Shield Form or deploying your **Tactical Barricade**, the hitched ally immediately shares the fortified space and its cover. You can expend an active **Boost** die to add the Boost die to your movement test roll and carry up to two allies simultaneously.

Tactical Barricade [Action]

- **Form:** Shield
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** You spend 1 AP to drive your Board into the ground, deploying an immovable kinetic barricade that provides **Medium Cover (+2 Protection)** to you and any allies within your space against attacks originating from outside the space. If you expend an active **Boost** die when deploying the barricade, it reinforces into **Heavy Cover (+3 Protection)**. Occupants sheltering behind the barricade are anchored and immune to forced movement (such as push or pull effects). Enemies cannot enter or cross the barricade's space without succeeding on an opposed contest against your **Shield**. You can reclaim the Board back into standard Shield Form for **0 AP** whenever you declare a Movement Action or swap forms.

HAWK COMBO

The Hawk Combo configures the Board into an extreme-range precision marksman rifle, utilizing gyroscopic stabilization and telemetry tracking across vast engagement distances.

Long Cannon [Passive]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Effect:** Your Board reconfigures into a Long Cannon sniper platform. While in Cannon Form, your Board suffers **-1 Accuracy** at Short range, gains **+1 Accuracy** at Long and Extreme range, and gains a **Damage Bonus of +2** when firing at Medium range or farther. This configuration cannot be combined with *Assault Cannon* (if you possess both abilities, you choose which configuration your Cannon Form takes during downtime).

Tracking Shot [Action]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Effect:** Make a ranged attack using your Long Cannon against a visible target. For each Hit you choose to set aside from the attack roll, you paint the target with a persistent telemetry tag, granting an automatic Hit on your next ranged attack made against that target during the current Round.

Overwatch [Reaction]

- **Form:** Cannon
- **Cost:** 1 AP
- **Trigger:** When a target affected by your Tracking Shot tag declares an action or attempts a Movement Action.
- **Effect:** You consume 1 automatic Hit granted by Tracking Shot to fire an intercepting snap shot at the target before its declared action resolves. Roll a **Cannon Success Test** to determine the damage dealt by the shot.

CLASS MODS

Vanguard Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each and can be socketed into open chassis mod slots (unlocked at Levels 3 and 5; maximum 2 active mods):

- **Twin Turbo:** Advanced dual-capacitor banks allow you to hold up to two **Boost** dice at the same time. When spending Boost, you may choose to expend one or both banked dice on the same action.
- **Cheat Move:** Once per round, you can change your Board's form without spending AP (**0 AP**), and this transition still counts as a legitimate **Form Move** for combo prerequisites.
- **Head Start:** At the start of each Round during combat pacing, you can swap to any desired Form for free (**0 AP**). If you do not currently hold a Boost die, you immediately gain one **d10 Boost die**.
- **Hesitation Moves:** Inertial stabilizers preserve kinetic charge. You qualify for Form Move requirements if you performed the corresponding Form Move at any point during the current **Round**, rather than strictly during your current turn.
- **Boost Buildup:** At the end of the Player Turn, if you have remained in the same Form and have not swapped Forms during that turn, kinetic pressure builds up and grants you one **d10 Boost die**.

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Class Creation Points** among Shield, Glider, and Cannon (base 1 / 1 / 1; maximum starting rating of 5). You begin with **1 complete Combo** of your choice.

VANGUARD CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Combo, Boost Engine	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Combo (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

CLASS: THE WEAVER

The Weaver is the cell's master of molecular manipulation and on-the-fly fabrication, defined by total neural command over a specialized Weaver-pattern MANTLE (*Modular Adaptive Neural Transmission Linked Equipment*) housing millions of microscopic Nanites. Controlled directly through the operative's permanent Neural Control Chip (NCC) and cranial shunt, the rig centers around pressurized titanium-ceramic reservoirs anchored to the thoracic spine and routed across the body through subdermal micro-manifolds. Visually, a Weaver cuts an unmistakable, iridescent silhouette. Dormant nanite fluid constantly cycles across their person, pooling into shifting metallic scarves, flowing cloaks, or reinforced layers of kinetic weave that shimmer with subtle chromatic pulses. With a single neuro-synaptic impulse, these fluid fabrics can instantly solidify into razor-sharp monomolecular blades, lock into rigid ballistic plating, or atomize into an airborne cloud of micro-mechanical dust.

In active combat, the Weaver's reservoir operates under hard-science principles of programmable matter and high-frequency magnetic confinement fields. Billions of microscopic, multi-jointed alloy nodes rapidly interlock at the molecular level, allowing the Weaver to fabricate tools, forge weapons, or reinforce structural bulkheads in mere seconds. The experience of commanding the swarm is intensely tactile; operatives describe a distinct hum along their nerve endings as high-density telemetry streams back through their shunt port, conveying the structural integrity, surface tension, and molecular density of their creations in real time. Rather than carrying cumbersome bags of situational gear, the Weaver carries raw structural potential, reshaping their metallic fluid to solve logistical hurdles or tactical crises as they unfold.

The modular versatility of the Weaver MANTLE chassis makes it the ultimate force multiplier across all operational theaters. An operative can tune their nanite suspension into solid-state ballistic shields and physical armor to anchor a defensive perimeter, forge high-leverage melee blades or precision-calibrated long guns, weave aerodynamic aerofoils for effortless 3D flight, or flood allied tissue with cellular micro-sutures and clotting agents for emergency field triage. In technical environments, the nanite swarm can infiltrate sealed data ports and electronic consoles, short-circuiting security networks from the inside out. Whatever the mission demands, the Weaver ensures the cell is never without the right tool for the job.

ATTRIBUTES

A Weaver's capabilities are governed by three Class Attributes:

- **Create:** Molecular structural synthesis, solidifying dormant nanite fluid into functional physical tools, shields, and armaments.
- **Control:** Telemetric dynamic manipulation, guiding active swarms and directing forged constructs across spatial vectors.
- **Modify:** Precision lattice bonding, infusing existing equipment, physical structures, and organic tissue with adaptive nanite layers.

BASIC MECHANICS

When utilizing nanite capabilities, you roll tests using your Weaver Attributes. By default, your raw nanites can only create, modify, or manipulate simple objects that do not possess combat statistics or specialized properties—such as basic prybars, ropes, lockpicks, simple furniture, or utilitarian covers. Forging functional weapons, ballistic armor, medical consumables, or electronic viruses requires unlocking the corresponding **Nanite Weaves**.

To execute a nanite test, you declare your narrative action and pair your chosen Weaver Attribute with an appropriate Core Attribute (`Class + Core`), or with another Weaver Attribute (`Class + Class`). For example, combine **Create + Strength** to forge a heavy prybar and wrench open a jammed hatch, pair **Create + Finesse** to fabricate a micro-lockpick and align security tumblers, roll **Control + Instinct** to thread a nanite sensory cable beneath a blast door, or use **Modify + Presence** to subtly alter the identification text and seal on an executive credential.

THE NANITE RESERVOIR

Every Weaver maintains a physical reserve of programmable matter, measured in **Reserve**:

- **Baseline Capacity:** Operatives start with a capacity of **4 Reserve**.
- **Physical Volume:** A single point of Reserve corresponds to roughly 1 liter of concentrated nanite fluid held within the operative's pressurized dorsal canisters and subcutaneous manifold lines.
- **Material Scale & Density:** Stretched to its structural limits, 1 Reserve can produce a 24-meter cable, a 1-square-meter rigid surface, or handheld items equivalent to Load 1–2:
  - **1 Reserve:** Handheld tools, cables, grappling hooks, 1H weapons, simple containers (Load 1–2).
  - **2 Reserve:** Ladders, chairs, full hazard suits, 2H firearms, deployable barriers (Load 3–4).
  - **3 Reserve:** Reinforced benches, heavy 1m × 1m blast walls, pressurized airlocks (Load 5–6).
- **Workspace Limitation:** You deploy nanites in the **space you currently occupy**, unless an ability extends range.
- **Load Invariant:** All items forged purely from nanites have an effective **Load of 0**. Modifications applied to existing equipment preserve that equipment's original Load.
- **Instant Disassembly [Free Action]:** Decouple, liquefy, and siphon creations back into your reservoir at any time for **0 AP**, instantly recovering spent **Reserve**.
- **Reserve Cycles:** When spent Reserve recharges at the start of next round or end of turn, it is actively circulating and cannot be allocated until the duration elapses.

CLASS ABILITIES

Weaver abilities are grouped into thematic packages called **Nanite Weaves**. Each Weave is a tripartite suite containing three specialized applications—one for **Create**, one for **Modify**, and one for **Control**. Operatives select one starting Weave at character creation, and unlock an additional Weave at Levels 2, 3, and 4.

HARDWEAVE

HardWeave configures your nanite swarm into high-density interlocking crystalline lattices engineered to absorb catastrophic kinetic shock and deflect incoming fire.

HardWeave Shield [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Micro-crystallized plates interlock across your forearm to form a rigid ballistic barrier.* You forge a physical shield in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **1H shield** (Min STR 0, Load 0) granting a base **+1 Physical Protection Bonus**. Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent increases the shield's Protection Bonus by **+1**.

HardWeave Armor [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Adaptive fluid seeps into seams and weave layers, hardening upon impact to distribute concussive force.* You reinforce worn armor on yourself or an ally in your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent increases the armor's **Physical Protection by +1** until the end of the round.

HardWeave Block [Reaction]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round)
- **Trigger:** When you or an ally in your space are targeted by an attack.
- **Effect:** *A reactive burst of pressurized nanites flashes outward to deflect an incoming projectile or blade.* You can contest the incoming attack for **0 AP**, rolling your **Contest Roll** using your **Control** Attribute instead of your standard physical Attributes.

SLICEWEAVE

SliceWeave aligns your nanite swarm into high-density cutting geometries, honing edges to monomolecular sharpness capable of parting composite armor and bone with equal ease.

SliceWeave Blade [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Metallic fluid coalesces into an ergonomic hilt and extends a razor-honed blade of solid carbide alloy.* You forge a melee weapon in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **1H melee weapon** (Min STR 0, Load 0, base **Damage Bonus +1**). When forged, declare its damage property: **Piercing** (favored pair **Agility + Finesse**), **Slashing** (favored pair **Agility + Strength**), or **Striking** (favored pair **Strength + Finesse**). Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent increases the weapon's flat **Damage Bonus by +1**.

SliceWeave Edge [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A vibrating monomolecular ribbon bonds along the striking edge of an existing weapon.* You reinforce a melee weapon in your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent increases the weapon's flat **Damage Bonus by +1** until the end of the round.

SliceWeave Slash [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A scything ribbon of high-velocity nanites lashes across the air in a lethal, sweeping arc.* Select your current space or one adjacent space and roll a **Control Success Test**. You inflict **Slashing** damage equal to your **Success Points + your Control Attribute** to all designated targets in the chosen space. You may spend additional available Reserve (which recharges at the start of the next round) to include one additional space per Reserve spent.

BOLTWEAVE

BoltWeave structures nanites into high-tolerance magnetic accelerator barrels, tailored propellant chambers, and aerodynamically perfected kinetic sabots.

BoltWeave Weapon [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Fluid alloy solidifies into a shoulder-fired long gun with calibrated magnetic rails and an optical rail.* You forge a firearm in your space for yourself or an ally. It functions as a **2H firearm** (Min STR 0, Load 0) with a base weapon profile: `Acc: [3 / 2 / 1 / 0], RoF: 1, Dmg: +1`. Roll an Action Roll using **Create**. Each **Hit** spent allows you to calibrate the firearm by selecting one of the following options (you cannot choose the same option twice; different Accuracy band pairs count as separate options):
  - Increase flat **Damage Bonus by +2**.
  - Increase **Rate of Fire (RoF) by +2**.
  - Increase two adjacent **Accuracy bands by +1** each (cannot increase a single band by +2).

BoltWeave Ammo [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Chambered ammunition is coated in high-mass sabot jackets and terminal guidance fins.* You infuse and calibrate the ammunition of an ally occupying your space. Roll an Action Roll using **Modify**. Each **Hit** spent grants that ally's firearm attacks your choice of the following benefits until the end of the round:
  - **+1 Damage Bonus**.
  - **+1 Rate of Fire (RoF)**.
  - **+1 Accuracy in a single range band** (this cannot grant the ability to fire at a range band the weapon cannot naturally engage, marked `-`).

  The spent Reserve recharges at the start of the next round.

BoltWeave Bullet [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Pressurized reservoir coils launch a dense, hyper-velocity slug directly from your harness.* Make a ranged attack against a creature or object within **Short range (0–5 spaces)**, rolling a **Control Success Test**. You inflict kinetic damage equal to your **Success Points + your Control Attribute**.

FLOATWEAVE

FloatWeave integrates aerostatic micro-turbines, magnetic repulsion baffles, and aerodynamic surface foils into your constructs to conquer vertical terrain and master 3D movement.

FloatWeave Infusion [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Effect:** *Internal counter-grav nodes and micro-thrusters allow forged items to hover weightlessly.* Any item or weapon you create with your nanites gains integrated levitation. These creations hover freely within your space, move alongside you without requiring hands to carry, and can be wielded or operated **hands-free** using your **Control or Create** Attribute in place of the normal required Core Attribute (such as firing a hovering BoltWeave rifle or striking with a floating SliceWeave blade).

FloatWeave Wings [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Articulated aerofoil wings of layered composite feather-plates unfold from the recipient's shoulders.* You attach wings to yourself or an ally in your space. The recipient gains **Flight** (base speed 4 meters, ascending costs double, ignores Difficult Terrain, and hovers in place). The recipient is immune to falling damage while the wings remain attached. When the recipient takes a movement action, they may execute their movement by rolling a Success Test using your **Modify** or **Control** Attribute.

FloatWeave Wind [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the end of the turn), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A howling micro-vortex of directed air and swirling nanites lifts you bodily into the air.* Until the end of your turn, you gain **Flight** and can use your **Control** Attribute on all Movement Actions.

LIFEWEAVE

LifeWeave programs microscopic bio-medical assembler nodes capable of cellular reconstruction, accelerated tissue granulation, and synthetic neural bridging.

LifeWeave Elixir [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Nanites suspend themselves in a concentrated metabolic nutrient fluid inside a sealed autoinjector.* You synthesize a consumable injector (Load 0). When a creature consumes the elixir as an Action, the user rolls a **Create Success Test** using your Create rating. For every **2 Success Points**, the user heals **1 Light Wound or 1 Light Stress**.

LifeWeave Heal [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *Active medical micro-swarms flood an open wound to cauterize vessels and knit torn flesh.* You inject medical nanites directly into an injured creature occupying your space. Roll a **Modify Success Test**. For every **3 Success Points**, you heal **2 Light Wounds** on the target.

LifeWeave Enhancement [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Effect:** *Subdermal nanite filaments weave through muscle fibers and neural pathways to augment physical and mental performance.* Any creature affected by your other LifeWeave abilities can substitute your **Control** Attribute in place of any Core Attribute on their tests until the end of the round.

MIRAGEWEAVE

MirageWeave commands nanites to align their surfaces into microscopic refractive lenses, sound-absorbing baffles, and adaptive pigments that bend light, alter physical appearances, and deaden acoustic signatures.

MirageWeave Infusion [Passive]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Effect:** *Adaptive photonic metamaterials and micro-pigments reshape the surface of your fabrications.* You can alter the visual texture, markings, and finish of any item you create to make it appear authentic, legitimate, or disguised. You may use your **Create** Attribute on any tests made while utilizing the fabricated item. Furthermore, whenever you roll to Create an object, you may sacrifice **Hits** from your Action Roll to establish a **Sustained Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) that opposes any attempts by hostile creatures to visually spot, detect, or identify the item.

MirageWeave Coating [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** *A shimmering, light-refracting film crawls across skin, armor, and gear to reshape silhouettes or mimic identities.* You coat a creature or object in your space. You can cosmetically alter the target's physical appearance, colors, uniforms, insignia, or facial features to disguise them. You can also roll **Modify** on tests relying on the coated creature or object to remain unseen or relying on other creatures to believe your disguise is authentic. Additionally, you may roll an Action Roll using **Modify**; for every **2 Hits** sacrificed, you establish a **Sustained Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) opposing all attempts to perceive, detect, or target the coated subject from outside its space.

MirageWeave Veil [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve (recharges at the start of the next round), 1 AP
- **Effect:** *An obscuring aerosol cloud of blackout nanites and optical chaff billows outward to shield your cell.* You disperse a mobile veil of refractive nanites that moves with you and covers your current space, shielding everyone within it. Roll an Action Roll using **Control**. For every **2 Hits** sacrificed, you establish a **Blocker Effect** (1 Blocker die per 2 Hits sacrificed) against incoming ranged attacks and visual detection from outside the space. This veil lasts until the beginning of the next Player Turn, but instantly breaks and dissipates if any creature makes an attack from within the veil.

CYBERWEAVE

CyberWeave configures nanites into conductive micro-circuitry, logic gates, and sensor diodes capable of infiltrating and dominating electronic systems.

CyberWeave Drone [Action]

- **Attribute:** Create
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You assemble a palm-sized hexapod crawler drone in your space. Roll a **Create Success Test**. For every **2 Success Points**, allocate a +1 bonus between its **Interfacing** or **Sensors** ratings. The drone moves up to 20 meters per round and can slice terminals or transmit telemetry. It disassembles if damaged or moving beyond 40 meters.

CyberWeave Virus [Action]

- **Attribute:** Modify
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You infect an electronic terminal, locked blast door, or sensor node in your space. Rolling **Modify**, you force the device to execute a standard function, display a false error, or short-circuit its primary bus. You can re-trigger this effect remotely within 40 meters.

CyberWeave Swarm [Action]

- **Attribute:** Control
- **Cost:** 1 Reserve, 1 AP
- **Effect:** You deploy an atmospheric sensor cloud (4-meter radius within 20 meters). Roll a **Control Success Test**: every 2 Success Points grants **+1 Upgrade** to all allied ranged attacks made against targets within the cloud. The swarm can be repositioned as an Action for 0 Reserve.

CLASS MODS

Weaver Class Mods cost **25,000 Credits** each (socketed at Levels 3 and 5, max 2 active):

- **Extra Reserve:** Gain **+1 Reserve** (increasing baseline reservoir capacity from 4 to 5).
- **Reborn Weave:** When rolling a Success Roll on Weaver tests, disassemble an active Creation/Modification enhanced with Hits to score those Hits and **8 Success Points** automatically.
- **Revitalizing Weave:** When recycling a Creation/Modification, also regain a spent Reserve that would have recharged at the end of the turn.
- **Woven Bond:** Gain **+1 Upgrade** on any test made while using equipment or weapons you have Created or Modified.
- **Weave Infusion:** Spend **1 additional Reserve** on a Weave test to add **+3 Success Points** or score an additional **Hit**.

PROGRESSION

At character creation, distribute **7 Points** among Create, Control, and Modify (base 1 / 1 / 1, max 5). You begin with **1 Weave**.

WEAVER CHASSIS PROGRESSION (LEVELS 1-5)

LEVEL	BENEFITS UNLOCKED	CREDIT COST
Level 1	Base Chassis, 7 Attribute Points (base 1/1/1), Starting Weave, 4 Reserve	**100,000 Credits***
Level 2	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**20,000 Credits**
Level 3	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 1), +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**40,000 Credits**
Level 4	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Weave (3 Abilities)	**75,000 Credits**
Level 5	+1 Attribute Point, +1 Class Mod Slot (Slot 2)	**150,000 Credits**

**The 100,000 Credit cost for Level 1 applies only when purchasing an additional class chassis after character creation; an operative's starting class chassis is free.*

TACTICAL WEAVER ARCHETYPES

- **The Armament Smith:** Invests in *Create* paired with BoltWeave and HardWeave. Forges customized sniper rifles and ballistic barriers on demand, arming the entire cell from a single reservoir.
- **The Kinetic Striker:** Balances *Control* with SliceWeave and FloatWeave. Slices through armored enemy bulkheads with sweeping monomolecular ribbons, hovering weightlessly across the battlefield.
- **The Infiltration Specialist:** Synergizes *Modify* and *Control* with MirageWeave and CyberWeave. Coats allies in chameleon films, overrides security terminals with viral tendrils, and deploys crawler drones for remote reconnaissance.
- **The Cellular Medic:** Dedicated to LifeWeave, synthesizing restorative nutrient elixirs and deploying medical micro-swarms to knit torn tissue and restart vital organs mid-firefight.